# NIGERIA: AN ETHNO-HISTORICAL SURVEY

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## Introduction

Nigeria is acknowledged as the most populous country in Africa.' Although the country is yet to produce archaeological evidence of the earliest forms of human beings like those found in the eastern and southern parts of the African continent,[2] evidence of the antiquity of human habitation in the Nigerian area exists nonetheless. The earliest demographic evidence" comes from the artifacts excavated in the village of Nok (Plateau State) which have been radiocarbon dated to c.39,000 B.C.[3] Some other excavated sites show indications of human existence during the Late Stone Age (i.e.. 15,000 B.C.- 500 B.C.) Notable among these are the Mejiro cave (Oyo State) and rock shelters at Rop (Plateau State). Daima (Borno State) and Iwo Eleru (Ondo State.[4] Indeed from Iwo Eleru have come the remains of a human skeleton, the significance of which lies in the fact that it is. in the words of Frank Willet, the earliest Homo Sapiens yet excavated in \'est Africa'.[5]

Little is known of the nature, language, culture and racial composition of the Nigerian population in pre-historical times. However, it seems safe to conclude from available linguistic evidence that a great number of the country's ethnic groups had evolved by 500 A.D. Indeed, documentary evidence, when they began to appear, suggest that many groups may have occupied their present locations well before 1500, Thus by that dare the Hausa and the Kanuri, for example, already had an established tradition of commercial and political relations with the societies across the Sahara.[7] In the southern part of the country the earliest European visitors, arriving from the late fifteenth century, were in contact with the Ijebu (Yoruba), Benin, (Edo), Itsekiri, Urhobo and Ijo in their present locations.[8]

Nigeria contains a very large number of ethnic groups.[9] All that time and space will permit here is a consideration of some of the more sizeable or dominant ones. Generally, two themes, as may be found relevant for each group, will be discussed; namely, the history, and the political structure of the groups in the period before 1800. For the purpose of the survey, the country will be divided into four zones; the Northern Zone,[10] the Central Zone,[11] the Western Zone,[12] and the Eastern Zone.[13]

## The Northern Zone

The predominant ethic groups in this area are the Kanuri, Hausa and Fulani. The Kanuri, unlike the other two. were governed within a single state. The state established by the Kanuri is usually referred to as Kanem-Borno, and it is so called because at different times in its history, the state covered the eastern and western sections of the Lake Chad basin known respectively as Kanem and Borno. Established about the ninth century. Kanem-Borno was one of the earliest kingdoms which developed in the Nigerian area. The kingdom, according to tradition, is said to have been founded by a legendary figure called Saif. It is from the name of this dynastic ancestor that, the term Saifawa was used for the members of the Kanuri ruling family. The Kanuri king was addressed as Mai.[14] One significant aspect of the history of the Kanuri State is the fact that it was first region to record Islamic presence in the Nigeria area.[15] Some of the early Muslim rulers of the state were reputed for their zeal in the propagation of the faith. For example, Mai Dunama, a late eleventh century ruler, is reported to have launched a jihad during his reign. He performed the hajj twice, and drowned in the Red Sea on his way to a third.

The sixteenth century marked the apogee of the Kanuri state under Mai Idris Aioma. He died in. c. 1603 as the most documented and the most renowned of ail the kings of Kanem-Borno. For, more than any other in the Saifawa dynastic, he curtailed the centrifugal forces in the state and established an administration that guaranteed the general welfare of the state. Owing largely to the effective neutralization of the enemies of the Kanuri by Idris Aloma, his successors were by and large able to Keep the state intact. It was not until the first half of the nineteen century that the Saifawa were confronted with formidable

foes who were to bring to an end their over a thousand year rule as rulers of the Kanuri.

Westwards of the Kanuri live the Hausa, who in the period before 1800 established a number of states. These states, according to local traditions, were founded by the descendants of one Bayajidda, who is said to have fled from Baghdad his homeland, to kanem-Borno and then to Daura in Hausaland.[16] He killed a snake at Daura which had often deprived the inhabitants of the use of the town well. The Queen of Daura married Bayajidda in gratitude for his valiant effort. The union produced a son called Bawo whose six son of established the states of Daura. Katsina. Kano, Rano, Zazzua and Gobir. A seventh state was Biram which was established by another son of Bayajidda through an earlier marriage to the daughter of the Mai of Kanem-Borno. These states became known as the Uausa Bakwai (7) as distinct from another set of seven states, the Hausa Banza (bastard), said to have been established by BayajjIda's children through concubines. The Hausa Banza were: __ Zamfara, kebbi. Gwari, Yauri, Nupe, Jukun and Yoruba (i.e. the Qyo Kingdom).[17]

Scholars of Hausa history are generally agreed that the Bayajidda story or legend is not to be taken at its face value; nut opinions differ on its interpretation.[18] Most recently, Murray Last has, through the combination o anthropological, linguistic and documentary evidence, plausibly argue that the incorporation of Hausaland into the transh-Saharan trade network between c.1100-1400 stimulated a complex series of inter-group fusions which gave rise to centralized polities[19]. This phenomenon of fusion, he concludes, is represented by the notion of marriage in the Bayajidda story, namely, 'that kingdoms are founded on alliances'.[20] The seven Hausa Banza are probably to be interpreted as constituting a mirror image of the Hausa Bakwai, thus, reflecting the influence of large neighbouring societies on the course of Hausa history.[21]

One dominant theme in Hausa history in the period before 1800 was the recurrent issues of warfare among the various state.[22] This was because each state was eager to secure greater involvement in the trans-Sharan trade, and as no state succeeded in establishing a permanent military supremacy over Hausaland, political dominance when achieved was ephemeral. For the greater part of the sixteenth century, for instance, the leading Hausa state was Kebbi, and it succeeded in reducing Gobir and Zazzau to tributary status. But its dominance lapsed from the end, of the sixteenth century, as Zamfara took over. While it was the leading Hausa State, Zamfara inflicted military defeats on Katsina ana Kano, thereby controlling the trans-Saharau trade in Hausaland. But, like Kebbi before her: Zainlara's pre-eminence was transient. Gobir rose to prominence at the beginning of the eighteenth century and in 1762 inflicted a crushing defeat on Zamfara to become the most powerful Hausa State. The power of Gobir was cut short during the opening decade of the nineteenth century when the Fulani carried out a successful Jihad in Hausaland.

Fulani communities spread across the entire West African savanna region. In Nigeria, the Fulani are generally scattered-over the areas classified in this chapter as the Northern, and Central Zones. There are, however, large concentrations in Sokofo, Bauchi. Gombe and Adamawa States, The original homeland of the Fulani[23] is the Senegal River valley area where I they were derived from miscegenation between the local inhabitants and Berber immigrants - the one agricultural and Negronid, the- other pastoral and Caucasoid.

Those of the Fulani who inherited the pastoral and nomadic legacy of their forebears began to migrate out the River Senegal valley region from about the twelfth century. By the seventeenth century, scores of Fulani clans were already established throughout the West African savanna region, and these had also come to include many non-pastoral Fulani, who unlike then nomadic kinsmen took up permanent residence in then adopted areas. The sedentary Fulani (referred to in the literature as Town Fulani) was usually muslim, while his nomadic kinsmen (the Cattle Fulani) animist. A considerable number of the Fulani Muslims, on account of their great Islamic learning, served as tutors, advisers and administrators in several West African savanna states. It was in suchlike capacity, for example, that Uthman dan Fodio

was employed in the court of the king of Gobir on the eve of his jihad at the beginning of the nineteenth century.

It is significant to note that the word Fulani is a Hausa designation. The people refer to themselves as Fulo in the singular and Fulbe in the plural, while the term Fulfulde or is used to refer to their language. Other terms by which the Fulani are referred in the literature are Fellata, Foulah, Ful. Peul and Pulio.

The Central Zone

This area contains, probably, the largest concentration of ethnic groups in Nigeria. Some of the prominent groups here include, the Borgu, Nupe, Igala, Jukun, Idoma, Ebirra. Tiv. and a section of the Yoruha.[24] Except perhaps for the Borgu, Nupe, Igala "and the Yoruba o(' the present Florin emirate area,[25] most of the peoples of this zone lived in the period before 1800 in small non-centralised communities. Little is known of their earliest history; and their respective traditions of origin, where they are still preserved, speak of migrations into their present locations from outside. Claims of an immigrant Sounder dynast are also common in the traditions concerning the establishment of the kingdoms. Again, as in the preceding section, three groups will be examined here - the Nupe, Igala and Jukun.

The Nupe were governed under a single state system. "According to the traditions, the Nupe kingdom was founded by Tsoede (known also as Edegi) who was the son of an Igala king and a Nupe woman. After the death of his father, he is said to have fled upstream from Idah on the Niger with the essential paraphernalia of office, lie arrived in Nupeland, defeated the small chiefdoms in which the Nupe were organized, and established a central administration over them. The term Etsu became the royal title.

The precise date of the establishment of the Nupe kingdom is still a subject of speculation, but the state was certainly established by the end of the sixteenth century. One other issue of note concerning the Nupe kingdom was the fact that the centre or capital of the state continually shifted in response to historical developments. Tsoede established his capital at Nupako. but there were later capitals at Gbara and Jima.

The second half of the eighteenth century was marked by succession problems. In 1762 Etsu Jibrilu was driven away from the throne on religious considerations: he had aroused strong anti-Islamic forces against his rule. His successor, Muazu, suffered a similar fate of deposition after an eight-year period in office. Muazu was to fight his way back to the throne after about two decades in exile; but matters became so grave after his death in 1795, that by 1800. The kingdom had been split into two as a result of dynastic wranglings. One part was centred in Jima, while the other was at Raba. The two forces subsequently clashed, and as events turned out, it was the Fulani jihadists invited into the struggle that emerged as the new rulers of the kingdom.

Like the Nupe traditions, Igala traditions attribute the establishment of the Igala kingdom to an outsider. There are various versions regarding the origin and identity of the first Atta, the title of the Igala king.[27] The names that feature are Abutu Eje, Agenapoje, Ebelejomu and Idoko, while Yoruba, Benin and Jukun antecedents are given for the first Atta. What seems certain, however, is that the first Atta conquered various cheifdoms in the vicinity of Idah, established his rule over them and so laid the foundations of the Igala kingdom which subsequently extended to cover all Igala speaking grouns.[28]

The little that is known concerning the history of the Igala state before 1800 indicates that the kingdom exerted considerable political and cultural influence among its neighbour such as Idoma and Kakanda in the Niger-Benue confluence region, as well as the Igbo on the River Niger and those of the Nsukka area.

The Jukun were another group whose activities were felt beyond their borders, Jukun history before 1800

can be divided into two phases. The first phase concerns the period they inhabited the upper Benue region, while the second phase starts from the mid eighteenth century when they were forced to migrate to their present location in the lower Benue. Little has to come to light of Jukun political history during the earlier phase. The Jukun appear only in such external sources as the Kano Chronicle where they are referred to as the Kwararafa. What has therefore come down as Jukun history before the eighteenth century deals with their external relations with other peoples, especially the Hausa states and Kanem-Borno.

Jukun territory appear to have been subjected to raids by some of the Hausa states, notably Kano in the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries. But the situation was reversed from about the end of the sixteen century when the Jukun then began a carrier of distance in the northeast.[29] The momentum of jukun military force was, however, soon spent. For reasons which have continued to elude scholars, Jukun military power declined from the end of the seventeenth century, so much so that external pressure by such neighbouring groups as the Bata and Chamba caused them to migrate southwards to the lower Benue region by the mid eighteenth century.

In their new location, the Jukun established a number of chiefdoms which formed a confederacy under the ruler or Aku of Wukari. From her too, the Jukun subsequently exercised a considerable amount if cultural influence on several communities and ethnic groups in the Niger-Benue confluence region.

The Western Zone

The Yoruba are the largest ethnic group in this area. Divided into a number of dialect sub-groups – Oyo, Ijebu, Ijesa, Ekiti, Egba, Ondo, etc – they originally had no common or general name for themselves, each section regarding itself as a distinct nationality. The term 'Yoruba' was the Hausa designation for the Oyo dialect speakers only, and it was only from the nineteenth century that it came to extended to the other groups by Christian missionaries.[30]

The various Yoruba-speaking groups, however, share a common tradition of origin from Ile-Ife. Although there are versions of the tradition, Oduduwa is generally regarded as the progenitor of the Yoruba race. A popular version of this belief is the one recorded during the second half of the nineteenth century by the Revd. Samuel Johnson in his book The History of the Yoruba.[31] Accordingly to this version Oduduwa was the son of Lamurudu, the kind of Mecca. He relapsed from the Islamic faith into paganism, and in the crisis which this action subsequently provoked, Lamuurudu was killed and Oduduwa ejected from the state. Leaving Mecca with his body supporters, Oduduwa moved westwards, and at the end of a ninety-day sojourn arrived at Ile-Ife where he chose to settle. Seven of his grandsons subsequently led migrations out of Ile-Ife to begin the population of the Yoruba country. One of them, Oranmiyan (usually abbreviated Oranyan), founded the Oyo kingdom.

It has, however, been argued that this story of Middle Eastern origins is a re-modified version of Muhammed Bello's account that the ancestors of the 'Yoruba' (i.e. Oyo) were a negriod race ejected from the Middle East.[32]

A number of kingdoms developed among the Yoruba. The notable ones include Ife, Oyo, Ijebu, Owo, Ondo, Owu and those of the Ekiti area.[33] Oyo was the largest and most powerful of all the kingdoms. The Oyo king was titled Alafin. The kingdom reached the zenith of its power under the reign of Alafin Abiodun (c.1774 – c. 1789). His successor, Awole (c. 1789 0 c.1796) was confronted with a rebellion by some of the provincial rulers of the Kingdom, notably Afonja of Ilorin. The crisis eventually led to the collapsed of the state.

To the East of the Yoruba are the Edo. Unlike the Yoruba, the Edo developed a single kingdom, the Benin kingdom. The foundation of the Benin kingdom is attributed in local traditions to Oranrniyan (the same one in Oyo traditions). According to the Bini story, an appeal was made by a hereditary order of chiefs, the Uzama, to Oduduwa of lle-lfe to send one of his sons to govern their territory. Oranrniyan was consequently

dispatched; but he found the Bini a difficult people to govern. The name Bini is, in fact, said to have been derived from the phrase. He Ibinu (the land of vexation) by which, in exasperation, he described the territory he had come to rule- Oranrniyan in the end came to the conclusion that only a prince of Bini blood could govern the people. Consequently, he married the daughter of a Mini chief, who gave birth to a son called Eweka from whom the present line of the kings of Benin is traced.[34]

One school of thought is that, this story, even if it is not to be literally interpreted, suggests Yoruba antecedents for the Eweka dynasty.[35] Another school holds that the Oranmiyan-Eweka story is a reflection of a 'culture capture', namely, an endeavour to associate the Bini monarchy with its prestigious Ife counterpart reputed also for its antiquity.[36] Whatever may have been the circumstances surrounding the origins of the Bini monarchy, however, available archaeological evidence does seem to support the traditional one that the Benin kingdom was established sometime during the thirteenth century.[37]

The Benin kingdom attained the peak of its power during the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries. Specifically this was achieved under the reigns of Ewuare (c.1440 - c. 147.1), Ozolua (c.1481 -.c.l504), Esigie (c.1504 - c.1556), Orogbua (c.1556 - c.1578) and Ehengbuda (c.l504 - c.l608). These were kings who maintained a practice of leading their armies to war in person. During the period covered by their reigns, Bini political and cultural influence was felt in almost every part of present-day Edo and Delta States. The same applied to some of the Yoruba-speaking groups in Ondo and Ekiti states, and as far as the island of Lagos.

The political fortunes of Benin began to dwindle from the seventeenth century. The practice of the king having to lead his army in person which was initiated by Ewuare had to be discontinued when Ehengbuda lost his life on his return journey from a campaign. In the words of A.F.C. Ryder, the king thereafter. 'became a semi-divine ruler occupied in an endless round of ritual, emerging from his palace only once or twice a year on ceremonial occasions, and never going beyond the city wall.[38] The martial traditions of the kingdom progressively waned; and by the end of the eighteenth century its claims of suzerainty over its dependencies had largely become nominal.

To the South of the Edo are the Itsekiri who were also administered under a state system. In fact, Bini and ltsekiri traditions attribute the foundation of Itsekiri kingdom to Iginua, a son of Oba of Benin who reigned in the fifteenth century.[39] The Urhobo, Ishan, Ivbiosakon, (Owan), Etsako, and Isoko are now usually linguistically .classified as Edo-speaking groups. Unlike the 'Edo proper,' however, these were non-centralised societies; political administration being strictly functional at the town or village level.

The Eastern Zone

The prominent groups in this area include the Igbo. Ijo Ibibio and Efik. The area is, in general, characterized by non-centralized societies, with the Ijo being probably a minor exception.

The Ijo occupy the Niger Delta area in a belt stretching from Ondo State to Bayesa and River States. Those of them in the Eastern Delta section developed small states, the more prominent ones bciii!' Ibani (Bonny) Elem Kalahari (New Calabar). Nembe (Brass) and Okirika. The development of the stales occurred from about the sixteenth century in response to the Atlantic trade.

Before the arrival of the Europeans the typical Ijo settlement in Eastern Delta was a small village containing only a few hundred inhabitants."[1] Each village was divided into wards (polo) which was in turn sub-divided into households (Wari). The main political authority in the village was the assembly of all adult males which was presided over by the Amanyanabo who owed his office to the fact that he was the head of the lineage which discovered or founded the village site. The Amanyanabo's functions were, however, essentially ritual. With the advent of Atlantic trade, villages or communities which succeeded in gaining greater control of the commerce with the Europeans became nuclei of new states, and the Amanyanabo metamorphosed into a political official.

The Efik became the main distributors or the Atlantic trade on the Cross River just as the Ijo did in the Eastern Delta. The four major Efik settlements of Ohio Oko (Creek Town), Atakpa (Duke Town), Obutong (Old Town), and Nsidung (Henshaw Town) came to be collectively called Calabar. Although the various Efik communities had their titular heads, styled the Obong, effective authority was exercised through membership in political societies, the most important of which was the Ekpe. The Obong was therefore a member of the highest grades of the society.

The most prominent neighbours of the Efik are the Igbo, one of the three largest ethnic groups in the country. Like most Nigerian societies little is known for certain of the evolution of Igbo society; and there have been claims of a Jewish origin for them, the term Igbo being said to be a corruption of Hebrew.[41] Linguistic evidence indicates, however, that the Igbo language together with such genetically related languages as the Yoruba. Idoma. Igaia, evolved in the Niger-Benue confluence area 6.000 years ago. in other words. The origins of the Igbo are ultimately to be derived from the Niger-Benue confluence region.

No centralised polities developed among the Igbo; each settlement or village was an autonomous political unit. The major organ of government was the council of ciders called Amala. In exceptional cases, however, young men of proven ability could be allowed into the council. The Amala was usually presided over by the head of the most senior lineage in the village.

Although the Igbo were administered in separate and minuscule entities, there were several integrating mechanisms which bound the disparate communities. The most prominent in this regard was the oracle among the Aro called Ibinu Ukpabi generally referred to as the Arochukwu oracle. Judicial suits were referred to the oracle from far and wide, as it was generally believed that its verdicts were impartial. Indeed, the economic and political influence enjoyed by the Aro over Igboland during the pre-colonial period owed largely to their control of the oracle. It was this pre-eminence which at the beginning of colonial rule led the British to the erroneous impression that Igboland was under the political domination of the Aro. Hence one of the earliest measures taken by the colonial authorities was the destruction of the Arochukwu shrine.

**Conclusion**

The ethnic groups that have been considered in this chapter represent, as earlier mentioned, only a small fraction of the country's total number. A comprehensive list of the groups and their principal locations has been provided in the Appendix below. It needs to be stressed that even though the focus here has been on the individual experiences and character of the respective groups, there were variegated commercial and political contacts, with consequent social and cultural effects, among and between various groups.[43] Indeed, three events were to occur in the nineteenth century which were to precipitate wide-ranging inter-group response. These were the Fulani Jihad of Uthman dan Fodio, the fall of the Oyo Empire, and the advent of British. The detail of these events are discussed in subsequent chapter.

Appendix: Name and Location of Nigerian Ethnic Groups

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Notes and References

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# 3 THE PT OF COLONIALISM AND THE NIGERIAN EXPERIENCE (1900 – 1960)

**O. M. EHINMORE**

## Introduction

This chapter discusses the concept of colonialism, the Nigerian experience from 1900 to 1960. It attempts a discussion of the factors that motivated the subjugation of Nigerian communities by the British colonial administration, the development of nationalism and the various means adopted by Nigerian leaders to achieve independence. **Colonialism:** This is the belief in and support for the system of one country controlling another'. Imperialism is often used as an instrument to achieve colonialism. The two terms - colonialism and imperialism refer to a country's efforts to have overwhelming power and influence over other countries in political, social and economic affairs. Imperialism is a gradual and tactical process of colonization. As a prelude to colonization, the colonizer spreads her political and economic tentacles over the weaker country in order to suppress and render it politically and economically impotent and submissive. This may involve signing of ambiguous and insidious treaties. This stage in colonization is imperialism. When a country is colonized, it means the stronger country has gained political, social and economic domination, control and effective occupation of that country. The term, colonialism often arouses strong emotions. It is like a master-servant relationship. Colonialism as a system came into being as a result of a number of people in Western Europe holding certain ideas in matters of religion, social policy, politics and economics who came into contact with Africans holding different ideas and living under different socio-economic and political system[2],

In order to clearly understand colonialism, it is germane to study the prevailing ideas in Europe and adequately understand the circumstances which brought Europeans and Africans into contact, especially in the 19th century. Although, all the countries in West Africa emerged from the colonial period within a few years of each other, they were colonized at different periods.[3] The Europeans in the 19th century had uncontrollable quest for expansion beyond their continent in order to explore, exploit and subjugate other countries of the world and to project the ideologies, technologies and institutions of "modernity". Why Africa became their tempting prize was obvious. Three major reasons were advanced by Jules Ferry in 1885 for these aggressive European expansionist tendencies. These were: to have access to the raw materials of the colonized countries, to create market for the sales of manufactured goods of their home countries and to carve out fields for the investment of surplus capital.

Whichever ways one views this outward movement of the Europeans towards the African continent, it is incontrovertible that both Britain and France had similar colonial objectives -economic, social and political domination. Moreover, industrial revolution in Europe remains undebatable as a unifying factor that precipitated colonization of Africa. In the light of this analysis, colonialism can be described as the policy by which an imperialist (colonizer) ties her .colonies to herself by political bind with the primary objective of promoting her own economic interest and advantages[4].

## The Colonization of Nigeria

Though, Nigeria's contact with the Europeans pre-dated 1900, this period is very significant in Nigerian history because, it was the actual time which the British completely and effectively occupied the country. It should not be forgotten that, Lagos was conquered and eventually subdued by the British government in 1851 and this marked the

beginning of the British colonial rule in Nigeria. The pattern of the colonial contact with Nigeria was similar to other West African States such as Gambia, Ghana and Sierra-Leone. Though, the British colonial race for Nigeria took place in the 19th century, it is treated in this circumstance as a pedestal to clearly understand the major events of the 20th century. The British penetrated Nigeria in four major forms -as explorers, as missionaries, as traders and as diplomatic military invaders before they finally settled as capitalist overlords. Initially, the relationship between the British and Nigerians was characterised by confusion and suspicion as differences in colour and culture created doubt, distrust and contempt[4]. This disdainful phenomenon could be seen as a deliberate way of playing down on each other's cultural pride and legitimate existence in order to assert socio-cultural superiority. One plausible reason for this misunderstanding could be seen from the standpoint of cultural differences and abysmal ignorance about each other's cultural setting and values. However, most of these misconceptions have been settled through the study of modem history. By the end of the 19th century, the various Nigerian communities were made to understand and agree that the wearer of the while skin whom they first pitied and treated with little regard was a 'semi-divine God' who was fully armed to be their ruler. The white man did not at a tune disclose his main motive, he only presented himself as a partner. He made the people believe that he would respect the existing native authority and the culture of the land[5]. Like the crafty fox, he finally became the arrogant and oppressive overlord using various fraudulent means to convert the Nigerians to unwilling subjects and inferior citizens of the British empire[6].

**Factors that Influenced Colonization of Nigeria**

Many factors were responsible for the colonization of Nigeria by the British. Though, some of these factors had been mentioned earlier and had been discussed by various authors, British colonization of Nigeria forms an interesting theme in African history hence it deserves a thorough re-appraisal.

Industrial revolution in Europe played a key role in the European colonization of Africa in general and British colonization of Nigeria in particular. As a result of the change from the use of manual labour to the introduction of machines, there was drastic increase in the production of goods, which therefore required wider market for adequate distribution of these surplus products. There was also the growing need for tropical African agricultural products by the - Europeans as a result of the abolition of the slave trade. "The replacement of the slave trade with palm oil trade brought the British steadily into the political life of the coastal kingdoms and led finally to conquest and partition"[7]. In addition to the high demand for palm oil, crops such as cocoa, groundnuts and rubber were in steady demand. It was the sturdy quest for steady market for their surplus products and to control the natural agricultural products of Nigeria that stimulated the colonization. The phenomenon described above gives adequate room for a logical conclusion that if the British had not found an alternative trade, they would not have supported the abolition of the slave trade.

The previous experience, exploits and the reports of the early explorers on African natural potentials and endowment no doubt provoked to a large extent the search for colonies in the colonies. It was this positive economic report that exposed Nigeria to the whole world as a land "flowing with milk and honey". This eventually made her become the focus of the British economic interest.

The breach of the balance of power principle in-Europe was another factor accountable for the British colonization of Nigeria. Immediately after the defeat of Napoleon Bonaparte in 1815 at the battle of Waterloo, all European powers met at the Congress of Vienna and agreed on a term of equal political strength that was in the spirit of equality in the possession of political and economic power in relation to acquisition of territories. Eventually, Belgium, under king Leopold acquired a territory in Congo River on the ostensible guise of promoting a knowledge of African interior. This alarmed other European powers and their imperial motives in Africa became stimulated.

With this development, the gun for the colonial race was shot and at the same time no nation wanted a global war to attend the territorial struggle, because, the previous wars had taught them lessons. To avert war therefore, it was decided by the European powers to share African territories peacefully among themselves. This gave birth to

the Berlin 'African' conference of 1884 - 85 headed by Otto Von Bismarck of Germany. The crisis over the Congo river had been described as the immediate factor that brought about the partition of Africa. Unfortunately, Africa was not represented in the sharing of her territories. In the sharing arrangement, Nigeria became British territory.

It is however difficult to accept with high degree of conviction that it was at the Berlin conference that Africa was partitioned. Whichever ways one views it, colonization of Nigeria by Britain was motivated by both economic and political factors - industrialism and imperialism.

**Strategies of Colonization**

The British adopted various tactics in the penetration and eventual colonization of Nigeria. In the first place, the geographical terrain of the country favoured and facilitated this well-intentioned influx. The available waterways, sea, rivers. Lagoons and creeks were made use of by the British. With these natural means of transport, direct bombardment was relatively easy. In the process of acquisition and occupation of territories, the British applied arms and ammunition to attack areas of resistance. Lagos instance was attacked in 1851 and annexed in 1861. Benin was conquered and put under British control in 1897.

Moreover, the British made the Nigerian rulers accept deceptive treaties loaded with false and vague promises hence they were able to penetrate the territories with relative ease. As part of their usual divide-and-rule formula, they created confusion and conflicts among some Nigerian traditional rulers in order to subdue and relegate them. Such was the nature of the British intervention in Lagos political rift by expelling Kosoko and installing Akitoye who became their loyalist.[8]

As a matter of fact, the colonizers employed the services of the missionaries as effective agents of colonization. On the other hand, the missionaries solicited the support of the British to have grip of their areas of interest. It was partly to *find* a direct trade route from Abeokuta to the coast that missionaries joined traders in urging the British government to intervene in Lagos politics in 1861[9.] It sounds very incredible that some missionaries supplied ammunition to their supporters in Badagry and they also fought in favour of the Egba in their war against Dahomey, March, 1851.

While this complementary effort of the British and missionaries could be said to have accelerated colonization of Nigeria, it has also partly proved that the coming of the missionaries to Nigeria was extra-evangelical. The British fraudulently presented themselves to Nigerian rulers in order to weaken their sense of resentment and suspicion of enslavement. They appeared as explorers, partners in trade philanthropists and finally tactically entrenched themselves as the capitalist overlords after gaining effective occupation. Trade politics was obviously an effective device .used by the British to colonize Nigeria. As traders they pretended to be business partners whose commercial aspirations were to be complementary to those of Nigerians.[11] But finally the British turned round to be dictators of the commercial fortunes of the land. The Benin expedition of 1897 had much to do with the British ambition to have effective control of the trade of the kingdom. The intervention in the 19th century Yoruba civil wars by the British must have been for economic interest and domination. Even if the Nigerians were aware of the intending trickish and exploitative overlordship of the British, what would they have done in the presence of their sophisticated war equipment and their Wood-thirsty trained soldiers.

**Conquest and Resistance**

British conquest and establishment of colonial rule in Nigeria was however not without some level of resistance. Whether this resistance was feeble or tough depends on individual's evaluation and perception. With the attack on Lagos in 1851, no one needed be told that the battle of colonial rule in Nigeria had been won. Resistance movements against colonial rule in Nigeria and Africa in general took about three dimensions. These were passive, active and collaborationist movements. Opposition to the imposition of colonial rule took different shapes in different places. While in some parts of the country, there were lackadaisical resistant movements collaboration with the colonialists, and other were resolute and volatile in their defensive and

nationalistic struggle.

The early rulers that fought relentlessly against colonization were cited traditional nationalists. Some of them were indigenous rulers while others were products of missionary schools. For instance, Nana of Itsekiri gave a notable fight to the British at Ebrohimi in 1894 before he was arrested and deported to Ghana. Jaja of Opobo was also arrested after a prolonged resistance and was deported to Accra in 1887[12]. Oba Ovonramwen of Benin strongly protected his kingdom from the British expedition of 1897 but he could not stand the test of the superior belligerence of the British military squad. He was therefore exiled to Calabar. Oba Mafimisebi I of Ugbo was deported to Calaba in 1921 as a result of his stiff refusal to be a puppet to the British government. These traditional rulers and many others gave virile opposition to foreign rule, at the end of the struggle, they lost the battle and this gave way to British imperial encroachment in the territories.

The need therefore arises to find some logical explanations for this defeat and eventual subjugation. Why the British had relative ease in the conquest, acquisition and occupation of the Nigerian territories was not shrouded n magical or spiritual mysteries. The fact that the British were armed with modern and sophisticated weapons and war tacticians proved that there was no occurrence of miracle in their victory. On the other hand, the Nigerian rulers had at their disposal, local weapons such as, arrow, spear and the local maxim-gun (Kurufu, which was used by Nana during the Ebrohimi British expedition of 1894).

Equally important too was the fact that Nigerian leaders were not fully united as formidable blocs in their various sub-political units. Most of them did not fight with the kind of zeal that could sufficiently check external aggressions. The Satiru revolt of 1905, led by Isa in Sokoto was decisive against the British government. Samori Toure gave the French one of the toughest resistance as a result of the possession of a large number of ammunition and with determination and relative unity in the Mandinka Empire. He was deported to Gabon in 1898[13]. It could be deduced therefore that, if the Nigerians were well prepared and fully united, they would have given their aggressors tougher fight and resistance.

Moreover, the British also made use of superior diplomacy. A lot of deceptive and ambiguously signed treaties were used to deceive some traditional rulers hence some of them did not actively and loyally defend their territories. It was this passiveness and attitude of betrayer that paved way for insecurity which partly accounted for perforated and feeble resistance in some parts of Nigeria.

**Colonial System of Administration in Nigeria**

The colonial master that ruled Nigeria in the 20th century was Britain. British colonial administration in Nigeria could best be studied and understood through a detailed re-appraisal of its exploitative political, economic and social structures[14]. Sonic technically draconian measures were inherent in tins paradoxical 'Native authority' system such as the forceful and diplomatic reduction of virile Nigerian Opposition to the imposition of colonial rule.[15] This was to ensure consolidation and cunning expansion of the British central power over her colonized territories. Economic domination through the so called economic theories known as colonial pact and the dual mandate coupled with cultural subjugation through the overwhelming spread and practice of Western cultural values also characterized the British government.

Indirect rule was introduced as a form of government which ruled the people through their traditional rulers. It formed the basis of local government. It did not apply to the central government of the colony being run in accordance with traditional British ideas and practices. The Nigerian chief was the key political instrument of the local government.

He appointed all officials who were responsible to him. The application and execution of local Jaws were within his jurisdiction. He was however responsible to a British official, a Resident or District Officer who inturn was accountable to the central authority. Indirect rule did not directly attack the existing Nigerian culture, this however

did not mean that there was no cultural dislocation. The most criminal of the defects of indirect rule in Nigeria was the exclusion of the educated elite from active political participation. In matters relating to central administration, the colonial government in Nigeria left much to be desired. At this level of government, Nigerians were reluctantly involved in participation. Until the 1950s, the chief policy makers were British officials.

Draconian measures such as press and sedition laws in 1903 and 1909 were imposed. The primary objective of this was to check Nigerian criticism of questionable administrative policies. There was unofficial representation in the legislative council based in Lagos, in the executive council, the situation was same. This was a deliberate policy strategy to restrict Nigerians to minority class when there was the need to vote against official policies. Besides the official majority system, the governor had the veto power and power to initiate all legislations.

However more Nigerians were in the central (later federal) and regional cabinets from 1951 till independence. From 1951, the British government started to grant the requests of Nigerians on the issue of self - government[16]. This gave the impression that the British government with these new concessions allowed not only representative but also responsible government till the period of independence.

**Constitutional Development in Nigeria**

Nigeria underwent various constitutional changes from 1900 to 1960. In L8S6-wheniages-Y«trseparated from the Gold coast and given a separate government of its own. the administration of the territory was now vested in a governor, an executive council and a legislative council.[17] In 1906, Lagos colony was merged with the southern Nigeria protectorate and the legislative council's power was extended to cover the whole Lagos colony and the southern Nigeria protectorate. The council consisted of ten official members. The six unofficial members were; C.A. Sapara Williams, Kiloyi Ajasa, Dr. Obadia Johnson (all Africans) and J. T. Miller, R.U. Little, and A. Matheson.[18]

However, with the amalgamation of northern and southern Nigeria in 1914, there was a reduction in the membership of the legislative council which was still confined to the Lagos colony. A new council, the Nigerian council was created for the rest of the country, which was made up of twenty-four official members and twelve unofficial members. There were six Europeans representing commerce, shipping, banking, mining, chambers of commerce and six Africans consisting of the important chiefs of northern and southern Nigeria-Sultan Attahiru of Sokoto, the Alaafin of Oyo, the Emir of Kano, Chief Dogho Numa and educated Africans from Lagos and Calabar, The officials were the members of executive councils, first class Residents, political secretaries and the secretaries of the northern and southern provinces. These councils were however mere advisory ones. They had no binding legislative powers on the governor.

In 1922, the Clifford constitution was formed and it embodied in it the elective principle. This helped lo stimulate formation of political organizations and also served as a vehicle for expressing grievances and aspirations by the Nigerians.-This new legislative council consisted of 46 members, 27 unofficial and 19 official. The income qualification of £100 per annum as a condition for elective post did not however favour the Nigerians.

In 1944, Sir. Arthur-Richard published a new constitution, which was already started by Sir Bernard Bourdillon before his retirement. According to him, the constitution was designed to promote the unity of Nigeria, to provide adequately for the diverse elements of the country and to secure greater participation by Nigerians in their own affairs. This council was broader both in membership and scope. It was a landmark in the history of constitutional development in Nigeria. For the first time since 1923, Northern and Southern Nigeria were brought together and thus enhanced unity. Nigerians regarded this constitution as an imposition because there was no consultation before the draft which would have made them or the articulate minority register their opinions on the proposals.[19]

As a result of the defects in the Richard constitution, a new constitution was drafted in 19,5I known as the Macpherson constitution. In order to avoid the mistakes of the previous constitutions, there was a wide measure of consultation with the people starting from the-village level. It stimulated political consciousness and thus marked

the effective genesis of the development of modem political parties. The 1951.constitution also provided the people with the necessary training in the art of constitution drafting. For the first time in the Nigerian political history, central legislature (House of Representatives) and regional representation (house of assembly) were created.

The 1951 constitution was however attacked by the nationalist leaders on account of inadequacies. First it was criticized for representation of special interests and indirect system of elections to the legislature. It was also discredited for its failure to provide adequately for the ethnic differences in the country. The constitution failed to satisfy the three criteria by which a federal constitution should be judged. It was therefore "a wretched compromise between federalism and unilateralism".[20] The constitution ushered in an era of ethnic nationalism and regional divisions, thus, it promoted the spirit of ethnicity in Nigerian politics. Owing to the flaws inherent in this constitution and the fact that there was no collective desire on the part of the Nigeria leaders to ensure its continuity coupled with the political crisis of the period, the constitution became moribund. The collapse of the Macpherson constitution led to the drafting of the 1.954 Lyttleton constitution. The 1954 constitution was significant for its provision for revenue allocation based, on the principle of derivation. It also provided the basis of the constitution of independent Nigeria. The relevance of this constitution was aptly summarized by Sir Ahmadu Bello, the sardauna of Sokoto when he said, "Of all the conferences, the 1953/54 was the most decisive; the others stemmed from it and their conclusions were logical development, that is, there were no further structural changes".[21] The 1954 constitution was the last before independence, others were conferences.

The 1957 constitutional conference discussed the issue of minorities that of strong police, issue of fundamental human rights, that of boundary and other related matters. The 1958 conference was meant primarily to examine the recommendations and reports of the commissions of 1957- the constituencies delimitation and fiscal commissions. The most decisive of the issues discussed in the 1958 constitutional conference was perhaps that of Minorities Commission Report. Unfortunately, this problem was not solved before independence.
In order to ensure smooth administration and easy management of the economic resources in Nigeria and to unite the diverse elements, British government adopted the principle of amalgamation. The Lagos colony and protectorate was amalgamated with the protectorate of Southern Nigeria to form the new colony and protectorate of southern Nigerian may, 1906[22]. In 1914, the British government also attempted the amalgamation of northern and southern Nigeria. With the nature of the political tide of that period, amalgamation might be a wise option. On the other hand, the amalgamation had been viewed or suspected as being anything but amalgamation. Its primary aim seemed not to promote cultural or political unity among Nigerians as presented by Lugard but to harness the economic resources of the country and to create administrative convenience for the selfish interest of the British government. This was partly underscored by the fact that Nigerians were not consulted and involved in the amalgamation process to ascertain whether they were comfortable with such: political arrangement or not.

**Introduction of Indirect Rule in Nigeria**
Indirect rule or the native authority system as it was sometimes called had been previously practised in other places such as India before its introduction in Nigeria. In Nigeria, it was first adopted in the north about 1900. The introduction of indirect rule in Nigeria was influenced by a number of factors.

One of these factors was shortage of personnel. As a result of problem of manpower, Lugard could not afford direct administration hence he resorted to using the traditional rulers in his government. Closely related to this was inadequacy of finance. The British government was faced with financial crisis to pay more skilled white officials hence it employed the services of the indigenous rulers which was relatively cheaper.

There was also the language problem. Since language would have caused obstacles in effective communication, Lugard quickly trained some indigenous people to be clerks, store-keepers and interpreters. One of the reasons for establishing early schools in Nigeria was to train these groups of people for administrative ease.

The previous experience of Lugard in the practice of indirect rule also influenced its adoption in Nigeria. It had been introduced in some parts of the world with relative success. Its success in India for instance aroused the

assumption in Lugard of its workability in Nigeria.

The nature of the existing political system in Nigeria favoured the operation of indirect rule. The European on their arrival met a superstructural political arrangement worthy of respect and emulation hence they had no other option than to embrace it. For instance, there was a well organised centralised political structure in the north, in the south, the Yoruba, Bini and Itsekiri settlements were semi-centralised and headed by traditional rulers with distinct cultural pattern and values. From the aforementioned factors, it could be deduced that indirect rule was adopted in Nigeria generally as a result of some irresistible circumstances.

Indirect rule was introduced and practised in three major geographical areas in Nigeria. In the North, East and in the West. In the Caliphate in Northern Nigeria, indirect rule was successful owing to the centralized nature of the Emirate and partly due to the fact that Lugard had intimate knowledge of the Emirate society[23]. The application of indirect rule failed in the East and west because, Lugard was ignorant of the political culture and social structure of the people. He therefore imposed, sometimes unacceptable leaders (warrant chiefs) and taxes on the people without understanding and even willing to study their socio-cultural history. In order to legalise the power they exercised on their fellow countrymen, each of those recorgnised as chiefs by the colonial administration was given a certificate. The certificate was known as a 'warrant' and partly for this reason, the chiefs were called warrant chiefs.[24] It was however a bit successful in the West especially in Yoruba land as a result of the semi-centralized nature of the society. It was an abysmal failure in Igboland owing to the segmentary political structure. It was however the out-break of the Aba women's riots of 1929 which resulted from the imposition of tax on the women that demonstrated a high degree of resentment towards indirect rule in Eastern Nigeria.

**An Appraisal of British Rule**

In assessing the British system of government in Nigeria, it requires careful examination of the level of achievements in relation to political developments, improvement on education, agricultural development, transportation and other social services in the areas of operation. Through the adoption of indirect rule, British government helped to transform the traditional political system into modern politics. Electoral system of government was formally entrenched in African political system. Though it excluded the African educated elite from active political participation, they were still indirectly positively influenced politically. The rise of nationalist movements in the 20th century West Africa drew inspirations from the British oppressive and exploitative policies.

Moreover, the constitutional development especially from 1922, 1946, 1951 to 1954 before the independence constitution of 1960 did not involve Nigerians in adequate political participation. They were mainly composed of the white official majority. To the Nigerian nationalists, all these constitutions were pro-British. Though, pro-British; these constitutions still served as training and inspiring institutions for the indigenous nationalist leaders. While the 1922 Hugh Clifford constitution introduced elective principle, the 1951 constitution introduced federalism and the 1954 Littleton constitution provided the basis for the constitution of independent Nigeria.

"One of the most revolutionary influences operative in Nigeria since the beginning of the European intrusion has been Western education"[25]. Coleman further maintained that these influences were directly felt by only a few numbers of the population before 1951 and that from the start, education was monopolised by the Christian missionaries. "To all intents and purposes, the school is the church, right away in the bush or in the forest the two are one, and the village teacher is also the village evangelist"[26]. As early as 1942, the missionaries were in control of about 99% of the schools and more than 97% of the students in Nigeria were registered in mission schools[27]. By 1945, a large number of Nigerians had already received western education.

However, Africans have hotly criticized the quality of education so far received from the British government and the missionaries as substandard compared with British standard at home hence it has been described as 'liberal education'. Perhaps, the British primary aim of establishing schools was just to train clerks, store-keepers, interpreters for administrative convenience.

One of the major factors which had changed both the structure and perspectives of the Nigerian traditional societies and peoples was western economic system. This new economic philosophy was tailored towards the development of good communication and transportation network, imposition of systematic taxation, introduction of a standard coin currency, encouragement of introduction and expansion of international trade.

The development of good communication network, roads and the creation of common currency improved mobility, effective commercial activities, intra and inter-regional group relations. The modern agricultural production was boosted by modem production techniques such as improved seedlings, pest control, modern irrigation, modem storage techniques, application of fertilizers, specialization theory e.t.c. These had increased the scope of both production and exchange. This trend at last influenced a high rate of urbanization in Nigeria[28]. Of these British economic achievements, transport service was prime. "Economic development requires adequate and effective transport services"[29]. It should however be noted that the potency of transport as a vital agent of economic growth and development is contingent upon other human and material factors.

It has been argued that the British developed railway, roads and waterways as means of securing her political and economic exploitation. The railway would facilitate diversion of commodities and trade to the ports of suitability of the colonial power. Both imposition of taxation and use of standard currency were meant to enhance the British commercial and political interest in the territories. The improvement on health services could easily be understood, considering the fact that the British officials needed this more than anything else as a result of change of environment and their fragile nature. As a matter of fact, colonial economic development in Nigeria was "a combination of European capital and efforts of Nigerian enterprise, while it is possible to compute the former the latter is incalculable as it took a heavy toll in lives and forced labour[30]",

**Development of Nationalism in Nigeria**

One of the most significant events in West Africa and Nigeria in particular in the 20th century has been the opposition to foreign rule and struggle for self-government. Nationalism in Nigeria took three major phases - resistance movement against the penetration of the Europeans (traditional nationalism) embarked upon by various traditional rulers. The second phase was struggle for active political participation by the educated elite who felt aggrieved as a result of the deliberate inclusion of the local chiefs and their own exclusion in the British political arrangement. The modem and the last segment of nationalism involved sentiment volatile activities and organizational developments aimed expressly at creating a sovereign state of international standard[31]. The genesis of nationalism in Nigeria could be found in the various resentments against the oppressive, exploitative, disdainful and discriminatory treatments of the British government of Nigerians. The emergence of Nigerian nationalism however pre-dated 20th century, it was during this period that it grew into full maturity.

One of the modem and militant nationalist struggles of note during this period was the Zikist movement (1946-1950). The movement stood for political struggle with the National Church of Nigeria as the religious wing which represented revolt against white European churches, the Nigerian Labour Congress represented the economic wing. To buttress the relevance of this movement, Nwanfor Orizu said "Zikism must grow and spread on one social myth; namely, African irredentism, which must mean, the redemption of Africa from social wreckage, political servitude and economic impotency". He further maintained that Africa is then to be saved from ideological confusion, psychological immaturity, spiritual complacency and mental stagnation.

In tracing the major factors that gave birth to nationalism in Nigeria, the defects inherent in indirect rule would come to focus. The deliberate exclusion of the educated elite in the British colonial administration has been criticized by the nationalists as a tactical way of perpetual political domination and the inclusion of the traditional chiefs suggested a fraudulent political arrangement hence it aroused the resentment of the nationalists.

The British system of indirect rule created a situation in which traditional rulers were imposed on the people through misguided and undue appointment by the British officials as was the case in eastern Nigeria. The result was that, some other chiefs became autocratic and despotic, consequently, the people lost confidence in

the British agents and became critical and suspicious of the British rule.

Another factor of note that influenced the growth of nationalism in Nigeria was western education. This exposed most Nigerians to political consciousness and therefore influenced their constitutional struggle for fundamental human rights. Their awareness that all the sensitive offices in the civil service and in the economic scene were dominated by the colonial officials without due recognition of the Nigerian elite elicited resentment.

Formation of political parties in Nigeria was very instrumental to the rise of nationalism. The Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP) was formed in 1922 and led by Herbert Macaulay, 'the father of Nigerian nationalism'. In 1934, the Nigerian youth movement was formed and became the most broad-based and forceful during this period[33]. N.C.N.C. was formed in 1944 and the Action group (A.g) sprang up in 1951. These parties were used as vehicles to harness and convey nationalist agitations or grievances during this period.

The role of the Nigerian press was decisive in arousing the spirit of nationalism in the people. In 1912 for instance, there were only four newspapers on regular publication. By 1926, there were already thirteen newspapers[34]. It was through newspapers that the obnoxious government policies were exposed and attacked. Fred Omu did not mince words when he described the Nigerian press of that time as "the guardian of the rights and liberty of the people as well as interpreters of their ideals and aspirations". In addition to the press was the emergence of the West African students' Union (W.A.S.U.) formed in 1925 by Ladipo Solanke, a Yoruba law student and Abeokuta indigene based in London. The union demanded for political, economic and social reforms in West African from the British government, the creation of a centre for the meeting of West Africa students in London to enable them discuss their common interests especially on national consciousness and racial pride.

The post-first world war economic depression was a vital factor that provoked the rise of nationalism in Nigeria. A few years after the first world war, Nigeria and West Africa in general witnessed a boom in trade. As a result of the huge sum of fund released for the civilians immediately after the war, production, sales and profits went up. However, between 1930 and 1938, price fell drastically low and the result was economic recession. In 1929, at the top of the boom, the value of Nigerian external trade was $30, 294,000. In 1931, the total value of exports and imports was approximately $17,000,000. In 1924 - 25, Nigeria received 3 pence a pound for its "American" cotton. In 1930 -31, she received as low as half a penny. The quantity exported dropped from 34,5000 bales to 14,000[36]. It was this economic hardship that further stimulated nationalist agitation and unpopularity of the British government.

Moreover, the outbreak of the World War II, 1939 - 45 was significant in the nationalist movement. The Atlantic charter, which was issued during the war, promised universal human rights for all races. The African ex-service men who fought during the war became exposed, and since they found nothing unique in the white man, they cast aside their colonial mentality, especially with the jobless situation after the war got fully prepared for nationalist struggle. The activities of the trade unions must not be forgotten in the struggle for self-rule in Nigeria and other West African territories.

In treating agitation for self-rule, one must not exclude the supportive role of the religious protest movements. There were religious secessionist movements at the early stage of nationalism in Nigeria which could best be described as the religious strand in Nigerian nationalism. These were the religious groups that seceded from the white dominated Christian churches in Nigeria[37]. One of the first of these separatist movements was the united African church which separated from the Anglican Church in 1891.

The discriminatory attitude of the Europeans became unbearable for the Africans hence they developed the intention of Africanization of mode of worship. The dominant intention of the Africans was expressed thus: "Thai tins meeting in humble dependence upon Almighty God is of opinion that Africa is to evangelized, and that the foreign agencies al work at the present moment, taking into consideration climatic and other influence cannot grasp the situation ... Resolved that a purely native African church be founded for the evangelization and amelioration of our race to be governed by African[38]. Dr. Edward Blyden of Liberia, a famous African spokesman was one of the major

pillars behind these movements. The editor of the leading nationalist paper in Lagos once wrote: "It is Dr. Blyden who has set the African thinking and caused him to see and understand that no people or nation has said the last word for the world and that each race should retain and develop upon its own natural racial lines[39]."

Another group of African Christians of note were the Aladura and Zionists. In Nigeria, Babalola of Ilesha founded the Christ Apostolic Church while Orimolade Moses of Lagos founded the Cherubim and Seraphim. Most of these separatist churches broke away as a result of disillusionment. They might be orthodox in doctrine but they aimed at exhibiting the quality of African leadership.

A notable and militant Nigerian led Christian movement called Orunlaism had its slogan as "scrap the imported religion ... there can be no political emancipation without spiritual emancipation ... paint Clod as an African, the angels as Africans ... the devil by all means in any colour than an African and thou shall be saved"[40]. The reasons for the development of schism in the orthodox churches and Africanism in many churches were the condescension towards African culture, intolerance of African customs and the Europeanization of everything about God by the white man.

**Means Adopted in Achieving Independence**

Nigerian nationalists adopted various tactics as tools for attainment of independence, Though, Nigeria attained independence in 1960, the struggle for independence took similar form and orientation in all West African States. This could best be summarised as dialogue and propaganda. Nigerian nationalists engaged in dialogue with the colonial masters in conferences on the issue of self rule. For instance, there were constitutional conferences in 1957 and 1958 respectively. In the 1958 conference, it was specifically resolved that Nigeria would be independent on 1st October. 1960.

Apart from these measures, there was the use of the press, through using news papers to express their demands and ventilate their grievances both at home and abroad. The nationalists also embarked on the use of propaganda - to achieve their nationalist objectives. Trade unions were formed to enhance and articulate their collective demands. Formation of political parties, students' union and other pressure groups were helpful instruments for attaining independence in Nigeria.

**Conclusion**

In treating colonialism and nationalism in Nigeria and West African in general, it should be clearly understood that the fundamental factors to be examined were the forceful and fraudulent penetration of the territories, the exploitative and discriminatory administration of the Europeans, coupled with the natural urge of the Africans to rule themselves. Other factors should be seen as developments alongside these and complementary to them. This chapter has examined the concept of nationalism in relation to Nigeria using 1900 - 1960 as the time frame. The study has demonstrated that colonization of Nigeria by the British government was a taxing venture. A careful perusal of this work would show that the nationalist struggle against European political and socio-economic domination and exploitation was not in futility. Though, many people died in the course of loyalty or patriotism and others were imprisoned, in the end, Nigeria gained the long awaited "freedom", on 1st October, 1960. Thus, this marked the end of an era and the beginning of another. However, for many years, Nigeria agitated for self-rule, today, it has taken the country about 43 years of sovereignty in which the chisel has been in her hand to fashion her destiny according to her cultural taste. Unfortunately, "She has only left Egypt, she has not got to the promised kind".

**Notes**


1. *Cambridge Inicnuiiii'iitil Dictionary- of English,* Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995, p. 259
2. Joseph Anene & Godfrey Brown (eds.): *Africa in* 7/,< *J9th & 20th Centuries,* Ibadan University Press. 1966, p. 308
3. Ibid p. 308

4. Ayandele E. A; " External Relations with Europeans in the 19th Century: Explorers, Missionaries and Traders" In Obaro Ikime (ed) *Groundwork of Nigerian History: Heine*mann Education Book, Ibadan, l%0, p. 36S. *Ibid,* p. 368 *Ibid,* p. 368

5. Ibid, p. 368

6. Ibid, p. 368

**NATIONALIST MOVEMENTS IN WEST AFRICA**

Nationalism can be defined as the identification by a group of people with a nation-state and a desire to achieve the political economic and social freedom and development of that nation-state.

**BRITISH WEST AFRICA**

Nationalist movement in British West Africa went through two phases: the period between 1865 and 1939 which witnessed mild nationalism, and the period between 1939 and 1960 that witnessed active nationalism.

**Common Trends in Pre-War British West African Nationalism**

1. *Early Reaction to British Rule:* These were organised protest movements against or resistance to growing alien political and economic control immediately after the conquest of individual African states. Two examples shall be taker here. One was the Fante Confederacy which was organised in 1868 to take over the control of the Gold Coast in the event of British withdrawal. However in 1974 this movement towards self-government was nipped in the bud by the British annexation of Fante territory. Another was the Aborigines Right Protection Society \which is regarded as the first major political protest after the partition).

   The society was formed in 1897 in the Gold Coast to deal with a land reform made by the colonial administration to invest all public, unoccupied land. The society sent delegations to London in 1898 and succeeded in preventing the Land Bill from being passed into law.

2. *Formation of Political Parties:* The first of such parties was the National Congress of British West Africa formed in Accra in 1920. The Congress did not ask for self-government. It only demanded constitutional reforms especially with regards to greater participation of Africans in the affairs of their countries. It however demanded the establishment of a West African University. In 1923, the Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP) was formed in Lagos. Essentially a Lagos party formed by Herbert Macaulay, it won all the elections into the Legislative Council between 1923 and 1938. Other political parties formed during this period were the Nigerian Youth Movement (1934), the Gold Coast Youth Conference (1938), the West African Youth League of Sierra Leone (1938), West African Students' Union (1925). They were the roots of party politics in West Africa.

3. *The Church Movement:* This constituted the struggle between African and European clergymen for control of the church. It led to the break-away of many African converts from the white- dominated Protestant churches to found new and indigenous churches. By 1920, no less than fourteen churches under African control existed in Nigeria alone. African names were adopted at baptism, the Bible was translated to African tongues, hymns were sung with African rhythm and clergymen started publishing tribal histories.

4. *The Newspapers:* African-owned presses and newspapers started to emerge during this period. The *Lagos Weekly Record* which began to appear in Nigeria in 1890 was unflinching in its defence of the Negro

race, while the Serra-*Leone* (1884) and the *Gold Coast Independent (1895)* all helped to spread nationalist ideology among West Africans.

5. *External Factor: Pan Africanism:* This movement originated in 1900 in a Conference organised in London by a West Indian barrister Henry Sylvester-Williams. Its aim was to fight racial discrimination in America and colonialism in Africa. The Congress was launched in 1918-1919 in France at the 2nd Congress convened by W.E.B. Du Bois and Blaise Diagne of Senegal. Three subsequent Pan African Congresses were held in London and Brussels in 1921, London and Lisbon in 1923 and New York in 1927. One thing about the Congress at this early stage was that the lead ers were not concerned with any demand for self-government.

**POST-WAR NATIONALISM**

**Effects of World War II on Nationalism in West Africa**

The Second World War was a European war. It was fought between Germany, Japan and Italy (the Axis powers) and Britain, France, America and Russia (the Allied powers). The war broke out in 1939 and it ended in defeat for the Axis powers in 1945. As colonial appendages of these European powers, Africans supported either side of the war. In the end, however, the war had tremendous effects on Africa.

1. The war created a period of economic boom. Following the loss of Asia to Japan, the allied powers looked to West Africa for supply of tin, rubber, cotton and palm produce which brought a higher standard of living to people who prospered in the trade. The first effect of this boom was the demand for social and economic reforms by nationalists after the war. This demand was further aggravated by colonial governments closer control of the economy by way of price-control, controlled marketing of export goods, wage ceilings, etc. Another effect was the rise in urbanizations and trade unions to co-electively bargain for more pay and better condition of service. The number of these unions and associations grew rapidly and cooperated with nationalist leaders who exploited their demands to call for self-government. Thus, the economic boom created a favourable pivot for nationalism in West Africa.

2. Socially, urban centres grew, schools were opened and many more children attended these schools. These school leavers further increased the population of the already crowded towns, further causing a lot more social problems. More over, those who attended schools were able to read the news papers which at this time were full of grievances against the colonial government. Hence, the spread of nationalist ideals among the unemployed and disgruntled people who subsequently constituted nationalist agitators.

3. The return of the ex-servicemen also speeded up the spread of nationalism in West Africa. Thousands of West Africans served in the British colonial army during the World War. When they returned, they intimated the stay-at-homes with their experience outside Africa. Especially, they broke the myth of European racial superiority by the account of their experience in European brothels. More importantly, they had seen nationalist struggles in Asia and the European sub-continent. They therefore gave some psychological encouragement to African nationalists and rabble rousers.

4. There was the Atlantic Charter. In this charter of 1941, President Roosevelt of the U.S. and Prime Minister Churchill of Britain declared respect for the right of all peoples to choose the form of government under which they will live. This incensed nationalists all over the world and they hoped that someday self-government would be granted them.

5. The United Nations Organization was formed at the end of the war. It made emancipation from colonization one of its guiding principles. This hastened the pace of decolonization in West Africa.

**Development of Political Parties**

1. *Nigeria:* The hopes raised by the 2nd World War needed a strong organization to coordinate them. The first political party in Nigeria was the National Council of Nigerian Citizens (N.C.N.C.). This was inaugurated in 1944 and it aimed at achieving national unity to attain self-government, social and economic security and political freedom of all Nigerians. Herbert Macaulay was President while Dr. Azikiwe was Secretary. The Party supported the general strike of 1945 and its Freedom Charter of 1948 appealed to nationalist sentiment of the masses. However, in 1951, two more political parties arose in Nigeria and thenceforth nationalism in Nigeria became regionalised. These were the Northern Peoples Congress (N.P.C.) and the Action Group (A.G.). The NPC had, as its leaders, the Hausa-Fulani combination of the Sardauna of Sokoto and Sir Abubakar Tafawa Balewa. The Party established undiluted control of the north and after the 1954 general elections it had the largest seats in the House of Representatives. The A.G. was formally formed in 1951 by Chief Obafemi Awolowo. The party had influence in the Western Region and won the elections of 1951.

2. *Ghana:* Founded in 1947, the United Gold Coast Convention (U.G.C.C.) of Dr. J.B. Danquah aimed at the attainment of self-government for Ghana. Dr. Kwame Nkrumah was invited home to be secretary. The party was famous for the support it gave to agitations by the ex-servicemen which eventually in 1948 caused the jailing of six of its leaders. It was at this stage that Dr. Kwame Nkrumah broke away to form his Convention People's Party (C.P.P.) whose programme was immediate self-government. Its positive action led to the arrest of Nkrumah and some others. In 1951, elections were held in which Nkrumah was elected while still in prison. He was soon released and became leader of Government. This quickened the pace of nationalist movement in Ghana.

**FRENCH WEST AFRICA**

Nationalism developed in French West Africa at a much slower pace than it did in British West Africa. This was due to a number of reasons:

1. The French system of assimilation outlawed political associations outside the Communes of Senegal. Politics flourished only in the four Communes (St. Louis, Refisque; Goree and Dakar). These Communes had the right of French citizenship and priviledge of representation in the French National Assembly. Elsewhere, the cruel law, *fnd/genat* was operative — a system of imprisoning political agitators with out trial.

2. Because the colonial government controlled the schools in French West Africa, only very few selected people received education. This meant a radical reduction in the number of potential political agitators.

3. The small number of French West African elites were not subjected to any racial discrimination in civil service appointments and were not embittered in any form to cause protest movements. Any elite who has attained French citizenship received all the rights that accrue to the French man.

4. Because of the federal structure of administration, French West Africans did not develop any national feelings until after the 2nd World War. Because of direct control from Darkar, the colonies did not have any regional feelings.

**Post-War French West African Nationalism**

The European and African factors of World War II which helped to stimulate the growth of nationalism in British West Africa also had similar effects on French West Africa. There were however some peculiar economic, social and political agitations against French colonialism in French West African nationalist movement.

1. Firstly, there was social discrimination as a result of the polarisation of the French West Africans into citizens and subjects. This, together with the overly obnoxious practices as indignant, conscription and forced labour caused resentment among the nationalists.

2. Secondly, the French government, as an act of gratitude to the colonies for their loyalty during the war, braced itself for political and economic reforms. In 1944, therefore, the *indignant* was eliminated together with forced labour. Further, the Constituent Assembly was called first in 1945 and then in 1946 which drew up a new constitution for France and her overseas colonies and which granted Territorial Assembly to each colony.

**2.** *Political Parties:* The first major political party founded in French West Africa after the war was the Rassemblement Democratique Africain (R.D.A.), the African Democratic Rally. It was founded in 1946 under the chairmanship of Felix Honphouet-Biogny of Ivory Coast. The R.D.A. allied itself with the French Communist Party because the latter was anti-colonial, though it rejected communist ideology as unpracticable to African society. Because the party was popular and successful in its anti-colonial drives, it soon became repressed by the French colonial administration. Its leaders were often arrested, shot or imprisoned. The party soon lost its revolutionary fervour, broke with the French Communist Party and became conservative. This notwithstanding, the party's leaders still managed, by cooperating with the administration, to win an increase in the powers of **the Territorial Assembly while curtailing those of the Governor-General at Dakar. Another political party was the Independents — formed in 1948 by a group of deputies who were hostile to R.D.A.'s communist association. With L.S. Senghor as its leader the I.O.M. was a darting of the ruling French Socialist Party.**

**HOW NIGERIA ATTAINED INDEPENDENCE**

1. Nigeria's struggle for independence, except for some disturbances in 194850, was largely non-violent. Until 1946, the northern and the southern parts of Nigeria had been ruled separately. The 1946 Richard's Constitution brought the North and the South together in a central legislature. In this constitution the Legislative Council was empowered to legislate for the whole country. Nigeria was divided into three regions and each of them had a regional House of Assembly. The members of the Legislative Council were however elected indirectly by the regional Assembly. Apart from the Legislative Council, there was also an Executive Council of twelve out of which only one was African. This constitution proved unsatisfactory to the nationalist leaders and it was criticised.

2. The 1951 Macpherson Constitution came into being as a result of criticism levied on Richards' Constitution. It retained the regions, replaced the Legislative Council with a central House of Representatives of 136 members (68 from the North and 34 each from the West and the East). There was also the Executive Council of 12 African members (four from each region) and seven officials. African membership was increased, and an unofficial African majority in the ministerial system was introduced.

3. The 1954 Lytelton Constitution introduced federalism and allowed the regions a lot of autonomy. Subjects like banking currency, customs, external affairs, security, police, transport, communications were exclusive preserves of the Federal government while all other powers not included in the list went to the regional government as residual powers. There was regionalisation in Marketing Boards, Judiciary and the Public Service. The regions were ruled by a governor and a premier while the Governor-General ruled from Lagos. This constitution also provided for direct election of members into the legislature.

4. In the elections that followed the adoption of this constitution, the ISIPC won 79, NCNC 61, and A.G. 27 seats. The NCNC and the NPC formed a coalition government at the centre.

5. The last constitution before independence was that written in London at a Conference held between 957-58. This reform provided for a 320-member central Legislature and a Senate. The office of Prime Minister was introduced and universal adult suffrage was introduced in West and East. The East and West were granted internal self-government in 1957 while the North did not become self-governing until 1959. Independence of the country was preceded by a federal election and motion calling for the independence of the

country at the House of Representatives. When in 1959 these elections were held, the NPC won in the North, the A.G. in the West and the NCNC in the East. Again, the NCNC — NPC coalition persisted and the A.G. again went into opposition.

On October 1st 1960, Nigeria became independent with Sir Abubakar Tafawa Balewa as the first Prime Minister. The legacy of regional and ethnic hostility, which was to lead to violent political disturbances, military take-over and a bitter civil war was however visible.

**HOW GHANA ATTAINED INDEPENDENCE**

1. The Bourne's Constitution of 1946 which introduced unofficial African majority into the Gold Coast Legislative Council marked the beginning of Ghana's journey towards independence.

   This Legislative Council of 30 had 18 Africans as members. The constitution also provided for an Executive Council which consisted of 5 officials and 2 Africans nominated by the governor.

2. It was the Coussey Constitution of 1951 that set up a Legislative Assembly of 75 African members. The members of the Executive Council (Cabinet) were drawn from the Legislative Assembly. Members of the Executive Council however were responsible to the governor, not to the Legislative Assembly. Nkrumah's party (the C.P.PJ) won 34 out of the 38 directly elected seats when the constitution was adopted. He thus became in 1952, the Prime Minister.

3. Proposals submitted by the C.P.P. formed the basis of the 1954 constitution which provided for an elected Assembly of 104 members, and a Cabinet of 8 - all African members. The governor was given responsibility over defence and external affairs matters. This constitution was important for it gave the Gold Coast full internal self-government. In the election which followed this, the; C.P.P. won 71 seats and formed the government while the Northern Peoples Party'(N.P.P.) won just 21 seats - enough to form the opposition. The C.P.P. called for complete independence and stood for a unitary constitution. But the British government demanded a pro independence election to determine the popular will. This done in 1956, with the C.P.P. having a majority, the British government yielded and on March 6, 1957, Ghana became independent.

**INDEPENDENCE AND AFTER**

Problems Facing the Newly Independent States:

1. *Political:* The first political problem facing these new states is that of unity. Each of the countries is made up of multifarious ethnic groups each with its own distinctive language, custom, traditions and history. The ethnic groups had been forced together by colonialism and they remained unintegrated before independence. Subsequently after independence, inter-tribal rivalry and divisive forces of ethnicity started to plague the whole facet of public life. In order to win votes at election, tribal allegiances were sought; and politicians everywhere fanned the flame of tribal and religious sentiments. This is most exemplified in Nigeria where the three principal political parties after independence were regionally (and ethnically) based. Unity, under this situation, assumed a unique meaning - that unity is achieved if and when an ethnic group establishes its hegemony over the others. This leads to another political problem - that of stability. The governments were not stable (except in a few cases) and because of this instability, the era of army rule and its attendant coups and counter-coups was ushered in Rigging and many other election malpractices made the people lose interest in democracy and elections. Furthermore, the constitutional practice in these states which copied the imperial (British or French) system were adopted without adaptation. These soon proved unworkable in most countries. Many countries amended their constitution and, in the ones they wrote, removed the opposition and the independence of the judiciary.

2. *Economic:* The new states were not economically sound. National income per head was low. These nations

aspired to revolutionise the colonial economy under which West African countries had been preponderantly producers of raw materials and buyers of industrial and manufactured goods. Multi-national companies ran the import and export trades. To change this, the agricultural economy had to be supported so that self-sufficiency could be achieved in food production. Industrialisation is another economic problem. Manufacturing industries were either lacking or insufficient under the colonial rule. This was inherited by the new rulers who then decided to establish industries that would use the raw materials hitherto exported. But since industrialisation means heavy capital investment, the search for capital constitutes another problem. To get this, the former masters and their associates (who now pose as 'friends') had to be consulted.

Foreign aids, which these nations gave, however posed fresh danger to the newly won political independence — that of economic dependence. Even where the capital was accessible, another problem (of management and planning) arose. Qualified economic planners were lacking; and the services of the Europeans sought did not take congnisance of the nation's priorities, and not only promoted prestigious projects that did not raise the standard of living of a majority of people, but also served the interest of the Europeans. This brought into force what has been regarded as neo-colonialism.

3. *Social:* Corruption is the first social problem facing the new states. Most politicians saw their new positions as a way of enriching themselves at the expense of the masses of the people. They moved into houses hitherto occupied by the colonial officials, rode in plush cars and treated the masses that voted for them with contempt. Public funds were often embezzled and there was a widespread lack of proper accountability. This proved more serious when one realises that quite a high percentage of the people in almost all the states were illiterates. Education, important both for the understanding of the political processes and for providing the much-needed manpower in agricultural, industrial, and welfare programmes of the government, was not encouraged before independence. This inheritance proved a liability. Because the available manpower was neither technical nor vocational but literary, the rate of unemployment soared. The post independence growth of primary and post-primary institutions far out stripped the growth of the economy and school leavers hated to go back to the farm. When these school leavers got to towns in search of job and got disillusioned in the end, they constituted a new wave of social problems ranging from delinquency, drug addiction to crimes like robbery and burglary.

# AN OVERVIEW OF THE NATURE AND CHARACTER OF MILITARY RULE IN NIGERIA

**GBOYEGA AJAYI**

## INTRODUCTION

In the early hours of 15th January 1966. a bloody military coup was executed which unseated the first civilian administration in independent Nigeria. The military putsch, masterminded by Major C. K. Nzeogwu, claimed the lives of the Prime Minister. Alhaji Abubakai TafawaBalewa; the Premier of the Northern Region, Alhaji Ahmadu Bello; that of the Western Region, Chief Ladoke Akintola: the Minister for Finance, Chief Festus Okotie-Eboh; and, some high ranking military officers, mostly of Northern extraction.[1] Unfortunately for the coup plotters, the coup failed in the Eastern Region and Lagos - the seat of the Federal Government. Thus they were unable to secure total control of the country. For the records, it was the Chief of Army Stall. Major General Aguiyi Ironsi, who foiled the attempt in Lagos and subsequently became the Head of State.[2]

Ironsi was in office until the 29th of July 1966 when he was assassinated in a counter-coup which brought Lt. Col. (later General) Yakubu Gowon to power. Gowon was in office for nine year (1966 - 1975) before he was supplanted by another military regime headed by Brigadier (later General) Muritala Mohammed. Significantly the change of government was effected in a bloodless manner. However, Mohammed was in office for barely six months before he was felled by the assassins' bullets on the 13th of February 1976, in an abortive coup attempt. His second-in-command, Lt. Gen. Olusegun Obasan|o. stepped into his shoes and steadfastly implemented the regime's laid out programmes up to 1st of October 1979 when power was transferred to civilians. But the civilian administration of Alhaji Shehu Shagari lasted for only four years and three months before it was toppled by yet another military coup on the 31sl of December 1983.

The new military administration headed by Major General Muhammadu Buhari was itself supplanted in office by General Ibrahim Babangida (IBB), the erstwhile Chief of Army Staff, on 27th August 1985, through a palace coup. IBB managed to retain office for eight years through deft manoeuvres reminiscent of the Machiavellian Prince.[3] The Interim National Government (ING) to which he handed over power, following the unwarranted annulment of the June 12 1993 presidential election, which would have concluded the transition.[4] did not endure. It lasted between 26th August and 17th November 1993 when it fell victim of yet another military coup masterminded by (General Sanni Abacha, the erstwhile second-in-command in the ING contraption. Abacha was in office until June 1998 when he died in controversial circumstances. The rump of his administration now headed by General Abdulsalam Abubakar remained in office until May 29th 1999 when it handed over power to the democratically elected civilian regime of retired General Olusegun Obasanjo.

We have gone to this extent of giving a somewhat chronological detail of military regimes in order to imprint at the back of our minds the fact of the military's strong grip over Nigerian politics. In fact, between 1966 and 1999 there were only two brief periods of civilian interregnum; first, between 1979 and 1983, and, second, for three months in 1993. It is also necessary to establish a background for a fuller discussion of the performance of the military in government. Rather than a discriminatory epochal treatment, all the regimes will be taken together in the descriptive analysis that follows. The informing sensibility here is that fundamentally there was continuity (in terms of structure and disposition) under military dispensations in Nigeria. The minor changes (mainly in terms of leadership style and affectations) were superficial and so inconsequential. But where and when necessary examples of specific regimes will be invoked to buttress our position. in order to avoid repetitions, a thematic (rather than narrative) Approach is employed in this work. Thus the following themes are slated for discussion.

(i) Circumstances Leading to Military Intervention in Nigerian Politics;
(li) Structure and Disposition of Military Administration in Nigeria; and,
(iii) Some Legacies of Military Rule.

These shall be addressed in the order in which they are listed before rounding off with some concluding remarks.

**i. Circumstances Leading to Military Intervention in Nigerian Politics.**

Generally, the reasons for military intervention in politics have been dealt with by many authors. But some of the proffered reasons are of limited application. In the case of Nigeria, for instance, theories that portray soldiers as modern! sers[3]- puritans[6] and patriots[7] cannot be sustained by available evidences. This, therefore, calls for an in depth study of particular situations with emphasis on the peculiar circumstances warranting or paving way for military intervention. In the Nigeria of 1966 such circumstances were characterized by unmet rising expectations (based on campaign promises); corrupt and inept leadership; and general systemic decay. For the records, the Northern People's Congress (NPC) in coalition with the National Council of Nigerian Citizens (NCNC) was in control of political power during the First Republic (1960 -1966) while the Action Group (AG) acted as the opposition party in the parliamentary system of government that was operated then. These three parties were the majority parties which were, either by accident or design, regionally - based.[8] There were also nine other minority parties operating in the regions. Significantly none of the parties (majority or minority) had sufficient political clout to win a national election single - handedly. The situation warranted the initiation of alliances amongst the political parties. Thus, on the eve of the 1964/65 federal elections the twelve active parties had coalesced into two major alliances. These were the Nigeria National Alliance (NNA) and the United Progressive Grand Alliance (UPGA). The NNA, made up chiefly of the NPC (the senior partner in the two -party coalition government of the first republic); the United Peoples'

Party –UPP (a breakaway faction of the AG); the Dynamic Party; and the Midwest Democratic Party (MDP), used the power of incumbency and other ruthless devices to manipulate the election in its favour.[9]

This development sowed the seed of crises and political instability which threatened the corporate existence of the country. But it was the western regional election of 1965 and the role of the federal government in it that actually sounded the death knell of the first republic. It will be recalled that the NPC - controlled Federal Government backed the Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP) - a coalition party of a breakaway faction of AG and the NPC- in the blatant rigging of the election.[10] Predictably this generated more serious crisis leading to a complete breakdown of law and order. In fact there was organized destruction of lives and properties on a large - scale under the infamous" Operation *We tie* - (local reference to arson).

The federal government's nonchalant attitude to this ugly development did not help matters. Perhaps it felt that the situation was too parochial to warrant federal intervention or may be it saw in the situation an opportunity to destabilize the opposition and thereby gain permanent political foothold in that region. Whatever the case may be the lukewarm attitude of the government to the security and political fortunes of the western region made it more unpopular and uncaring. This and the frequent use of the military to clamp down on perceived opposition groups "made it clear to those soldiers who cared to think about it that the survival of the existing political order depended upon them".[11]

Thus the weakening in legitimacy of the civilian government beginning from its role in the AG crisis of 1962/63; the jailing of some notable leaders of the AG on trumped - up charges in 1963[12]; the census crisis of 1962/63; the general strike of 1964; and, which reached its culmination in the electoral crises of 1965 created the opportunity for military intervention in politics. Thus, when the military intervened the circumstances were quite auspicious. The civilian rulers had proved incapable of carrying the burdens of statescraft while the people had become disillusioned and apathetic. In sharp contrast to the malaise afflicting the civil society, the military organization appeared to be apolitical, nationalistic and disciplined. But the reality of the situation, which unfortunately was not open to the generality of the people then, was that the military had been politicized through the quota system of recruitment[13] and its invidious use by civilians to suppress civil unrest.

Thus, unwary Nigerians enthusiastically welcomed the coup, especially in the southern parts of the country. Even the North which was initially indifferent, and later antagonistic, to the emergent regime would most probably have supported the change of government if it had been effected without bloodshed

and ethnic undertones. The incontrovertible fact is that the civilian administration of the First Republic had lost legitimacy and so was ripe for the picking when the coup took place.

The counter-coup that followed six months thereafter was executed from all intent and purposes, to restore the political balance in favour of the North which had lost the cream of her political and military elite in the dastardly act of January 15. Significantly the counter-coup put in place a military regime indicating the loss of confidence in the civilian ruling elite. This supports our earlier submission that the civilian regime had been discredited across the country. However, the military regime, after an impressive start, exemplified chiefly by the successful prosecution of the civil war, soon started bungling like the civilian government it replaced. It was when its credibility was seriously at stake that a palace coup was executed in July 1975 to revamp the 'corrective regime' image, which it had carved for itself.[15]

By the time the military handed over power to civilians in 1978 it was hoped that we would have seen the end of military political adventurism. But this was not to be. The Second Republic was virtually a re-enactment of the evils of the First thereby creating a supportive environment for the return of the supposedly corrective military. Thereafter many other military juntas seized power, as we have noted previously or attempted to seize power (the failed coup attempt) not so much for the desire to offer a better alternative but mainly for self-aggrandizement. This therefore puts question marks on the often stated mission of the military in politics as corrective agency or reactive intervener.[16] The long stay of the military in power and the deliberate institutionalization of certain self-serving structures and procedures have not only exposed the lie in the supposedly transient nature of military rule but also impacted negatively on its performance in office. This shall be addressed in greater details.

**ii. Structure and Disposition of Military Administration in Nigeria**

The basic structure of military administration in Nigeria was a pyramidal arrangement with the leader of the coup plotters, or their representative, and a clique of trusted compatriots constituting a council at the apex. This superordinate Military Council was known at different time as Supreme Military Council (SMC); Armed Forces Ruling Council (AFRC); National Defence and Security Council (NDSC); and, Provisional Ruling Council (RRC). In theory this was the highest ruling body but under some regimes, like those of General Buhari, IBB and Abacha, it was merely a rubber stamp for validating the whims and caprices of the commander-in-chief. Next in the hierarchy was the Federal Executive Council – a purely advisory body to which the ministers and other high-ranking bureaucrats belonged. This was replicated at the state level where there was the State Executive Council performing similar functions for the military governor. At the Federal level there was also the Council of State to which all the military governors belonged. This was more like a feedback organ through which the Federal Military Government (FMG) felt the pulse of the people and passed instructions down to them.

The system of government was federal, having a recognized centre alongside with federating states and local government councils. But it was a peculiar from of federalism in which the centre was stronger and more preponderant than all the federating states and local councils put together. In fact, it was more of a regimental arrangement in which order came from the center and unquestioning obedience from the subordinate units. This stifling arrangement did not give room for local initiatives that would have fostered development at the grassroot level.

Furthermore, revenue allocation formulae under different regimes were also skewed in favour of the FMG at the center. The previous practice, during the First Republic, of allowing the federating regions to have control over revenue generation and appropriation, was dispensed with when Gowon ascended to power. Ever since successive military regimes entrenched a new arrangement by which the FMG transferred revenue to the states through the Distributable Pool Account (DPA)[17] which it controlled exclusively. This gave the military rulers profound clout; for, 'he who pays the piper dictates the tune'.

There were even some deliberate attempts to militarize the Nigerian polity in order to prolong military rule.

This came in the form of indiscriminate issuance and ruthless execution of decrees and the suspension or abrogation of certain sections of the extant constitution. There was also the establishment of military tribunals; sustenance of highly dreaded state security apparatuses; and, the regular employment of coercive and repressive methods to cow-down the citizenry and suppress civil organizations like Trade Unions, Human Rights and pro-Democracy groups, the Press etc. In these diverse ways the democratic space was constricted. It is ironical that it was under this uncertain atmosphere that most military regimes purported to effect a transfer of power to civilians. We have observed elsewhere that:

*…as a result of the vested interests of the military sponsors.*
*of the transition programme and the self-seeking orientation of their civilian collaborators, the political environment was always crisis-laden. The military then waited in the wings watching out for the usual promptings from the disillusioned segments of the society before staging a reluctant comeback.*'"

The situation described above has been aptly tagged the "handback option".[19] In short the transition was largely a ruse, cleverly contrived to elongate military rule in a surreptitious manner. We recognize the fact that the military had handed over power to civilians since 1999 and it has not staged a comeback yet. This has been the case because the circumstances are not yet auspicious if the following statement by retired General Babangida is anything to go by. He remarked in a press interview, that "(we) in the military are very smart people, we wouldn't interfere in government when we know it has the support of the populace".[20] We can also add that some legacies of military rule in Nigeria cannot endear it any longer to well-meaning Nigerians. We shall proceed to elaborate on this presently.

**iii Some Legacies of Military Rule**

Up to 1979 the military in Nigeria had a track record of some good political performances. The military has been credited with the creation of states ostensibly to enhance the nation's federal status. But it must be noted that the state creation exercises led to the balkanization of the polity and progressively weakened the position of the polyglot stales vis-a-vis that of the federal military government at the center. In lad the center grew stronger at the expense of the states. This was a peculiar form of federalism. The military also expended a lot of money on the construction of roads, airports, seaports, massive agricultural projects (like the Operation Feed the Nation - OFN, and the River Basin Development Authorities) and rural development programmes (like the Directorate of Food, Roads and Rural Infrastructure - DFRRI). Bui there is little to show for the huge investments on these projects. The projects actually served as avenues for corrupt enrichment for privileged members of the ruling class (military and civilian). However, there were the successful prosecution of the civil war without incurring any debt (foreign or domestic); institutionalization of potentially integrative cross-cultural devices like the National Youth Service Corps (NYSC) scheme, National Sports Festival, National Festival of Arts and Culture, and, the transfer of power to civilians in 1979. But all these were achieved at considerable cost. We must also remember that it was at this period that corruption started assuming gargantuan proportions and the proceeds of the fortuitous 'oil boom' were recklessly spent without improving the living standards of the people. Also the craze for foreign goods and services became well established and the various indigenisation schemes were short-circuited. The above notwithstanding, the departing military rulers in 1979 were still held in high esteem.

However, by the time of the last handover of power to civilians in 1999 the generality of the people in Nigeria had become disenchanted with military rule largely because of its overall noxious impact on the polity. It has entrenched a culture of violence, authoritarianism, massive corruption in high and low places,[21] and left behind a depressed and prostrate economy through ineptitude, instability and impious experimentations.[22] Significantly the national currency was progressively debased. It also bequeathed to the nation ethno-religious CRISES and a badly ruptured polity - consequences of the divide and rule tactics of some military rulers.

In particular, the infamous Abacha regime did more to discredit military rule in the way .and manner it handled state affairs as well as its ruthless treatment of anti-military social forces and other perceived opposition elements.[23] The National Democratic Coalition (NADECO) was particularly singled out for annihilation because of its robust pro - democracy stand. Under him, the military virtually became an army of occupation which ruthlessly pillaged the nation's resources while subjecting the citizenry lo abject poverty and squalor Abacha

single-handedly amassed enough wealth lo make the fabled oil sheikhs feel inferior. His death offered a convenient opportunity for the now discredited military to look for a dignified exit from the political terrain.

Consequently, the new regime of (Gen. Abubakar executed the shortest transition programme ever in the history of Nigeria.[24] This culminated in the transfer of power to the civilian regime of retired General Olusegun Obasanjo. Obasanjo's antecedent as a former military head of state who transferred power to civilian as promised, albeit in controversial circumstances,[25] his rising profile as an international figure since retirement and his ordeal under the infamous Abacha regime[26] made his election acceptable to some people and at least, tolerable for others.

He showed a clear perception of the mood of the nation through his initial 'anti-military' moves. These ranged from the mundane gesture of jettisoning his military rank of 'General' in favour of the more civil title of 'Chief" to the more telling compulsory retirement of some military officers who had held political appointments under military regimes. These moves sent the right signals to the right quarters. But it must be clearly spelt out that the best antidote against military comeback to politics is good governance based on equity, justice and fair play; and marked improvement in the quality of life of the people.

**Concluding Remarks**

One continuous thread that has run through this chapter is the issue of 'performance'. When the First and Second Republics under the civilians did not perform well they lost legitimacy and thereby paved way for military rule. And. as a result of the overall shoddy performance of most military regimes, military rule also lost credibility with time. The nature and disposition of military rule in Nigeria were such that it could hardly be described as an aberration or a short-term expediency. Over the years it became so seriously entrenched in power that it began to see itself as an alternative government. But it was more appropriately a political usurper because it overshot its legal limits as the protector of the nation's territorial integrity. By dabbling into polities for such a length of time its professional status was adversely affected. This development also created deep cleavages within the organistion. The recurrent nature of coups, countercoups, abortive coups and rumours of impending coups clearly illustrate the extent of the cleavages. More importantly they engendered instability leading to political atrophy and economic underdevelopment. The cumulative effect of all these was that military rule became increasingly unpopular. Needless to say that all these did not augur well for military rule.

It is our hope that the present civilian dispensation and others yet to follow would have learnt some useful lessons concerning the significance of performance in a development-hungry polity like ours. Thus, all known impediments to good performance, like unwarranted party squabbles, political distractions, corruption, nepotism, intolerance, ethno-religious crises, election rigging and mediocrity must

**ESSAY IN CONTEMPORARY NIGERIAN HISTORY**

**This book, Essays in Contemporary Nigerian History, is the story of Nigeria, the story Coloialism, independence, the quest for social-economic development and nation building. There is, in it, greater emphasis on how Nigeria leadership has fried since 1960 to develop Nigeria into a united and prosperous polity at home in the face of several obvious contradictions, and a respected country and active actor in the certain of nations.**



## THE EVOLUTION OF NIGERIAN WOMEN IN POLITICS

**S. O. ARIFALO**

### Introduction

This paper examines the process of Nigerian women's involvement in partisan politics in the proto-colomal period (when formal colonialism had not been declared), the colonial period and the post-colonial period up to the so-called Second Republic. This will necessarily involve a discussion of the experiences, agonies, gains and losses of women in their long tedious road to self-actualization.

Writing on this theme is a worthy endeavour as many Nigerian women have reached the top of the ladder in academics, commerce and other professions. Until recently both historians and political scientists have tended to ignore the roles played by women in the public life of Nigerian societies. Some have included one or two chapters on the place of women in their studies, but they have not identified the impact of women in Nigerian political life. Nina Emma Mba's book, **Nigerian *Women Mobilised: Women Political Activity in Southern Nigeria*** is an ambitious and monumental effort. The work is significant as n contains biographies of Southern Nigerian women, who had participated in politics. Mba is concerned with women in Southern Nigeria and does not deal with

women in Northern Nigerian politics. Her discussions do not cover the period after 1965. However, there is need to do more serious studies about Nigerian women's involvement in politics. This paper is a modest contribution to the study of this important topic.

In the pre-colonial traditional Nigerian societies, female participation in political life was limited. The few who participated included the legendary Queen Amina of Zazzau (Zaria), who was reputed to have ruled over an empire, Ile-Ife's Moremi and Queen Idia of Benin. Traditional Yoruba societies were noted for their kingdoms being ruled by kings. But some women were known to have been kings in certain kingdoms. For instance, in Ile-Ife, there had been two female monarchs, namely, Olowu and Teboye.[1] In Akure, also there had been three female monarchs -Eyearo (1393-1419), Eyemoi (1705-1735) and Amaro (1830-1841).[2] In Ondo, the YeyeLisa - Lobun, not only had a role to play in the appointment of a new Osemawe (the king), but also in his installation ceremonies.[3] In many Yoruba kingdoms, women were an integral part of a complex, centralized and hierarchical palace organization. They were often involved in political manoeuvering and intrigues with chiefs, kings and kingmakers.[4] They were also involved in the wider administration of the kingdom. These examples were exceptions rather than general rule. In most cases, women were politically apathetic and remained in the background and supporting their men in the main.

In some Nigerian pre-colonial traditional societies women were often given positions of responsibility, more because of their birth and lineage than the capability of leadership. In Bomo, for example, the king's mother, his first wife and his sister were given high positions, which entailed power.

Unfortunately, the colonial intruders did not take cognizance of the traditional structure of Nigerian societies. In their characteristic manner, they made sure that they destroyed many good aspects of our culture. The kind of educational system which was introduced by the colonial officials was planned with a bias towards placing men at an advantage. In fact, girl schools were few and far between for a long time during the colonial period, there was no provision for the nomination of women's representatives in the local government, regional and federal elections. As a matter of fact, women were not given the franchise until 1949 in Port Harcourt and much later in other parts of the country.

**The Beginning**

If women did not participate fully in the political affairs of their societies, they were active in other areas concerning their economic and social well-being. Many Yoruba cities for instance had ***lyalodes*** (the mothers of the cities), or head of the women, who took care of the problems of the women. The market women especially looked up to them as leaders. Madam Tinuhu, an ebullient woman held such an exalted position. She blazed the irai I in certain respects for the Nigerian modern women. In the country today, there are many outstanding women traders, who are performing the very important functions of middlemen in commerce and wielding tremendous influence in the political affairs of their societies. The lack of formal western education was not an impediment. Many of them were celebrities and acquired what Biobaku has called "a certain measure of immortality."[5] Madam Tinubu, a very remarkable woman, and one of their precursors, acquired both Italyalode (lyalode Square) in Abokuta and the famous Tinubu Square in Lagos. These are eloquent testimonies to her inventive capacity.

Madam Tinubu was horn in Own in the old Egba Kingdom. After undergoing the traditional apprenticeship in trade under her mother, she went to seek her independent fortune in Badagry, where she quickly made an impact and established a thriving trade in salt and tobacco. Here, also she came into contact with Brazilian slave traders for whom she acted as a middleman. By the time Akintoye, the displaced king of Lagos got to Badagry via Abeokuta in about 1846, Tinubu had been wel and firmly established there. Akintoye's mother is believed to be an Owu woman and Tinubu recognized this bond of kinship with the exiled king immediately. She espoused his cause and used her wealth and influence in Badagry to mobilize a faction dedicated to the support of Akintoye and his return to his throne in Lagos. All over the place Tinubu became known as Akintoye's "niece" and his chief supporter against the intrigues of his nephew and supplantcr, Kosoko. Thus, after Consul Beecroft's intervention in Badagry in 1850 and the actions taken by Kosoko in 1851, Akintoye was brought back to Lagos accompanied by Tinubu.[6]

In Lagos, Tinubu soon emerged as the great power behind Akintoye's throne. She also transferred her trading activities to Lagos, where she became a leading middleman between the European traders in Lagos and her own people in Abeokuta. Some Lagos chiefs were irked by Tinubu's growing dominance over Akintoye. In fact, there was a rebellion organized by some chiefs. When Dosumu succeeded Akintoye, his father, in 1853, Tinubu's influence on the king increased tremendously since Dosumu was weak and had to rely more and more on the advice and support of Tinubu. But then Tinubu had to contend with the British Consul in Lagos, Benjamin Campbell. He accused Tinubu of acting as a middleman between the European and Bra/ilian slave traders and the Egba vendors who were using the Okc-Odan route.[7] Tinubu was accused of monopoly. Campbell, who was favourably disposed towards the Brazilian, Cuban and Sierra Leonean immigrants in Lagos, believed that they were bringing new ideas and skills to Lagos. Believing that they should be encouraged, he threw his weight behind them and forced Tinubu out of Lagos.[s]

On getting to Abeokuta, Tinubu settled at the Owu quarter. Here, resolute and undaunted, with her unfailing business acumen and enterprise, she quickly set up a flourishing trade in gunpowder, builds and other weapons of war. It should be remembered that the 19th century witnessed a lot of inter-state wars in Yoruba land and arms and ammunitions, which were required for the wars, were in great demand. Tinubu was to be useful to the Egba people in another area. In 1863, the Dahomean invasion of Egba land was imminent. Tinubu was one of those who organized the defense strategy of Egba land. In 1864, the Dahomeans invaded Egba land. It was a time of great excitement, anxiety and commotion in the kingdom. All hands were to be on deck to ward off the invaders. Tinubu was at hand at this critical moment in Egba history. She threw in all she had to support the Egba war effort. She did not hesitate to turn her compound into a veritable armoury from which arms and ammunitions were distributed to the Egba troops on their way to the battlefield. At a critical stage during the war, Tinubu went to stay at Aro gate, which was not far from the battlefront. This place was virtually her war camp. In this camp, the wounded troops were treated by her and her female assistants. Troops, whose ammunitions had been exhausted, replenished their store and from here also, deserting solders were encouraged and sent bank to the front with renewed vigour. With the material and moral support from this indomitable woman, the Dahomeans were roundly

defeated with heavy losses on their side. Thus, with this victory, the Egbas dealt a severe blow to the Dahomeans' prestige from which King Glele and his people never recovered.

On their own part, the Egbas fully appreciated the immense contributions which this great woman had made towards their decisive victory over their enemies and honoured her in 1864 with the honourable title ***of lyalode*** of the Egbas or Head of the women. This title accorded her a unique constitutional right of having a say in the affairs of the Egba people.[9] This was a great honour indeed. By this title she has acquired a kind of status, which she did not possess in Lagos and one, which gave her every scope to perform her usual role of being the pillar of strength behind the throne.

A chance came in 1869, when there was a contest for the vacant throne of the Alake. One of the candidates, Ademola enjoyed the backing of the traditional authorities. But the other contestant, Oyekan enjoyed the support of the emerging educated elite and the influential lyalode. At the end of the day, Tinubu and her group lost. Ademola I, became the Alake. The opposition of Tinubu and her group weakened the regime. Oyekan was installed the Alake in 1879. Tinubu quickly assumed her well-known role as the power behind the throne in Abeokuta. She was, however, at the peak of her influence and popularity, when she died in 1887, Tinubu died childless. Among the Yoruba childlessness is regarded as a serious calamity. The sting of childlessness is most keenly felt in contemplating death, one's children arc most in evidence during funeral ceremonies. The Egbas demonstrated their appreciation of the contributions of their *lyalode.* They rose to a man to perform her filial functions and according to Biobaku, she was given "a veritable state burial." The generality of the Egba people not only mourned her demise, they also celebrated her achievements as a heroine that she was.

Madam Tinubu's accomplishment in commerce alone was striking enough. But she added to it an uncommon taste for politics, which in her days often involved intrigues and manipulations of opponents and spineless traditional rulers. Frustrated out of Lagos by the British and their collaborators, Madam Tinubu regained her composure and established herself in Abeokuta and by demonstrating her patriotism in the defense of the Egba Kingdom against the Dahomeans, the avowed enemies of the Egbas, she secured for herself a pre-eminent position in the annals and the hearts of her people. She did not allow her childlessness to prevent her from putting her talents in the service of her beloved people. Since then, it has been Tinubu forever in the hearts of the Egba people. This indomitable and energetic woman had proved beyond any doubt, the capabilities of Nigerian womanhood.

**Nigerian Women In The Era of The Anti-Colonial Movement**

One event, which brought Nigerian women into the limelight in the early stages of the anti-colonial movement in Nigeria, was the Aba Women's Revolt of 1929. The Revolt occurred in four divisions in Calabar Province and in Afikpo Division of OgojaProvince. During the riots, the women lost fifty-five of their companions who were killed and fifty were wounded. Rousedby the Native Administration's tax efforts, the angry women sought for the removal of European presence from their land. The women went all out to attack the agencies of local government such as Warrant Chiefs, Native Courts and their staff, in short, the men and institutions who and which brought British Colonial rule home to the people.[10]

This revolt was one of the most serious challenges to the so-called Indirect Rule System in Nigeria. In the words of Afigbo ". what is known is that it is this Riot that shattered the complacent British belief that their rule was welcome by an overwhelming majority of Nigerians." As a result of the Women's Revolt, the reform of the local government system in Nigeria was undertaken in earnest. The process of this reform can be said to have marked the earliest beginnings of the. end of colonial rule in Nigeria.[11]

Seven years before the Aba Women's Revolt, Governor Clifford introduced a new constitution in Nigeria. This constitution made a provision for the elective principle in Lagos and Calabar. This, amonv other things, stimulated

Ihc rise of political parties in Lagos, which then became the hotbed of nationalist activities. The most important of the new political parties was the NUT nan National Democratic Party (NNDP), which was formed on June 23, 1923 by Herbert Macaulay,[12] a grandchild of Bishop Ajayi Crowlhcr, a civil engineer and journalist. The party was formed for the purpose of providing an electoral platform for Lagos candidates to the new Legislative Council. The party was the first modem political party in Nigeria. From 1923 50 1938, the NNDP supplied all the elected legislative and town councilors Iroin Lagos.[13] In fact, the party influenced Lagos politics for nearly forty years. Macaulay himself was often regarded as the Father of Nigerian nationalism.

One of the reasons for the political strength of the NNDP was the tremendous support given to it by the market women led by Madam Alimotu Pelewura (lady with the golden facial marks). Pelewura, the *Alaga* (Chairperson) of Ereko Market Women Organizations, saw them solidly organized to a degree, which they have never been before and since her death in 1951. She piloted the women during the period of their fiercest commutation with the British colonial administration, their alliances with the first anti colonial movements and major pre-indcpendcncc economic crises.[14]

Alimotu Pelewura who belonged to the Awori Yoruba subgroup, was born and bred in Lagos. She was a humble fish trader. Like Madam Tinubu, she could neither read not write. Like Tinubu also, she was childless, but raised many children of friends and relatives as her own. There was no market women organization embracing all Lagos market before 1920. It is believed that it was Macaulay who inspired the organization of the first women's association for the whole city of Lagos. He was reputed for having a remarkable genius for organizing people and things. Alimotu Pelewura was a well-known leader of market women before her association with Macaulay. But there is no doubt that her alliance with the leadership of NNDP greatly enhanced her power and popularity and catapulted her into a wider leadership position. As the leader of the market women's association. Pelewura exacted the loyalty and followership of the estimated 8,000 Lagos women. Pelewura was able to mobilize the Lagos women to the support of the NNDP.

By the end of 1932, Pelewura had become a member of the Ilu Committee. This body was traditionally charged with the maintenance of law and order in the various wards of Lagos. In the words of Cole"...the Ilu Committee was extremely significant in the political development of Nigeria in that it was the first institutionalized alliance between the traditional and modem elite.[15] This body offered a platform for the recognized participation of market women in traditional politics. As a member of this body, Pelewura was the spokeswoman for 84 market women's representatives from sixteen markets. Members ol' the Ilu Committee were staunch supporters of the NNDP.

For about forty years, Pelewura had her finger in every pie as far as politics and the welfare of the Lagos women were concerned. She organized and led protest demonstrations against colonial government measures, which the women considered detrimental to their interest. In the mid 1930s, the colonial administration decided to move the Ereko Market to a new location at Oluwole area in Lagos. Bui the market women regarded the proposed location as most unsuitable. The women, led by Pelewura protested in very strong terms. In spite of the objection of the women, the Government tried to enforce the relocation. Led by Pelewura, the women decided to physically block the move. Several of the women were arrested along with their leader and detained. The detained women were later released after the police station had been besieged by protesting women from all over Lagos and asking to be detained with Pelewura. As a result of the action of the women, the proposed relocation of the Ereko Market was dropped, though it was later moved to Egerton Square.

In early 1932, it was widely rumoured that Lagos women were to be taxed. The women quickly set up a committee of which Pelewura was a member. Members of the committee marched to Government to register their protest against the

proposal with the Commissioner for the Colony. The Commissioner informed the women that there was no proposal to tax women. However, the issue of women taxation was shelved for the time being. It resurfaced in 1940. In that year, the Government passed an Income Tax Law, which was to tax women whose annual income

exceeded £50. Immediately, the women began to mobilize themselves to protest the new legislation. On December 18, 1940, the women led by Pelewura submitted their petition against the new tax law to Governor Bourdillon and thereafter they marched to the home of Macaulay with whom they reviewed the events of the day. Later in the year after some maneuverings by government officials, Bourdillon announced that the level of annual taxable income of women was being raised from £50 to £200. When Pelewura heard about this development, her response was that once the principle of taxation was conceded, it was only a matter of time before all women were taxed. As it turned out, Pelewura was proved right. Gradually the taxation of women was extended. Some years later, when voting right for women became a serious issue, Pelewura protested against tax payment being made one of the voting qualifications.[16]

One other welfare issue, in which Pelewura was deeply involved, was the Second World War food price control scheme. This began in 1941 under the direction of Captain A. P. Pullen, whose name was promptly attached to the operation, it became known as the Pullen Scheme." The inability of the Colonial Government in Nigeria to control the price of food-stuffs led to the extension of the original 1941 price control plan to a 1943 proposal to control not only the prices of food-stuff's but their actual sale. The market women, who were the traditional distributors and retailers of foodstuffs, refused to cooperate with the scheme, which they believed would cut the ground under their feet. Pelewura as usual, led the Lagos market women" in the agitation against .the Pullen scheme. As the leader of the market Women" Association, she accused the government of depriving the women of their livelihood, claiming that the authorities, who established the prices control scheme knew little or nothing about local markets and the trading processes. The Pullen Scheme was destined to fail. A vigorous black market, involving not only the market women but also the producers as well as European firms - developed. Several arrests were made in 1942 and in September of the same year an official of the C.F. A. O. was fined £6 for breaking the price control regulations, while many market women were sent to jail for one month each for an identical offence. This discriminatory punishment naturally outraged the women. Pelewura rose to the occasion. She and her market women's associations sent letters and petitions of protest to the Governor, the Lagos Chamber of Commerce and Industry, the Commissioner for the Colony, the Legislative and Town Councils. Conviction of lawbreakers, however, did not perform the expected miracle of getting sellers and buyers to operate within the official price system. As Oyemakde has put it: "While government kept on failing the black markets kept on flourishing." As the controversy over the price control dragged on, Pullen was at his wits end. He tried to test Pelewura's will. He said that he would appoint Pelewura as the head of all the women sellers and would pay her £7:10s a month. Pelewura as a highly principled and patriotic leader, turned down the offer; saying that even if the pay were £100 a month, she would not take it as Pullen wished to break and starve her country. The women did not relent in their outcry against the Pullen Scheme. Pelewura sent a petition to he Governor, protesting against the entire Pullen scheme and including the badge number of the three policemen, whom she accused of commandeering gari, in the end, he scheme was an exercise in futility. As Oyemakinde puts it:
*The futility of hying to remove the price system as a deterrent of resource allocation thus became apparent even though the price control scheme was allowed to linger until 1947, when the "sick man's" (Pullen Scheme) weakened life could no longer be lengthened.18*

Although, the Nigerian press and other groups from all over Nigeria opposed the Pullen scheme, its collapse could be seen as a triumph for Pelewura and her women. Pelewura was not only interested in the welfare of the market women, she participated in the anti-colonial activities of her day. In July 1938 a new political party was considered as more radical, more forward-looking and more youthful than the NNDP. Pelewura became an active member of the Nigerian Union of Young Democrats. She often campaigned on behalf of the party's candidates even though Nigerian women had not been enfranchised; Pelewura was reputed as a powerful speaker, who often swayed the crowd. Even though she was a member ol the executive of the NUYD, she retained her membership ol the NNDP. When in June 1942 the NNDP wanted to inaugurate a branch in Aheoknta; Pclewura was the main speaker at the meeting. Her speech received an impressive applause.

In spite of her advancing age (she was about 80 years old) and failing health, Pelewura continued to be active in politics. As a result of the NNDP - NCNC merger of 1944, most of the Lagos women were supporters of the

NCNC, which at this point in time could be described as a pan-Nigerian political party. While the party made the famous tour of the country in 1946, it was Pelewura who hosted it in Lagos. When Oba Talolu was queried by the Government in 1947 for conducting a sacrifice on the Victoria Heach, Lagos, allegedly on behalf of the NCNC, Pelewura in a public statement supported the Oba and threatened that thousands ol Lagos women would be called out to demonstrate if the Government did not stop to harass the Oba. That statement put paid to the matter. As a result of her invaluable contributions to the development and organization of the party, she was easily appointed as a mcmhcr of the famous NCNC delegation to London in 1946 to protest against the so-called Richards Constitution. Unfortunately, she was loo old and ill to make the trip. This was an important national assignment. Her nomination was not a mean achievement, considering the caliber of the members of the delegation, which included people like Bukar Dipcharima and Mrs. Funmilayo Ransome Kuii. Thai delegation in itself represented a high point in Nigerian nationalism. Pelewura was a legend. Her episode in Nigerian political history is a clear evidence that not only were the women acutely aware of the political and economic frustrations of the colonial period and ihcy were aware that they had leaders who were capable of leading them in times of crisis. If her demise created a vacuum for the Lagos market women, she did not leave a vacuum in Nigeria politics. It is true that she had blazed the trail but people like Mrs. Funmilayo Ransome-Kuti and Margret Ekpo were on the wings to pick up the gauntlet.

**Nigerian Women in the Era of Decolonisation.**

The period between 1945 and 1960 was the era of decolonization in Nigeria-period during which the British began to hand over power to Nigerians through a slow process. This period saw the emergency of nationalist movements in the form of political parties in the country. Some of them took the bullby the horns. They were nolonger satisfied with playing the role of kingmakers or powers behind thrones. Among the front-liners in this crusade were Mrs. Margaret Ekpo, Mrs. Olufunmilayo Ransome-Kuti, Miss Aduni Oluwole, Mrs. Wuraola Esan, Mrs. Janet Mokelu, Lady Abayomi Oyinkan, Alhaja Gambo Sawaba and Madam Ekpo Young. Most of these women politicians were either active members of the defunct political parties or leaders of the women's wings of the parties.

The first Nigerian female politician to be lected into a legislative assembly in this country was Mrs. Margaret Ekpo, who was a Home Economics graduate and a renowned teacher.[19] Mrs. Ekpo organized the Aba Women's Association. She was a fierce opponent of colonislism and a strong advocate in demanding equal rights for Nigerian women. In 1945, JANET Okala formed the Enugu Women's Association. She and Ekpo worked hand in hand with Kuti to organize strikes and demonstration against objectionable government policies. She had joined the NCNC in 1944 as one of the foundation members. She was appointed a Special Member of the Eastern House of Assembly. This was an unprecedented feat in Nigerian political history. She achieved this through the dint of hard work. Like Mrs. Kuti, she was pan-Nigeria in her political outlook. Mrs. Ekpo was a member of the NCNC delegation to the Nigerian Constitutional talks in 1953, 1957 and 1958 both in London and Lagos.[20] Sola Balogun has summarized the achievements of Mrs. Ekpo for us. His words:

*As a leader nationalist and defender of women's rights Mrs Ekpo main achievement is her courage and ability to keep the woemen together as well as encouraging them to imbibe the spirit of nationalism. Essentially, Ekpo succeeded inmaking the women aware of their rights. S he also taught them how to protect and defend their rights.*[21]

Like Mrs. Ekpo, Mrs. Ransome-Kuti was heart and soul in Nigeria politics. A graduate of Home Econimics from Britain, she was a teacher herself and also a proprietress. The first attempt at a formal women's association was made by Mrs. Kuti when she inaugurated the Abeokuta Ladies Club. Initially the Club organized lessons for the non-literate Egba market women. Members of the Club concerned themselves with the imposition and increase of taxes on women and objected strongly against the Sole Native Authority system. Mrs. Kuti was deeply interested in the provison of increased facilities for the enlightenment of women. Mrs. Kuti was a fearless and rugged fighter and was a petrel of Nigeran politics. She was one of the foundation members of thedefunct NCNC when it was founded in 1944. She was the President of the Women's Wing of the NCNC in the former Western Region and the President General of the Nigerian Women's Council and also the Treasurer of the NCNC seven-man delegation sent to London in 1947 to protest against the Richards Consitution.

Mrs. Ransome-Kuti's foray into Nigerian politics was not smooth sailing. It was fraught with hazards, and embarrassments. She was persecuted and her movermnets in and outside Nigeria were under very close surveillance by government security agents. She was even denied freedom of movement and association. For instance, in 1958, the Government of Nigeria flagrantlyrefused to issue a passport toher to travel to England. When the issue was raised on March 3, 1958 in the House of Representatives by Mr. J. A. O. Akande, member for Egha North in that House, the Prime Minister, TafawaBalewa stated that as a matter of policy, passports were usually refused persons who wished to visit countries behind the Iron Curtain, where they might become involved in Communist activities and that access to Comnumisi countries was not in the interest of Nigeria.[23]

To support his allegation of Mrs. Ransome-Kuti's contacts with the Communist World, Balewa informed members of the House ol Representatives that since 1945, she had been reported to have had contacts with several Communist organizations, including the Women's International Democratic Federation of which she became Vice President in 1952. Balewa went further to tell the House of how Mrs. Ransome-Kuti was invited to a peace Congress in Vienna and subsequently to a meeting of the Women's International Democratic Federation at the expense of these organizations, which were Communist. Balewa said that when in April 1954, a professional Communist Women's Organizer visited Nigeria for forty-eight hours; she called on Mrs. Ransome-Kuti twice. Balewa recalled that in May 1955, Mrs. Ransome-Kuti and two other women planned to attend a meeting of the World Assembly of Peace at Helsinki in Finland, an Assembly which was a Communist Front Organization and that she also wished to visit Russia and China. Balewa added that Mrs. Ransome-Kuti went to England in April 1956 from where she went to Europe and China and attended a Council meeting of Women's International Democratic Federation in Peking, at which it was alleged that she stated: "Women in Nigeria had never ceased fighting for then-rights during the last ten years."[24]

On the particular occasion, when Mrs. Ransome-Kuti's request for a passport was refused, Balewa, while explaining the reason for this, alleged that even though, she said she was traveling on health grounds, she had been offered a return air ticket to travel to East Berlin. Balewa accused her of not only being aware of the Communist nature of her contacts abroad, but also of her determination to go to any length in order to achieve her personal ideals. The Prime Minister then Federal and the Regional Governments of Nigeria would use cvci v means in their power to prevent the infiltration of Communism and Communist ideas into Nigeria.[25]

Mrs. Raiisoinc-Kuti's explanation to the effect that she was not interested in Communism hut that she had merely visited China and Berlin several times to attend meetings of women organisations did not impress Balewa and his government. She was denied the passport and she could not travel. This traumatic experience did no deter her from pursuing her objectives as vigorously as possible. In 1959, Mrs. Ransome-Kuti contested the election into the house of Representatives as an independent candidate in Abeokuta when the NCNC refused to adopt her as the official party candidate.[26] But she diil not succeed.

Back at home in Abeokuta her political exploits could not easily be forgotten. Here, she led the women to fight for the promotion of their economic and social wellbeing and also to secure their emancipation. On April 28, 1948, Mrs. Ransome-Kuti led an irate crown of Ijebu and Egba Women, who for five long hours barricaded the streets of the ancient city of Abeokuta, protesting vehemently against the three shillings flat rate tax imposed on the women of Ijebu-Ode and Abeokua by the Native Authorities in both cities. The angry women demanded the immediate removal of the Alake of Abeokuta, Oba Ladapo Ademola II, who they alleged, collaborated with N. A. officials to auction and appropriate the proceeds from the food item confiscated from the market women. The protesting women were particularly infuriated by the debasement and dehumanization by the notorious rate collectors, who they alleged often chased and stripped women naked in the streets to ascertain whether they were old enough to pay tax or not. The women further complained that the money realized from taxes was never spent on the welfare and education of their children.[27] At the front of the Alake's palace, the women performed mock funeral rites of the Alake and sang abusive and death songs.[28] At the end of the day the women, who were until that time the only Nigerian women, who paid poll tax, won. The Alake lost hands down. He was smuggled out of Abeokuta to Osogbo, where he was in exile until 1950.[29] It was Mrs. Ransome-Kuti's greatest hour of triumph. She

had emerged as the great liberator of the oppressed Egba andljebu women. The flat rale lax was abolished and the Sole Native Administration System was replaced by the Fgba Council, which became the new Native Authority. The lit'ha women were ivprcsenlcd on the Council by four of their members. Mba was so impressed by this development that she wrote:

By *the admission of women into the Council, Egba Women were reintegrated into participation in the executive organ of government for the first time since pre-colonial days. Egba women regained a power base in their society, with the capacity to influence the whole society, not just the women. The participation was by no means equal to that of the men, but at least it was a departure from the colonial policies of excluding women.*[30]

Although Mrs. Funmilayo Ransome-Kuti's attempt to form a political party of her own did not materialize, she had made an impressive and indelible contribution to the development of political consciousness among Nigerian women. According to Akinniyi Sowunmi, Mrs. Kuti was "the mother ol' nationalist struggle against the British colonial arrangement in Nigeria...."[31]

In one respect, Miss Aduni Oluwole went a step further than Mrs. Ransome-Kuti, by successfully forming her own party. Miss Oluwole, who hailed from Ibadan, in Oyo State, formed her Nigerian Commoners Liberal Party at Mushin in 1954, thus becoming the first Nigerian female politician to found a serious political party.[32] In the same year also, G. Olateju, a pensioner and cocoa fanner formed the Nigerian Liberty Party, which soon merged with Miss Oluwole's party. The Nigerian Commoners Liberal Party itself affiliated with the NCNC.

The marriage between the two parties did not last because Adunni did not agree with the ideology of the NCNC. She believed that what the NCNC was struggling for was not a real and true independence, but neo-colonialism, which was a grave charge against the NCNC. Adunni was a woman of great courage ad iron determination. As a totally detribalized Nigerian-woman, from an Akure constituency, she contested the 1956 election into the Western House of Assembly and lost.[33]

This was not surprising as winning an election in Nigeria usually cost a lot of money, which Adunni did not have. She contested that election m the lace of many odds. This writer attended some of Adunni's political rallies, which often pulled mammoth crowds of youths and at which marathon speeches, castigating the leaders of the other political parties and the colonial rulers, were made. Even though, she lost the 1956 election, yet she remained as resolute and as determined as ever. Adunni died of a tetanus infection in 1957 while campaigning for her party.

No account of the political activities of Nigerian women will be complete without a discussion of the important role played by the irrepressible Alhaja (Malama) Gambo Sawaba. Her experience in certain respect was different from that of other women politicians in Nigeria. Her father came from Ghana and her mother hailed from Bida and she lived in Zaria, in Northern Nigeria. She once described herself in the following terms. "From the beginning I went radical. I know definitely I am a radical, a no-nonsense radical."[34] She entered polities at the age of 17 years and went to jail for the first time at the age 18, which was most unusual. She spent three months of political tutelage under Mrs. I'uninilayo Ransome-Kuti. She later acquired more political education under Aminu Kano at the "NEPU" School of Agnation and Propaganda" between 1951 and 1952. She vigorously championed the cause of women in Northern Nigeria where she agitated for female franchise, she condemned the marriage of girls who were under age and the use of forced labour. She was also a great advocate of Western education in the North.

In 1953, she organized the inaugural meeting of the women's wing of the NEPU in Kano. She was arrested with other two hundred women for not obtaining a permit for the meeting. They were charged to an Alkali Court, which sentenced them to a month in prison each. Alhaja Sawaba was subsequently imprisoned on many occasions. In fact, it is said that she went to prison sixteen times and usually on trumped up charges. On several occasions, she was brutalized by the police.[35] On the one particular occasion, she was deported from the city of Kano as a troublemaker. In 1956, she served half of a six-month prison sentence before the

conviction was reversed by a Northern High Court.[36] In July '1958, during its second Congress the women's wing of the NEPU decided to affiliate with the All-Nigerian Women's Union under the leadership of Mrs. Ransome-Kuti. Sawaba was a woman of great courage, when we take into account the harsh and feudalistic repressive atmosphere of Northern Region.

**Nigerian Women in the Politics of the Second Republic**

During the last stage of the transition to civil rule particularly between 1978 and 1979, Nigerian women began to show an increasing political awareness. One clear indication of this development was the fact that over twenty-four million women registered to vote.[37] This is an all time record in Nigerian history. Shortly, after the ban on political activities was lilted some prominent Nigerian women joined the newly formed political parties. It appeared that they were ready to fill the vacuum left by women like Ransome-Kuti and Adunni Oluwole. Among these women were Mrs. Regina Agbakoba, Oyinbo Odmamadu, Lei la Dongonyaro, Madam Jolubu, Madam Anya Tyozua, Janet Akinrinade, Hajiya Ashama, Bimbo Akintola, Ebun Oyagbola, Helix, Murume and Bola Ogunbo. Some of them even attempted to form their own political parties.

Mrs. Odmainadu, who was one of the National Vice-Presidents of the then Awolowo's Unity Party of Nigeria (UPN) for Anambra State, was nominated as her party's candidate for the post of the Deputy Governor of that State. She was a woman of sterling qualities and highly principled. It needed a lot of courage to belong to the UPN in a hostile environment like Anambra State, she had been the State President of the National Council of Women Societies since its inauguration. She was a renowned school-teacher. Like Odinamadu, Bola Ogunbo was picked as presidential running mate for the Peoples Redemption Party.

In the old Oyo State, there was the late Mrs. Janet Adefenwa Akinrinade, a charming, astute and dynamic woman. She was theonly woman elected into the then Constituent Assembly in 1978. She had earlier won (he Local Government Chairmanship Election in Oyo North, from where she hailed. Between 1979 and 1981, she was the Minister of State for Internal Affairs. As a leading member of the Nigerian Peoples Party, she was the Commissioner for Internal Affairs in Plateau State between 1981 and 1983. As a frontline activist in her party, she became the Deputy Governor in the old Oyo State in 1983. Her excellent performances are worthy of emulation by other women in Nigeria politics. She was the leading member of the Nigeria People Party (NPP). She was one of the Nigerian women who felt that women should no longer sit back and watch the menfolk mislead and misgovern the country. She believed that the old politicians should get out of politics before they were given the boot. In the 1976 Local Government Elections in Abuja, Hajiya Ashama floored the then Chairman of the Caretaker Committee of the Abuja Local Government, Alhaji Muhammadu Gambo, who was a diploma and a member of the dissolved Constituent Assembly.[38] This was regarded as a big achievement. While Franca Alegbua got elected into the senate; Bimbo Akintola and Ebun Oyegbola were appointed Ministers in the Second Republic.

The fact that no other political party founded by a woman in Nigeria has ever succeeded, did not deter Mrs. Agbakoba and Miss Feliz Murtune from trying. In 1978 these two women made desperate efforts to form two political parties, which they named Women's National Party and National Democratic Action party. But because of the almost insurmountable obstacles put in the way of new parties, the parties were not regi stcred by the FEDECO. Whether the parties were registered or not, the two women will go down in the history of Nigerian politics as the only women who tried to organize political parties in 1978. Mrs. Agbakoba strongly believed that for women to achive the deserved recognition they ought to organize themselves in such a manner by which their sheer number would make it possible for a people-oriented political party to be voted into power in the Federal and Stale legislatures.

**Conclusion**

For the Nigerian women, their adventure in the Nigerian political terrain has been long, rough, tough, tedious and tortuous. They have responded admirably to the arrogance of a male chauvinistic and hostile environment in various ways and places. The unconquerable Madam Tinubu was able to weather the political storm as a power broker in Lagos and Abeokuta while Pelewura fearlessly defended the right of Lagos women with her

might and main. The Aba Women's Revolt of 1929, which among other things sought the termination of colonial rule in Nigeria, led to a drastic reform of the Indirect Rule System. The Abeokuta and Ijebu-Ode demonstrations of 1948 led by the lion-hearted Ransome-Kuti resulted in abdication of the throne by the all-powerful and influential Alake of Egbaland. These memorable events had set precedents. Thereafter, the struggle to elevate the status of women in the Nigerian society has become a continuous process. This process has been kept going by women like Gambo Sawaba, Aduni Oluwole, Leila Dogonyaro, Margaret Ekpo and many others.

Women in modern Nigerian can no longer plead lack of precedents and role models. All over the world women have broken into areas that used to be the exclusive preserve of men. Here and there women have achieved monumental success. Take for example the election of Lady Margaret Thatcher as the Prime Minister of Conservative Britain for three consecutive terms or Indira Ghandi, who was the Prime Minister of India for ten years. In the same way Gaolda Meir served as the Prime Minister of Israel, Corazon Aquino was the Prime Minister of the Philippines and Tajah Halonen had served as the Prime Minister of Finland. Megawatti is currently the Prime Minister of Indonesia, which is reputed to be the largest Muslim country in the world. The notable achievements of these indomitable and irresistible women should serve as signposts that women have surely arrived. Even here is Nigeria there are numerous women who have reached the top of the ladder in academic, commerce and other professions: Zulu Sofola did not mince words when she stated that if Nigerian women moved mountains in the past, there is no reason why they cannot move them today.[39] However, Nigerian women have to realize that in the realm of politics there are no more free lunches. They should be ready to fight their way to the top, enduring bruises and scars.

**Notes**

1. R. C. Abraham, *A Dictionary of Modern Yoruba* (London: University Press, 1953), p. 279.
2. J. O. Atandare, *Itan Akure ati Agbegbe Re* (Akure, Duduyemi Press, 1973), pp, 26, 36, and 52.
3. R. S. Smith, *Kingdoms of the Yoruba* (London, Methuen and Coy. Ltd. 1974), p. 74.
4. The administration of prc-colonial Akure was not the exclusive responsibility of the men, women also took active part. There were three important groups of women chiefs. These groups were known as the Apate, the Ukoju and the Esare (the selected).
5. S. O. Biobaku, "Madam Tinubu" in K. Dike (ed.) *Eminent Nigerians of the 19th Century* (London, Cambridge University Press, 1960), pp. 33-40.
6. *Ibid.*, p. 34
7. *Ibid.*, p. 35
8. *Ibid.*, p. 37
9. *Ibid., p. 39*
10. A. E.Afigbo, "Revolution and Reaction in Eastern Nigeria, 1900-1929.*"Journal of Historical Society of Nigeria,* Vol. 3, No. 3, December 1966, pp. 339-557.
11. *Ibid., p.* 557
12. Macaulay qualified as a civil engineer and surveyor in 1893 and was appointed Surveyor of Crown Lands for the Colony of Lagos. He resigned from that post in 1898. He was the most outstanding figure in Nigerian politics throughout his life. For nearly 40 years he agitated against the Colonial Government in Nigeria. For more information about Macaulay, see I. B. Thomas, Life of Herbert Macaulay (Lagos, Tika-Tore Press, 1947). Teken.

# 6

## AN OVERVIEW OF THE NATURE AND CHARACTER OF MILITARY RULE IN NIGERIA

GBOYEGA AJAYI

**Introduction**

In the early hours of 15th January 1966, a bloody military coup was executed which unseated the first civilian administration in independent Nigeria. The military putsch, masterminded by Major C. K. Nzeogwu, claimed the lives of the Prime Minister, Alhaji Abuhakar TafawaBalewa; the Premier of the Northern Region, Alhaji Ahmadu Bello; that of the Western Region, Chief Ladoke Akintola; the Minister for Finance, Chief Festus Okotie-Eboh; and, some high ranking military officers, mostly of Northern extraction.[1] Unfortunately for the coup plotters, the coup failed in the Eastern Region and Lagos - the seat of the Federal Government. Thus they were unable to secure total control of the country. For the records, it was the Chief of Army Staff, Major General Aguiyi Ironsi, who foiled the attempt in Lagos and subsequently became the Head of State.[2]

Ironsi was in office until the 29th of July 1966 when he was assassinated in a counter-coup which brought Lt. Col. (later General) Yakubu Gowon to power. Gowon was in office for nine years (1966-1975) before he was supplanted by another military regime headed by Brigadier (later General) Muritala Mohammed. Significantly the change of government was effected in a bloodless manner. I lowever, Mohammed was in office for barely six months before he was felled by the assassins' bullets on the 13th of February 1976, in an abortive coup attempt. His second-in-command, Lt. Gen. Olusegun Obasanjo, stepped into his shoes and steadfastly implemented the regime's laid out programmes up to 1st of October 1979 when power was transferred to civilians. But the civilian administration of Alhaji Shehu Shagari lasted for only four years and three months before it_was toppled by yet another military coup on the 31st of December 1983.

The new military administration headed by Major General Muhammadu Buhari was itself supplanted in office by General Ibrahim Babangida (IBB), the erstwhile Chief of Army Staff, on 27th August 1985, through a palace coup. IBB managed to retain office for eight years through deft manoeuvres reminiscent of the Machiavellian Prince.[3] The Interim National Government (ING) to which he handed over power, following the unwarranted annulment of the June 12 1993 presidential election, which would have concluded the transition.[4] did not endure. It lasted between 26th August and 17th November 1993 when it fell victim of yet another military coup masterminded by General Sanni Abacha, the erstwhile second-in-command in the ING contraption. Abacha was

in office until June 1998 when he died in controversial circumstances. The rump of his administration now headed by General Abdulsalam Abubakar remained in office until May 29th 1999 when it handed over power to the democratically elected civilian regime of retired General Olusegun Obasanjo.

We have gone to this extent of giving a somewhat chronological detail of military regimes in order to imprint at the back of our minds the fact of the military's strong grip over Nigerian politics. In fact, between 1966 and 1999 there were only two brief periods of civilian interregnum; first, between 1979 and 1983, and, second, for three months in 1993. It is also necessary to establish a background for a fuller discussion of the performance of the military in government. Rather than a discriminatory epochal treatment, all the regimes will be taken together in the descriptive analysis that follows. The informing sensibility here is that fundamentally there was continuity (in terms of structure and disposition) under military dispensations in Nigeria. The minor changes (mainly in terms of leadership style and affectations) were superficial and so inconsequential. But where and when necessary examples of specific regimes will be invoked to buttress our position. In order to avoid repetitions, a thematic (rather than narrative) approach is employed in this work. Thus the following themes are slated for discussion.

(i) Circumstances Leading to Military Intervention in Nigerian Politics;
(ii) Structure and Disposition of Military Administration in Nigeria; and,
(iii) Some Legacies of Military Rule.

These shall be addressed in the order in which they are listed before rounding off with some concluding remarks.

**i. Circumstances Leading to Military Intervention in Nigerian Politics.**

Generally, the reasons for military intervention in politics have been dealt with by many authors. But some of the proffered reasons are of limited application. In the case of Nigeria, for instance, theories that portray soldiers as modernisers[5] puritans[6] and patriots[7] cannot be sustained by available evidences. This, therefore, calls for an indepth study of particular situations with emphasis on the peculiar circumstances warranting or paving way for military intervention. In the Nigeria of 1966 such circumstances were characterized by unmet rising expectations (based on campaign promises); corrupt and inept leadership; and general systemic decay. For the records, the Northern People's Congress (NPC) in coalition with the National Council of Nigerian Citizens (NCNC) was in control of political power during the First Republic (1960-1966) while the Action Group (AG) acted as the opposition party in the parliamentary system of government that was operated then. These three parties were the majority parties which were, either by accident or design, regionally-based.[8] There were also nine other minority parties operating in the regions. Significantly none of the parties (majority or minority) had sufficient political clout to win a national election single - handedly. The situation warranted the initiation of alliances amongst the political parties. Thus, on the eve of the 1964/65 federal elections the twelve active parties had coalesced into two major alliances. These were the Nigeria National Alliance (NNA) and the United Progressive Grand Alliance (UPGA). The NNA, made up chiefly of the NPC (the senior partner in the two - party coalition government of the first republic); the United Peoples' Party -UPP (a breakaway faction of the AG); the Dynamic Party; and the Midwest Democratic Party (MDP), used the power of incumbency and other ruthless devices to manipulate the election in its favour.[9] This development sowed the seed of crises and political instability which threatened the corporate existence of the country. But it was the western regional election of 1965 and the role of the federal government in it that actually sounded the death - knell of the first republic. It will be recalled that the NPC - controlled Federal Government backed the Nigerian National Democratic Party (NNDP) - a coalition party of a breakaway faction of AG and the NPC- in the blatant rigging of the election.[10] Predictably this generated more serious crisis leading to a complete breakdown of law and order. In fact there was organized destruction of lives and properties on a large - scale under the infamous" Operation *We tie* - (local reference to arson).

The federal government's nonchalant attitude to this ugly development did not help matters. Perhaps it felt that the situation was too parochial to warrant federal intervention or may be it saw in the situation an opportunity to destabilize the opposition and thereby gain permanent political foothold in that region. Whatever the case may he, the lukewarm attitude of the government to the security and political fortunes of the western region made it more unpopular and uncaring. This and the frequent use of the military to clamp down on pcrceived opposition

groups "made it clear to those soldiers who cared to think about it that the survival of the existing political order depended upon them.[11]

Thus the weakening in legitimacy of the civilian government beginning from its role in the AG crisis of 1962/63; the jailing of some notable leaders of the AG on trumped - up charges in 1963[12]; the census crisis of 1962/63; the general strike of 1964; and, which reached its culmination in the electoral crises of 1965 created the opportunity for military intervention in politics. Thus, when the military intervened the circumstances were quite auspicious. The civilian rulers had proved incapable of carrying the burdens of statescraft while the people had become disillusioned and apathetic. In sharp contrast to the malaise afflicting the civil society, the military organization appeared to be apolitical, nationalistic and disciplined. Bui the reality of the situation, which unfortunately was not open to the generality of the people then, was that the military had been politicized th rough the quota system of recruitment[13] and its invidious use by civilians to suppress civil unrests.[14]

Thus, unwary Nigerians enthusiastically welcomed the coup, especially in the southern parts of the country. Even the North which was initially indifferent, and later antagonistic, to the emergent regime would most probably have supported the change of government if it had been effected without bloodshed and ethnic undertones. The incontrovertible fact is that the civilian administration of the First Republic had lost legitimacy and so was ripe for the picking when the coup took place.

The counter-coup that followed six months thereafter was executed from all intent and purposes, to restore the political balance in favour of the North which had lost the cream of her political and military elite in the dastardly act of January 15. Significantly the counter-coup put in place a military regime indicating the loss of confidence in the civilian ruling elite. This supports our earlier submission that the civilian regime had been discredited across the country. However, the military regime, after an impressive start, exemplified chiefly by the successful prosecution of the civil war, soon started bungling like the civilian government it replaced. It was when its credibility was seriously at stake that a palace coup was executed in July 1975 to revamp the 'corrective regime' image, which it had carved for itself.[15] By the time the military handed overpower to civilians in 1979 it was hoped that we would have seen the end of military political adventurism. But this was not to be. The Second Republic was virtually a re-enactment of the evils of the First thereby creating a supportive environment for the return of the supposedly corrective military. Thereafter many other military juntas seized power, as we have noted previously or attempted to seize power (the failed coup attempts) not so much for the desire to offer a better alternative but mainly for self-aggrandizement. This therefore puts question marks on the often stated mission of the military in politics as a corrective agency or reactive intcrvener. [16] The long stay of the military in power and the deliberate institutionalization of certain self-serving structures and procedures have not only exposed the lie in the supposedly transient nature of military rule but also impacted negatively on its performance in office. This shall be addressed in greater details in the section below.

**ii Structure and Disposition of Military Administration in Nigeria.**

The basic structure of military administration in Nigeria was a pyramidal arrangement with the leader of the coup plotters, or their representative, and a clique of trusted compatriots constituting a council at the apex. This superordinate Military Council was known at different limes as Supreme Military Council (SMC); Armed Forces Ruling Council (AFRC); National Defence and Security Council (NDSC); and, Provisional Ruling Council (PRC). In theory this was the highest ruling body but under some regimes, like those of Generals Buhari, IBB and Abacha, it was merely a rubber stamp for validating the whims and caprices of the commander-in-chief. Next in the hierarchy was the Federal Executive Council - a purely advisory body to which the ministers and other high-ranking bureaucrats belonged. This was replicated at the state level where there was the State Executive Council performing similar functions for the military governor. At the Federal level there was also the Council of State to which all the military governors belonged. This was more like a feedback organ through which the Federal Military Government (FMG) felt the pulse of the people and passed instructions down to them.

The system of government was federal, having a recognized center alongside with federating states and local

government councils. But it was a peculiar form of federalism in which the center was stronger and more preponderant than all the federating states and local councils put together. In fact, it was more of a regimental arrangement in which order came from the center and unquestioning obedience from the subordinate units. This stifling arrangement did not give room for local initiatives that would have fostered development at the grassroot level.

Furthermore, revenue allocation formulae under different regimes were also skewed infavour of the FMG at the centre. The previous practice, during the First Republic, of allowing the Federating regions tohave control over revenue generation and appropriation, was dispensed with when Gowon ascended to power. Ever since successive military regimes entrenched a new arrangement by which the FMG transferred revenue to the states through the Distributable Pool Account (DPA)[17] which it controlled exclusively. This gabe the military rulers profound clout; for 'he who pays the piper dicates the tune'.

There were even some deliberate attempts to militarize the Nigerian polity in ordr to prolong military rule. This came in the form of indiscriminate issuance and ruthless execution of decrees and the suspension or abrogation of certain sections of theextant consistution. There was also the establishment of military tribunals; sustencance ofhighly dreaded state security apparatuses; and, the regular employment of coercive and repressive methods to cow-down the citizenry and suppress civil organizations like Trade Unions, Human Rights and Pro-Democracy groups, the Press etc. In these diverse ways the democratic space was constricted. It is ironical that it was under this uncertain atmosphere that most military regimes purported to effect a transfer of powr to civilians. We have observed elsewhere that:

*...as a result of the vested interests of themilitary sponsors of the tansisition programme and the self-seeking orientation of their civilian collaborators, the political environment was walways crisis-laden. The military then waited in the wings watching out for the usual promptings from the disillusioned segments of the society before staging a reluctant comeback.*[18]

The situation decribed above has been aptly tagged the "handback option"[19] In short the transition was largely a ruse, cleverly contrived to elongate military rule in a surreptitious manner. We recongnise thefact that themilitary had handed over poer to civilians since 1999 and it ha not staged a comeback yet. This has been the case because the cirumtances are not yet auspicious if the following statement by retired General Babangida is anything to go by. He remarked in a press interview, that "(We) in themilitary are very smart people, we wouldn't interfere in government when we know it has the support of the populace."[20] We can also add that some legacies of Nigerians. We shall proceed to elaborate on this presently.

**iii. Some Legacies of Military Rule**

Up to 1979 the military in Nigeria had a track record of some good political performances. The military has been credited with the creation of states ostensibly to enhance the nation's federal status. But it must be noted that the state creation exercises led to the balkanization of the polity and progressively weakened the position of the polyglot states vis-à-vis that of the federal military government at the center. In fact the center grew strongly at the expense of the states. This was a peculiar form of federalism. The military also expended a lot of money on the contrusction of roads, airport, seaports, massive agricultural projects (like the Operation Feed the Nation – OFN, and the River Basin Development Authorities) and rural development programmes (like the Directorate of Food, Roads and Rural Infrastructure – DFRRI). But there is little to show for the huge investments on these projects. The projects actually served as avenues for corrupt enrichment for privileged members of the ruling class (military and civilian). However, there were the successful prosecution of the civil war without incurring and debt (foreign or domestic); instituonalization of potentially integrative cross-cultural devices like the National Youth Service Corps (NYSC) scheme, National Sports Festival, National Festuvak of Arts and Culture, and, the transfer of powr to civilians in 1979. But all these were achieved at considerable cost. We must also remember that it was at this period that corruption started assuming gargantuan proportions and the proceeds of the frtuitous. 'Oil boom' were recklessly spent without improving the living standards of the pople. Also the craze for foreign goods and services became well established and the various indigenization

schemes were short-circuited. The above notwithstanding, the departing military rulers in 1979 were still held in high esteem.

However, by the time of the lasl handover of power to civilians in 1999 the generality of the people in Nigeria had become disenchanted with military rule largely because of its overall noxious impact on the polity. It has entrenched a culture of violence, authoritarianism, massive corruption in high and low places,[2I] and left behind a depressed and prostrate economy through ineptitude, instability and impious experimentations.[2] Significantly the national currency was progressively debased. It also bequeathed to the nation ethno-religious crises and a badly ruptured polity - consequences of the divide and rule tactics of some military rulers.

In particular, the infamous Abacha regime did more to discredit military rule in the way and manner it handled state affairs as well as its ruthless treatment of anti-military social forces and other perceived opposition elements[23] The National Democratic Coalition (NADECO) was particularly singled out for annihilation because of its robust pro - democracy stand. Under him, the military virtually became an army of occupation which ruthlessly pillaged the nation's resources while subjecting the citizenry to abject poverty and squalor. Abacha single-handedly amassed enough wealth to make the fabled oil sheikhs feel inferior. His death offered a convenient opportunity for the now d i scredi led mi Htary to look for a dignified exit from the political terrain.

Consequently, the new regime of Gen. Abubakar executed the shortest transition programme ever in the history of Nigeria.[24] This culminated in the transfer of power to the civilian regime of retired General Olusegun Obasanjo. Obasanjo's antecedent as a former military head of state who transferred power to civilians as promised, albeit in controversial circumstances,[23] his rising profile as an international figure since retirement and his ordeal under the infamous Abacha regime[26] made his election acceptable to some people and at least, tolerable for others.

He showed a clear perception of the mood of the nation through his initial 'anti-military' moves. These ranged from the mundane gesture of jettisoning his military rank of 'General' in favour of the more civil title of ‘Chief to the more telling compulsory retirement of some military officers who had held political appointments under military regimes. These moves sent the right signals to the right quarters. But it must be clearly spelt out that the best antidote against military comeback to politics is good governance based on equity, justice and fairplay; and marked improvement in the quality of life of the people.

**Concluding Remarks**

One continuous thread that has run through this chapter is the issue of 'performance'. When the First and Second Republics under the civilians did not perform well they lost legitimacy and thereby paved way for military rule. And, as a result of the overall shoddy performance of most military regimes, military rule also lost credibility with time. The nature and disposition of military rule in Nigeria were such that it could hardly be described as an aberration or a short-term expediency. Over the years it became so seriously entrenched in power that it began to see itself as an alternative government. Bui it was more appropriately a political usurper because it overshot iis legal limits as the protector of the nation's territorial integrity. By dabbling into politics for such a length of time its professional status was adversely affected. This development also created deep cleavages within the organization. The recurrent nature of coups, countercoups, abortive coups and rumours of impending coups clearly illustrate the extent of the cleavages. More importantly they engendered instability leading to political atrophy and economic underdevelopment. The cumulative effect of all these was that military rule became increasingly unpopular. Needless to say that all these did not augur well for military rule.

It is our hope that the present civilian dispensation and others yet to follow would have learnt some useful lessons concerning the significance of performance in a development-hungry polity like ours. Thus, all known impediments to good performance, like unwarranted party squabbles, political distractions, corruption, nepotism, intolerance, ethno-religious crises, election rigging and mediocrity must be curtailed and contained in the nation's interest. The fact that military rule no longer enjoys popular support should not encourage nonchalance for, as noted previously, the best antidote against military rule is good governance based on equity, justice, fairplay and better living

standard for the people.

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## A SURVEY OF DEMOCRATIC ELECTIONS IN NIGERIA SINCE 1979

**MICHAEL M. OGBEIDI**

### INTRODUCTION

This chapter intends to discuss a short history of the electioneering process in Nigeria since 1979. It proceeds to give a brief background of democratic practices in the country. The chapter will also attempt to explain the meaning, nature and form of electoral malpractices in Nigeria. The resultant crisis and the way forward for the Nigerian polity shall also be brought under focus. Democracy can be defined as the system of electing representatives into government through the ballot box, it has been described as the best form of governance because it enables both the majority and minority to have their say and to have their rights protected.[1] Available records have shown that the greatest problem of Nigeria's democracy has been the issue of credible elections. Past attempts at sustainable democracy failed because of fraud associated with elections in Nigeria.[2]

Electoral malpractices are palpable illegalities committed with a corrupt, fraudulent or sinister intention to influence an election in favour of a candidate(s) by means such as illegal voting, bribery, cheating and undue influence, intimidation and other acts of coercion exerted on voters, falsification of results, fraudulent announcement of a defeated candidate as the winner (with/without altering the recorded results). The serious problem posed by election rigging stems more from its insidiousness. It is perpetrated in the private homes of individuals and in great secrecy, which effectively shields it from the prying eyes of election observer teams and which adds to the difficulties of proving it in a court of law.[3]

Republic (1960-1966) collapsed like a pack of cards due to several factors which made it unworkable. First, politicians lacked the political discipline required to make democracy work. Second, they failed to imbibe the political ethos that would have brought about a difference in the political struggle. Thirdly, the electoral body (the Federal Electoral Commission) was not seen as an impartial body which even caused the entire process to break down fastly. In fact, it was for the above reasons that the coup of January 1966 was welcomed by the larger public. The military which took over power held unto it until 1978 when the former Head of State, General Olusegun Obasanjo inaugurated a Constitution Drafting Committee (CDC) headed by a Lagos-based legal practitioner, Chief Rotimi Williams, to draw up guidelines for a Constituent Assembly. The final draft of the Constitution by the Assembly was adopted as the 1979 Constitution.[4]

The 1979 Constitution provided for an executive president, a Federal Senate and House of Representatives, state governors and state legislators. The government also established a Federal Electoral Commission (FEDECO) to conduct elections. Some of the guidelines set out for political parties intended to overcome the shortcomings of the First Republic included; that to qualify for registration, a political party must demonstrate an effective nation-wide presence by having functional offices in 13 of the then existing 19 states. This was to ensure that the support base of the political parties cut across ethnic and regional lines, and to prevent the emergence of regionally, or ethnically-based parties. A second major electoral reform was that the person to be elected must have the highest number of votes cast in addition to receiving at least, 25 percent of the votes cast in two-thirds of the 19 states.[5]

Following the laid-down guidelines, FEDECO registered five political parties which included the Unity Part of Nigeria (UPN), the National Party of Nigeria (NPN), the Nigeria Peoples Party (NPP), the People's Redemption Party (PRP) and the Great Nigeria People's Party (GNPP). The 1979 constitution was a departure from the parliamentary system of government operated after independence. However, about fifty political parties emerged for the purpose of elections in 1979 but only five satisfied registration requirements.[6]

The 1979 elections surprised many watchers of the Nigerian polity particularly those who were cynical about the ability of Nigeria organise a successful election for various stages of political governance inspite of the fact that the country was at its infancy in computer literacy. The 1979 election was unique in that it was the first series of elections held successfully on the basis of mass participation and direct balloting since the 1964 and 1965 federal and regional elections both of which ended in controversy. Though, there was a local government election in 1976, it did not evoke mass participation and interest because the Nigerian electorate then did not attach much importance to the new local government structures. Also the Constituent Assembly of 1977 was conducted through local government representatives who constituted the electoral colleges. This election did not carry the people along as.it did not involve mass participation in contest and voting.[7]

The 1979 election was not crisis free. The Federal Electoral Commission released the list of registered voters on Wednesday, March 29, 1978 in which a total of 47,433,757 voters were registered. In the Presidential election, 16,846,633 votes were casted representing 34.64 percent votes. The NPN won $12^2/_3$ of the votes cast in 19 states of the federation. It won 203 seats in the Federal Legislature and seven governorship seats. The UPN led by Chief Obafemii Awolowo came second with 138 seats in the Federal Legislature and five governors. Awolowo went to court to challenge the results of the elections. He alleged that the presidential election was rigged. However, the Supreme Court declared that the NPN led by Alhaji Shehu Shagari as President had satisfied the constitutional and geographical requirements. Alhaji Shagari was therefore declared as constitutionally elected. He assume office on

October 1, 1979 as President.[8]

The formation of political parties, campaign and voting during the 1979 elections was by and large designed along ethnic affiliation, and political participation was more on ethnic spheres. Although the rules compelled political parties to make their interest and representation national, essentially most Nigerians queued behind parties which they identified with their regional or ethnic regions. Thus, the Yoruba of the south-west lined up behind Chief Obafemi Awolowo of the Unity Party of Nigeria, the Igbo of the south-east did same for Dr. Nnamdi Azikiwe of the Nigeria Peoples Party, the Hausa-Fulani of Kano and Kaduna voted for Mallam Aminu Kano of the Peoples Redemption Party (PRP), while the Kanuri of Bornu and other minorities of the Borno-Gongola axis massed behind Alhaji Waziri Ibrahim's Great Nigeria Peoples Party (GNPP). The National Party of Nigeria (NPN) dominated Sokoto, Niger, Bauchi and Kaduna states with strong affiliation in Kwara, Plateau, Benue and Gongola.[9]

Although the NPN won the presidential elections with a two-third of votes casted in the existing 19 states at that time, it had only 38 seats which made control of the central legislature not too easy for the NPN led federal government. One month after its inauguration, the Presidency only had 20 of its nominated 38 Ministers confirmed by the National Assembly. The fear of the Presidency was confirmed when it had to go on a coalition with the NPP in order to receive majority support in the legislature. Similar situation existed in some states where governors were unable to secure majority for their parly in the State Houses of Assembly, in such cases the state legislatures gave the governors tough times in confirming appointments and passing other bills.

Due to the crammed nature of the 1979 elections,[10] some legislators scaled through successfully riding on their parly leaders without the electorates knowing very well whom they voting lor or what the aspirant stood for.[11] Indeed, most voters only voted once or twice in the five elections that were slated to elect leaders. The turnout of voters during the 1979 elections was low. It ranged between 25 and 35 percent of the registered voter, what this revealed was that the register of voters may have been inflated.[12]

From 1979 to 1983, Nigerians were subjected to a state of socio- economic trauma by the misrule of the NPN led by Alhaji Shehu Shagari. Chief Obafemi Awolowo gives a vivid picture of the eenario whenhe said thus: *The federal government is the source from which our material blessings are ordained by the Constitution to flow to the states and the people. But instead, if is the source from which our sufferings flow since independence in 1960. NPN mis-governance led to over-dependence on foreign imports, decline in GDP, reliance on petroleum as the only source of foreign exchange earning. The consequence of an import dependent economy is unemployment and poverty, armed robbery and violence, lack of regard for ethical norms and the lack of fear of God.*[13]

The Nigerian people were not happy about the gross mismanagement of the economy by the ruling party. They thus became disenchanted with the regime and desired a change, and this came when the military struck again in December 1983 three months of the general elections.

**The 1983 Elections**

In the 1983 elections, all the political parties re-nominated their presidential candidates. FEDECO registered one more political party, the Nigerian Advanced Party (NAP) with Barrister Tunji Braithwaith (the founder) as the presidential candidate. After the August 6, 1983 elections, there was widespread complaint by members of the opposition parties that the ruling party, NPN had rigged the elections lo remain in power. Indeed, the NPN had boasted before the elections that it would not only record a landslide victory, but a "moonslide victory" - an acronym for a total sweep of the polls. It did this by taking the NPP stronghold of Anambra State and the UPN stronghold of Ondo State. The level of cheating and manipulation of figures was revealed in the many election petitions challenging the NPN's victory. In Ondo State, the declared result was reversed and the UPN candidate re-instated.[14]

President Shehu Shagari therefore began his second term in office against the background of the disputed electoral outcome. This coupled with the large record of economic mis-management by the NPN controlled government led to military intervention in the country's polity on December 31st, 1983. Traumatised Nigerians heaved a sigh of relief when General Muhammadu Buhari and the late Brigadier Tunde Idiagbon took over power promising Nigerians greater accountability.[15] This marked the collapse of the Second Republic.

**The Babangida Transition**

General Ibrahim Badamosi Babangida took over power through a coup from the General Buhari and Idiagbon regime in August 1985 and began a highly regimented transition to civil rule programme in 1986. He established a Political Bureau to recommend the basic philosophy that would guide the action of government in an envisaged Third Republic in July 1987. Under Decree 25, General Babangida prevented most ex-politicians from participating in politics. Among the conditions set out for each party was that each must establish a base in the "grassroots", avoid ethnic politics, have sufficient personnel manning offices at all levels and have a clear and detailed positions on specific national issues. Finally, each party was to pay a non-refundable fee of 50,000. The National Electoral Commission (NEC) established by the regime was to monitor the political associations which applied for registration, vet their applications and make recommendations to the Armed Forces Ruling Council, which in turn, was to approve two parties.[16]

On October 7, 1989, the AFRC rejected all the six political associations presented by NEC, charging them with bankruptcy of ideas, elitism, debilitating in-fighting, factionalism and ethnic and regional polarisation. It further accused them of being led by leaders who were surrogates of banned politicians. In their place, Babangida decreed into existence two government funded parties - the Social Democratic Party (SDP) which he directed to be "a little to the left" in ideological orientation and the National Republican Convention (NRC) which was directed to be "a little to the right". Nigerians were directed to join the two parties as equals since they had no "founders" and all members were "joiners". Although this appears to have solved the problem of money bags hijacking parties as there was experienced during the first and Second Republics, some politicians however refused to join as they derided the parties as "government parastatals."[17]

**The June 12, 1993 Mandate**

Late in 1990, local government elections were held across the country and elected council officials assumed office in January 1991. Also, at the state level, elections were conducted late in 1991 and elected officials began functioning in January 1992, while the National Assembly elections took place in July 1992 and when the elected members assumed office they never had nor exercised full legislative powers. Everything went smoothly and the Presidential election took place on 12th of June, 1993 under a peaceful atmosphere.[18] Results were collated and announced by NEC. The election was generally considered to be free and fair. Chief Moshood Kashimawo Abiola of the Social Democratic Parly, SDP, had 57% of the votes cast and announced from 16 states.'" Results from the remaining states were still being collated when the Head of State, General Ibrahim Babangida, in a special broadcast on June 24, 1993 annulled the June 12 elections, suspended NEC and discontinued the transition programme. The statement by Bahaiuliga reads thus:

*In view of the series of litigation jiending in various courts, the federal mililarv government is compelled to take appropriate steps in order to rescue the judiciary from intra-wrangling. These steps are taken so as to protect our legal system and the judicial from being ridiculed and politicised both nationally and intcrnationallv. It is common knowledge and an indisputable fad that the last hope of all law-abiding citizens is a resort to the courts. Government would not fold its arms or despair in the face o/ this unfortunate and unwarranted situation which is fast eroding the esteem, honour and confidence willi which the public holds the nation's judiciary....*[20]

General Babangida went ahead to state that in order to stop the various court litigations on the elections so far he stopped all such proceedings particularly concerning the June 12 1993 presidential election. He also repealed Devree Nos. 3, 52 and 13 of 1992 and 1993 which boarders on the transistion to civil rule programme.[21]

For over a year before the elections, there had been calles from individuals and unknown associations for an extension ofmilitary rule. On June 10, 1993, an Association for Better Nigeria (ABN) represented byone Abimbola Davies filed a case before an Abuja High Court that the presidential election be suspended on grounds of corruption going on the party politics. Justice Bassey Ikpeme granted the order that NEC be restrained from conducting the presidential election. It was revelaed later that Justice Ikpeme's order was written by the then Justice Minister, Mr. Clement Akpamgbo.[22] The court judgement received a wide condemnation from both the Nigerian public and the international observers.[23]

**Inter Interim Nationa Government**

The annulment of the June 12, 1993 elections led to series of protests by the Campaign for Democracy (CD) led by Dr. Beko Ransome-Kuti and Olisa Agbakoba of the Civil Liberties Organisation (CLO). As a result of the intensive protests mounted against the Babangida regime, he was forced to hand over hastily to an unelected Interim National Government (ING) headed by Chief Ernest Shonekan. In the third month of the ING, it was declared an illegal government by Justice Dolapo Akinsanya of the Lagos High Course when Chief M. K. O. Abiola filed a suit challenging the ING. On November 17, 1993, Chief Ernest Shonekan was forced to hand over power when General Sani Abacha who was left in office as the Minister of Defence by General Ibrahim Babangida seized power. But because of the strong opposition against the annulment of the June 12 presidential election, General Sani Abacha quickly put in place a Consistutional Conference. Abacha was able to manipulate decisions of the Conference as one third of the members were appointmed by him. The Conference attempt to fix an exit date for themilitary was aborted and Major-General Musa Yar'Adua suggested that the 1st of January 1998 shouldbe thedate for the termination of military rule in the country was arrested on March 9, 1998 for charges of coupt plotting.[24]

General Sani Abacha had identified all opposition to military ruleand was bent on crushing opposition elements before transforming himself to a cilvilain president via a self-scucession bid.[25] Chief M. K. O. Abiola was arrested in June 1994 by security operatives of the Abacha junta for declaring himself the President and Commander-in-Chief of the Armed Forces of Nigeria. He was held in solitary confinement and neither members of his family nor his personal physician was allowed to see him in spite of alarming reports of his state of health.[26] Chief Abiola spent four years in detentionand refused to renounce his June 12, 1993 presidential election mandate. General Abacha died onJune 8, 1998 while Chief M. K. O. Abiola died in detention on July 7, 1998.

**The 1999 Election**

General Abdulsalam Abubakar succeeded General Abacha as Head of State. He announced May 29, 1999 as the terminal date for the military to hand over to a democratically elected government. He also announced the cancellation of the flawed transisiton programme put in place by Abacha. The G34, a group of politicians which included ex-civilian governors and top politicians called for a scrapping of all the previous political paties. General Abubakar constituted an Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) which set guidelines for political parties to exist and to function. Some of the guidelines included: that parties must accept theprinciple of power sharing and rotation of key offices and must exist in functional terms in at least 24 states of the federation.[27]

Furthermore, parties were required to pay a non-refundable deposit of -100,000 and maintain fully staffed and well equipped offices. The net effect of these conditions was that out of the 25 parties which applied for registration, only 3 met INEC's registration criteria. Ehese 3 were: The People's Democratic Party (PDP), All People's Party (APP) and the Alliance for Democracy (AD). Others that were not registered by INEC include: Agenda '99 – Masses Democratic Party of Nigeria, All Nigeria Party, Community Party of Nigeria, Democratic Alternative, Democratic Advance Party, Movement for Democracy

and Justice, Minority Rights Party, Nigeria Renaissance Movement, National Unity Party of Nigeria, National Democratic Congress, National Development Party of Nigeria, Nigeria Millennium Party, Nigeria Labour Party, National Solidarity Party. National Coalition Party of Nigeria, Nigeria Liberation Party, National Restoration Democratic Party, Peoples Redemption Party, Peoples Liberation Party, Peoples Democratic Congress, United Peoples Party and the United Democratic Party.[28]

Elections were conducted into various political offices between January and May 1999.[29] On May 29, 1999, President Olusegun Obasanjo of the PDP became the Second Executive President after a general election generally considered to be free and fair. The peoples Democratic Party (PDP) also won majority seats in the national legislature and two thirds of the thirty six states of the federation.[30] The Alliance for Democracy candidate, Chief Olu Falae, though challenged the results of the election at the Court of Appeal presided over by Justice Dahiru Mustapha lost the case.

**The 2003 Elections**

Before the 2003 elections, INEC had registered twenty-seven more political parties in addition to the existing three bringing to a total of thirty political parties that contested the elections. Most of these parties were those earlier denied registration by INEC before the 1999 elections. However, before the April 2003 elections, there were public outcry over the manner in which politicians and corporate entities donated to politicians and political parties. For example, President Obasanjo and his deputy, Alhaji Abubakar Atiku, realised over -5.5 billion in their fund-raising campaign. The governor of Delta State, Chief James Ibori raised ~2 billion. Governor Bola Ahmed Tinubu of Lagos State raised -1.3 billion. The public described these fund-raising as regressive events. By the donations, political parties violated the Company and Allied Matters Act of 1990 and Section 225 of the 1999 Constitution which prohibited companies from contributing fund to political parties and receiving funds from outside Nigeria.[31]

There was public outcry aliu the April 2003 elections which saw the PDP retaining the presidency, winning more seats at the national legislature and the governorship positions of more states. Some sections of the Nigerian public believed that the elections were massively rigged especially that of the gubernatorial and presidential elections. For instance, an association called the Patriots led by Chief F. R. A. Williams called for an interim government as a way out of the widespread protest against the results of the elections. Similarly, the Civil Liberties Organisation (CLO) called for a cancellation of the election results and the hosting of a national conference.[32]

After the presidential and gubernatorial elections, some political parties seeing their woeful performance decided to withdraw their participation from other subsequent elections alleging that the earlier elections were marred by fraud.[33] Twelve political parties held a meeting on Tuesday, April 15,2003, and unanimously agreed to reject the result of the National Assembly polls. The parties were National Democratic Party (NDP), United Nigeria People's Party (UNPP), All Progressive Liberation Party (APLP), New Nigeria People's Party (NNPP), Justice Party (JP), Progressive Action Congress (PAC), All People's Grand Alliance (APGA), All Republican Party (ARP) and Community Party of Nigeria (CPN).'[4]

Following threats by former military Head of State and Presidential candidate of the All Nigeria People's Party (ANPP), General Mohammed Buhari(Rtd), to make the country ungovernable if the results of the general elections of April and May 2003 were not cancelled and another election conducted, some Nigerian citizens including former Heads of State intervened on the outcome of the general elections by inviting (icneral Muhammadu Buhari to a parley and asking him to challenge the results of the polls at the Election Tribunal and to drop his threat of making the country ungovernable.[35]

Earlier, a group of Northern leaders led by Etsu Nupe, Alhaji Umaru Sada Ndayako presented Obasanjo with a list of conditions for saving the country from a clear state of emergency arising from the rejection of the April general elections by over 16 opposition parties led by the ANPP. Among the conditions given by these Northern

leaders was that Obasanjo should dissolve INEC, reconstitute another electoral body, cancel the April election results wherever rigging was alleged and initiate a new election.[36]

There was, however, another group of people that believed that the results of the elections should be allowed to prevail for the sake of moving the country forward. The argued that peace must be allowed to reign.[37] Even within opposition parties, there were opposing views which believe that the results of the election should be accepted as they were. For instance, majority of the members of the ANPP in Rivers State decamped to the PDF immediately after the election.[38]

At the end of the April 2003 election into various political offices in Nigeria, Election Appeal Tribunals were set up to look into petitions filed by aggrieved parties on the election in accordance with Section 285(l)(a) and (2) of the 1999 Constitution.[39] The INEC advised that aggrieved parties should resort to only legal remedies through the judiciary. However, the European Union Election Observer Mission (EUEOM) in Nigeria disagreed over the conduct and outcome of the elections. It asserted that it had confirmed the allegations of serious irregularities'by "new information received."[40] It noted that elections in Cross River, Delta, Edo, Enugu, Imo, Kaduna and Rivers were marred by serious irregularities.[41] The Head of the observer team, Mr. Max Van dem Berg said that the EUEOM was concerned about reported cases of arrest of opposition candidates shortly before the May 3 elections as a case in Edo State showed.[42]

**The Way Forward**

The greatest problem confronting Nigeria's democracy has been how to conduct a credible election accepted by all parties. Past attempts at sustainable democracy have failed because of fraud associated with election in Nigeria. As a way forward, we are of the opinion that the option A4 method adopted during the regime of General Ibrahim Babangida be adopted as a permanent method of electioneering. Also, guidelines for political parties must include stringent measures that would de-emphasize ethnic or tribal affiliations and religious undertone. Candidates to all political offices should be screened in such a way that those who have embezzled public funds and those whose means of income are questionable would be barred from participation. The judicial arm of government must be made totally independent so that incumbents will not use the courts to install a wrong candidate. A five-year single term of office be prescribed for all political office holders in this way, the incumbency factor would not be abused.

**Conclusion**

It is well known that the vast majority of the Nigerian citizenry live below poverty line. If elections are to be instituted as a credible way of electing the leadership of the Nigeria state, poverty must be banished from among the populace. Most Nigerians become docile to political money-bags because of the tips they get from these money bags at election times. Poverty has reduced many to slavery and unthinking beings. This is a challenge before our leaders.

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## A HISTORY OF NIGERIA'S FOREIGN RELATIONS, 1960-2000

**S. T. OKAJARE**

### INTRODUCTION

From the era of slave trade, through the period ol trade in silvan goods to the epoch of colonial rule, Nigeria remained an extension of European (particularly British) sphere of influence. As such, the relations Nigeria had with the outside world during these three epochs were extension of British external relations. Particularly in the latter epoch of colonial rule, such representation was kept more on a tutelary basis - with Britain as the overseeing authority than as a mark of sovereignty.[1] But,Nigeria emerged out of the web of colonial rule on October 1,1960 with the trappings, symbols and paraphernalia of an independent country (at least politically). That development made Nigeria a recognizable member of the comity of states of the world known in diplomatic parlance as the international system.

This chapter is a historical discourse on Nigeria's entry into, and membership of, this community of humanity which shall henceforth be called the international system in this work, and it covers 1960 to year 2000. The work aims at adding to the pool of scholarly works on Nigeria's external relations from independence. It is divided into three major parts. Part one introduces the work while the second part discusses Nigeria's external relations under various regimes. The third part concludes the work.

Like other African countries that gained their independence in the 1960s, Nigeria was ushered into an international system that was cleft into two opposing power blocs: North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) headed by USA and the Warsaw Pact underI ISSR.[2] It was possible for Nigeria to take her stand within this intricate system because of her status as an independent nation. Like other newly emergent nations of Africa, Nigeria considered it more expedient "to stay out of military blocs and pursue political and ideological neutrality" in principle.[3]

For clarity of exposition, it is crucial to define the two concepts of foreign policy and international relations since the former is the framework within which the latter is being conducted. Foreign policy entails all those policies a country formulates towards the protection of its interest in the international system. Kolawole sees foreign policy as the "instrumentality of making friends and of creating enemies".[4] Julius Pratt sees it as comprising the objectives that a nation seeks in its international relations and the means and methods by which it pursues them.[5] In essence, any nation's foreign policy is the blue print it articulates to serve as the guide for the conduct of its foreign relations. On the other hand, international relations is the actual intercourse between or among states in the international system. This relationship may be between two countries (bi-lateral) or among several countries (multi-lateral).[6]

The foregoing points to the fact that foreign policy is *sine qua non* to the thrust and dimensions of external relations of any nation. The above classification, it is hoped, will help us to understand the thrust of Nigeria's foreign relations under each regime in the light of the foreign policy of such regime.

### Nigeria's Foreign Relations from 1960 To 1965

It had become clear by 1954 that Nigeria was already at the threshold of attaining her independence. As observed by Crowder:

*The 1954 constitution marked the end of nationalist struggle with Britain. ..It was hardly surprising therefore that the year after the new constitution came into effect was a quiet one with ministers taking over departments and learning the basic mechanics of the services for which they were now fully responsible.*[7]

It was under this arrangement that Sir Abubakar Tafawa Belewa became Prime minister. Basking in the euphoria of this new status, the Prime minister made his first official foreign policy statement on 20th August 1960 (before independence) in the Federal House of Representatives. In the speech described as "a brief but strongly worded policy statement"[9] Balewa tried to state the major elements of the general principles that would guide the conduct of Nigeria's foreign relations. One of such principles was an:

*independent policy which would be founded on Nigeria's interest and consistent with the moral and democratic principles on which our constitution is based.*[9]

Six days after the attainment of independence (October 7, 1960), Sir Abubakar further expounded on the aims and principles of his government's foreign policy. The occasion was the meeting of the United Nations General Assembly where Nigeria was admitted as the ninety - ninth member of the UN. Those principles were:

a. The defence and promotion of Nigeria's sovereignty, territorial integrity and national independence.
b. The creation of the necessary economic and political conditions to secure the government, territorial integrity and national independence of other African countries and their total liberation from imperialism and all forms of foreign domination
c. The creation of the necessary conditions for the economic, political social and cultural development of Africa.
d. Promotion of the rights of all black and oppressed peoples throughout the world.
e. Promotion of African unity.
f. Promotion of world peace built on freedom, mutual respect and equality of all peoples of the world.
g. Respect for the territorial integrity of all nations.
h. Non- partisanship in East - West ideological disputes and freedom of association and action in the international system.'"

Over the years, these principles have remained the enduring underlying framework of Nigeria's foreign relations. As it has been observed:

*They have retained their vitality and remained virtually unedited through the changes of regimes and the vagaries of domestic polices.* [11]

Though, the Balewa regime championed the above principles, it did not always act in accordance with the spirit and letters of those principles. For instance, the regime exhibited an unveiled preference for pro-West relations and a clear antipathy towards the Eastern bloc. This was in spite of the avowed principle of non-alignment in the East - West cold war. Balewa perceived the contemporary international system as a dangerous terrain where the country should tread cautiously by remaining with trusted friends while discouraging relations that could further aggravate the fragility and instability at the domestic front. As a mailer ol fact, all the major parties (NCNC, A G, NPC) on the eve of independence embraced a pro-West external relation, despite then' fundamental and deep - scaled differences in terms of political ideology. Particularly, all the parties agreed on Nigeria's membership of the Commonwealth[12:] The declaration of Balewa that "we shall never forget our old (Western) friends" [l3] was a clear

testimony that Nigeria was still to continue tutelary relationship with Britain.

It demonstrated further that there are contradictions in theoretical principles of external relations and the actual state behaviours in the course of conducting that relationship. It could also be taken to signify a proof that Balewa and his close aides had no good understanding of the workings of the international system as a forum where there is no permanent friend or enemy, but permanent interests.

The Anglo - Nigerian Defense pact of 1958 was yet another proof that Nigeria's foreign policy was an appendage of British policy. The terms of the pact covered an unfettered access by Britain to use any part of Nigeria as landing space and other sundry military operations in exchange for military defence and professional assistance to Nigeria. In clear terms, this was an erosion of the territorial integrity of Nigeria. Scathing criticisms followed the leakage of the pact after independence and by 1961, it was abrogated. Notwithstanding the abrogation, there continued a kind for special relationship with Britain throughout the regime of Balewa. The ministry in charge of external relations was known as Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Commonwealth Relations. Between October 1960 and July 1961, Balewa was personally in charge of the external affairs portfolio, apparently to integrate Nigeria permanently to the orbit of the British Empire. Jaja Wachukwu became the first appointed Minister of External Affairs and Commonwealth Relations in July, 1961[14]

Furthermore, the Soviet Union was not allowed to open an embassy in Lagos until 1961. Even then, according to Amechi, unprecedented logistic and bureaucratic restrictions were imposed to marginalize its effectiveness[15] The ostensible reason for the delay was because Nigeria could not afford to reciprocate such in Moscow. The real reason was not unconnected with the fact that British tutors had imbued Nigeria leaders with anti-communist sentiments. For a long time, communism-related literature was banned from circulation in Nigeria while Soviet - trained Nigerians were not employed in the civil service. This prompted Amechi to conclude that prior to the civil war in Nigeria, the Soviet Union and Nigeria maintained what can be called a zero or minimal relationship.[16]

As if Nigeria had not been hatched out of the shell of colonial rule, Balewa could hardly take any major foreign policy decision without first consulting the British Government. Idang exemplifies that during the Bizerta crisis of 1961, Balewa traveled to London to seek the advice of the British Government before issuing any statement on the issue[17]

On pan-Africanism, Balewa had affirmatively stated that "We belong to Africa and Africa must claim first attention in our external affairs"[18] What eventually came up was a cautious and functional approach to African matters. This drew the ire of articulate Nigerians who felt that their expectation had been cut short as the approach could not inspire any national pride. Like a representative voice ofihc people, Enahoro once declared; "A policy which advocates functional cooperation instead of organic (political) union of Africa cannot inspire anybody"[19] Balewa conceived of a pan - African union as a long - term evolutionary process. To him, it was too early to be thinking of an organic political union for the whole continent. He advocated a continuous, prolonged contact to serve as a base for possible future political fusion. He and those who thought like him diplomatically believed that economic and cultural cooperation would serve the African purpose better than political union. Balewa detested any boundary adjustment that could alter the existing one which grew out of the European creation at the 1884 - 1885 Berlin Conference. This position made Nigeria most vulnerable to the open and clandestine neo-colonial machinations of the Western world. It offered them an ample chance to perfect the mechanisms of post - independence political manipulation which they had instituted at the eve of independence. Hence, the resultant effect was a consistent inconsistency, ambivalence and contradictions between the professed principles and actual practice of foreign relations.

The first military coup of January 15, 1966 led to the termination of the First Republic. Balewa, along side some national leaders, was killed. In a swift manipulation of the confusing situation that ensued, General Aguiyi - Irons! emerged as the first military Head of State of Nigeria. Congenitally crisis - ridden and lacking in focus, the Ironsi government was upstaged on July 29, 1966 after a 'three - day' interregnum, Lt. Col. Yakubu Gowon emerged as

the new Head of State on August 1, 1966.

**Nigeria's External Relations, 1966 - 1975.**

From the start, the regime of Gowon appeared to have a clearly different conception of the international system. This has been explained as due to the prevailing circumstances under which the Gowon regime operated:

*Given the imperatives of domestic politics and the opportunities of a more relaxed international system, it was not surprising that Gowon 's foreign policy, attitude and orientation, as well as the perception of Nigeria's interest and means of attaining them were significantly different from those ofBalewa.*[20]

There were two fundamental developments during the Gowon regime which might reasonably aid our understanding of the regime's experience and behaviour in the international system. These are the civil war and the oil boom. During the civil war years (1967- 1970), uncertain future was very glaring in the Nigerian horizon and a big question dangled on the issues of national interest and the corporate existence of the country. The major point of grave necessity as to national interest then was how to maintain national unity in the face of the pogrom. All appropriate means and methods were to be employed to prevent the territorial disintegration of Nigeria. Under this circumstance, the sincerity behind the so - called special relations Nigeria had hitherto maintained with our "true friends" - the West, particularly Britain - was put to the test.

Apart from condemning the Federal blockade against the waters of Eastern Nigeria, as against international law, Britain placed embargo on sale of arms to the Federal Government. USA, France, Holland and Czechoslovakia followed suit. In such instance, the Gowon regime had to have a more relaxed, flexible and all-embracing worldview. Gowon, therefore, embraced the Eastern bloc particularly the Soviet Union which transited from being a country to be dealt with cautiously to an ally. This was in view of the growing demand for weapons and international support to prosecute the war to a successful end.

With the oil wealth of the 1970s, Nigeria's international relations assumed a new dimension. As observed by Otubanjo.

*Oil wealth strengthened the opportunity for positive non-alignment and provided the impetus for a more expansive role in Africa; an active presence in world politics and indeed a radical role in regional economic relation and the search for distributive justice in the international system.*[21]

This new - found financial strength explains why Gowon had the spine to promulgate the Indigenisation Decree in 1972. With this decree, the government proceeded to take over a controlling share in the operations of various multi - national oil companies. This was to compensate Nigeria for its loss of a national resource. Between 1973 and 1974, the government bought 55% of the total shares of these companies.[22]

After the civil war, Gowon embarked on what may be called 'win - back - old - friends' diplomacy and fully assumed the control of all facets of Nigeria's external affairs. According to Garba, "Nigeria's post - war diplomacy was based on two things - the former Head of State himself, because he toured extensively, and oil".[24] Despite Nigeria's bitter experience from the West during the war, the Anglo -Nigerian relations of 1970 1975 period improved considerably so much that it had reached the level of special relations of Balewadays. Trade relations between Nigeria and the West improved considerably while Soviet Union was reduced to just a friend to Nigeria.[24] Consequently, Nigeria drew closer to Britain for multiple assistance and the European Economic Commission in order to secure the friendship of other European nations like France and Germany.

Obsessed with the national grandeur that came with the oil wealth, Gowon embarked on spending spree in the course of his world - wide personal diplomacy. He committed N19.5 million to Commonwealth fund for technical cooperation and paid the salaries of civil servants in Grenada in 1974. In the African continent, Gowon concluded bi-lateral agreements with Tanzania, Zambia, Guinea, Togo, Niger, Chad, Republic of Benin and Cameroon.

Though these diplomatic gestures improved the international image of Nigeria and its leadership, the irony was that while Nigeria was desperately in need of effective post - war reconstruction, the leader was junketing round the world on donation spree. Whal was arguably the major achievement of Gowon's post - war diplomacy was the almost singular establishment of the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS). The terms and instrument of establishing ECOWAS were finally ratified by all the states involved on 28 May, 1975.[25] Thus, Gowon effectively unified countries of the West African sub-region through ECOWAS.[26].

**Nigeria's Relations under Muritala/Obasanjo Regime**

The Muritala/Obasanjo regime came on board through a bloodless coup that swept off the Gowon regime on July 29, 1975. The new regime exhibited a 'no-nonsense' posture by embarking on some radical actions. One of such radical actions was the setting up of a committee made up of personages drawn from the armed forces, the universities and among career diplomats from the Ministry of External Affairs to review the whole basis of Nigeria's foreign policy and to formulate new guidelines.[27] The committee was headed by Professor Adebayo Adedeji and some eight months late according to Garba:

*The panel produced a report which included not onlv an overall review of Nigeria's foreign policy since independence, but also projected for at least the following decade objectives priorities and strategies.*[2S]

From the onset, the regime demonstrated that Africa would occupy the central position in its foreign policy without affecting the national interest negatively.[29] The first litmus test for this was the Angolan crisis. South Africa had invaded Cunene-a Southern province of Angola on the ostensible argument of protecting the Cunene dam. But, the invasion was to demonstrate South African support for UNITA (Union for the Total Independence of Angola), one of the three factions involved in the nationalist struggle for Angola independence. The other two were MPLA (Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola) and FNLA (National Front for the Liberation of Angola). South Africa was aversed to the eradication of racial discrimination and apartheid in Africa as declared by OAU. The apartheid regime thereby embarked on supporting one group against the other.[30] While FNLA enjoyed support from the West (Britain and USA), MPLA was supported by USSR and Cuba. The initial position of Nigeria was to integrate the three groups to one formidable anti-colonial force. But the groups did not cooperate and instead they "simply engaged in cut-throat struggle for power".[31]

In such cumbrous circumstance, Nigeria demonstrated an independent action by backing the MPLA. Nigeria gave N13.5 million to MPLA and thereby showed that Africa and Africans were no longer to be used for the advancement of racist policies. Nigeria recognized the MPLA government of Argustino Neto on November 25,1975, unreservedly condemned foreign involvement and advocated the withdrawal of all foreign troops fostering the division of Angola. In December 8, 1975 a grant of $20m was announced by the Federal Government for Angola while material aid to the tune of $100m was also delivered later.

Apart from material and financial assistance, Nigeria gave huge political and diplomatic support to Angola. The Federal Government literally became the mouthpiece of the Angolan government within Africa. Delegations were dispatched to various African States to pursue recognition for MPLA. After his robust condemnation of the United States' and South African roles in the Angolan crisis, Muritala argued the Angolan case for recognition that:

*On the one hand is the MPLA whose record in the struggle against Portuguese imperialism is impeccable and whose government in Luanda has been recognized by 23 African countries. The Nigeria Federal Military Government has been deeply convinced that the MPLA is the most dynamic, most nationalistic of all the movements representing the interest of the Angolan people and convinced that it possesses the attributes of an effective Government, joined other African countries in according it recognition. It is the duty of this Summit session to complete the process undertaken so far by individual governments by unanimously according the recognition of our organization to the Government of MPLA.*[32]

This eventually yielded dividends as many of those states which had hitherto maintained neutrality, recognized

the MPLA's government promptly. Even though the unanimous recognition was not immediately accorded, Nigeria's powerful diplomatic lobby won for MPLA the sympathy and understanding of some of the delegations. This diplomatic romance between Nigerian government and the MPLA would have expectedly guaranteed a smooth pattern of relations between Nigeria and Angola. This was not exactly so. It is crucial to note that there were some forces within Nigeria that were aversed to the pro-MPLA stance of the Muritala/Obasanjo regime.[34]

General Olusegun Obasanjo succeded Muritala in 1976. The new leader further clarified Nigeria's commitment to total liberation of Africa in 1977 when Nigeria played host to the World Conference for Action against Apartheid. Obasanjo accused the foreign multinational companies of "contributing in no small measure to the evil machinations of apartheid". He added that the country was "mounting surveillance on all those enterprises who depend on our raw materials and markets but continue to help our enemies: such enterprises must decide now to choose between us and our enemies".[34] Obasanjo's regime also broadened the provision of the 1972 Indigenisation Decree on the premise that "a dynamic foreign policy had to be based first on control over local resources".[35] The new arrangement had three schedules of 100%, 60% and 40% Nigerian participation respectively through either private owners or institutions. Foreign companies were ordered to Nigerianise their sales, marketing and personnel departments while those that failed to comply by July 1976 were taken over by the Federal Government.[36] Apart from improving the recurrent revenue of Nigeria, the government was now able to prop up the various liberation movements in the continent. In 1976, $250.000 was given to such movement in Zimbabwe while a National Relief Fund was launched for Southern Africa with N2.5m donation by the Nigerian Government and N2.000 personal donation by Obasanjo. Over 200 students who were displaced as a result of the Soweto massacre were also admitted to different Nigerian Schools.

Nigeria also advanced the cause of Africa through the opportunities of international organizations. In the conference of Non-Aligned Nations in Colombo, Sri Lanka, in 1976, General Joe Garba (Nigeria External Affairs Commissioner) condemned the lukewarm attitude of the Non-Aligned nations towards the liberation fund in aid of the struggle in Southern Africa. In his passionate appeal to members to contribute to the liberation fund, Garba said:

*every pledge, however little, by each of us can have for the freedom fighters a psychological impact out of proportion to that amount.*[31]

Garba went further to condemn France for supporting racist regime in Zimbabwe by concluding nuclear deal with it. He therefore advocated a concerted effort by Non-Aligned Nations against France for its persistent defiance of international decisions on apartheid.

There was no fundamental change in Anglo-Nigerian relations from the periods of the two previous regimes until February, 1976 when Muritala was killed in a coup believed to have been sponsord by Britain.. This put a strain on Nigeria's relations with Britain and a number of unwholesome events followed/[1]"However, these seemingly negative developments did not profoundly affect the Anglo-Nigerian intercourse particularly in its economic aspect. As noted by Ademran:

*It was business as usual with the leadership of the Nigerian Chambers of Commerce and Industry tiding on behalf of the Federal Government in negotiations witli Britain while Britain's trade surplus with Nigeria continued to record hundreds of millions of pounds.* [39]

In 1979, Nigeria nationalized Shell - BP (Nig.) Ltd., and changed its name to African Petroleum. This was when it was discovered that Britain under Margaret Thatcher had broken the oil embargo on Rhodesia (Zimbabwe). This action was taken when the Commonwealth Conference was in progress in Lusaka, Zambia. The major impact of this action was that it made Britain to shift ground in its policy on Rhodesia.[40] It also agreed with the wave of public opinion in Nigeria which had favoured a radical posture on all fronts as to the independence of

Zimbabwe. Whether the action was a retaliatory move against the British break of the oil embargo or a persuasive strategy to sway Britain into changing her position on Zimbabwean independence is immaterial. What is worth noting is that Nigeria used her resources strategically to back up her foreign policy objectives in Africa.

However, it should be noted that the above radical foreign policy position of Obasanjo should not be taken as an anti-West position. The regime's support for MPLA in Angola and the nationalization of a British oil firm were demonstrative of the Afro-centric dimension of Nigeria's external relations during the period. Such desire to protect the African interest in the international system was not restricted to actions against the West only. In 1979, Obasanjo, without mincing words, stated at the OAU Summit in Khartoum (Sudan) that:

*Nigeria's objective was and is the independence of Africa and its freedom from external control or intervention from whatever source(whether East or West)* ***(emphasis mine)***[41]

A fundamental effect of this new emphasis on African liberation by the Muritala/Obasanjo regime on Nigeria's external relations is that greater coherence now existed on the process of making and implementing foreign policy. External relations were based on clear evaluation and perception of the international system in terms of the behaviour of other members (states) of that system. Such behaviour was to be gauged as to whether it would be conducive to total liberation. During this period, for instance, Nigeria perceived rather correctly that the Carter-led USA was prepared to be more sensitive and receptive to African opinion over such matters as Namibia and Southern Africa. There was thus a remarkable improvement in the Nigerian-USA relations particularly in terms of economic relations which covered bi-lateral agreements on agriculture, technology transfer, development and education.

On the other hand, this careful assessment explains why Nigeria did not outrightly sever relations with Britain even when the articulate public asked for such step. Until the advent of the North Sea oil which made Britain relatively self-sufficient in crude oil products, Nigeria remained Britain's major source of supply. In essence, while some unpalatable events threatened to pull the two countries apart, the strong centuries-old economic cord continued to bring them together.

On the whole, in spite of what might be the shortfalls of its foreign policy posture, the Munitala/Obasanjo regime demonstrated greater independence in foreign policy making. While the Gowon regime effected little or not - too-fundamental change in the blueprint it inherited, the 1975-1979 period witnessed a radical departure from the *status quo.* This change has been attributed to the influence of radical intelligentsia on the policy making process. It has been observed that:

*The inputs from academics and various advisory bodies took on greater prominence, a characteristic which marked not only the foreign policy scene but the system of administration as a whole.*[42]

The army relinquished power on October 1,1979 and a civilian regime under Alhaji Shehu Shagari was ushered in.

**Nigeria's External Relations: 1979 - 1983.**

Under the preceding regime. Nigeria's external relations had become more diversified and liberalized with a clear preference of independence of action on international issues rather than the professed but not practicalized ideology of non - alignment. Such diversified external relations with Africa as the centerpiece of foreign policy thrust was inherited by the Shagari administration in October 1979.

It is pertinent to mention at the outset that what was known as special relations with Britain in the 1960 - 1975 period had been replaced by special relations with the United States at the end of the Obasanjo regime. The

outgoing military regime had shown preference for (and adopted) the American style of presidentialism. Also, the Kellogg fertilizer deal with which Obasanjo's agriculture project: Operation Feed the Nation was actualized was sponsored by the charismatic Andrew Young - USA Ambassador to the United Nations. He had visited Nigeria in 1977 when he was warmly received by Obasanjo.[43]

However, Britains' trading relations continued to improve despite the crises surrounding the nationalization of British Petroleum under Obasanjo. Adeniran has observed that:
*British investmentsin Nigeria continued with comfortable margins of profit ...Britain's economic interests were in no way threatened.*[44]

As a matter of fact, Nigeria sought the cooperation of Britain in diverse areas of external relations including her effort to ensure the liberation of Southern African countries like Namibia and Zimbabwe. The regime had inherited this militant African-centered foreign policy from the previous military regime. In this direction, Shagari granted $10 Million to Zimbabwe in April 1980 during the celebration of her independence. Commendably the Shagari regime stood its ground against the Machiavellian machination of the Reagan Government against the cause of liberation in Southern Africa.[16] However, Shagari stopped the annual aid donation of $5 million to African Liberation Movements. This was due mainly to the economic strain that had set in on Nigeria's economy at this time.

In his thought - provoking and lengthy address to the OAU Summit held in Freetown, Sierra Leone under the chairmanship of President Siaka Stevens. Shagari left no one in doubt that Africa really occupied the central point in Nigeria's foreign policy priority. He spoke severally on the bloody and protracted crises in Chad, Western Sahara, Horn of Africa, South Africa and Namibia and the newly won independence of Zimbabwe. His speech also covered economic cooperation among member states and the Middle Last situation. He warned members of the grave consequences of these crises and their implication for Africa if powers outside the continent were "allowed to exploit the unfortunate situation"[46]

The Shagari regime also demonstrated an independent status in its foreign policy as it maintained cordial relations with countries of the eastern bloc. Particularly from the experience of the civil war under Gowon, Nigerian perception of the Soviet Union and her allies in the communist world had changed from what it used to be in the First Republic. Though the level of economic ties still remained ridiculously low, Nigerians received from the East much needed international support for the liberation movements in Africa.[47]

We can deduce from the above that the Shagari years were a period when Nigeria's external relations embraced friends from both sides of the global divide; East and West. There is no denying the fact, however, that the United States had an edge over others in the relations. Apart from operating a replica of the American model of presidentailism, major economic policies of Shagari administration drew Nigeria closer to USA than had been the case. However, there were still some grey areas of misunderstanding particularly as regards issues of racism, aparthered and liberation movements in Africa. On the other hand, the Soviet Union continued to be a reliable friend that could not be ignored.

The economic recession that followed the unprecedented corruption of the Shagari regime led Nigeria to embark on borrowing spree with Britain acting in most cases as the guarantor. This marked the beginning of a new epoch of debtor-creditor relationship in Nigeria's external relations.

**Nigeria's Foreign Relations under Buhari.**
The socio-economic and political events of the latter part of Shagari's regime made military intervention easily predictable. On December 31, 1983, the military struck and installed Major General Muhammadu Buhari as Head of State. What appeared to be the major pre-occupation of the regime was how to revamp the grossly battered economy. As noted by Amechi:

*The Buhari administration surely came in on a very difficult economic footing. It was the proved mismanagement of the economy and the inability to redress it that led to the con/} that brought the Bitiuiri regime into Iteing.*[48]

This probably explains why the regime's foreign policy speech was not made until December 3, 1984. In the speech, Buhari indicated thai his foreign policy and, in effect, thrust of external relations would be informed by what he called the 'new realities'.

The 1983 coup did not in any fundamental way cause any rupture in the Nigeria -Britain relations. This was more so as the coup was staged against the backdrop of domestic developments. But, the events that followed the coup led to diplomatic row between the two countries and the situation is better described as an era of confrontational diplomacy.[49]

However, this issue did not have any significant impact beyond mere hostile verbal exchanges. Both countries realized their importance to each other. Nigeria still remained a large market for British goods while Britain was a major consumer of Nigeria oil and an attractive state to Nigerian leaders who were largely capitalistic in orientation. Coupled with this is the fact that USA was ill -disposed to the coup that truncated Nigeria's first romance with American model of presidential system. In short, the coup injured American ego in Nigeria. The Buhari regime therefore found in Britain an accommodating friend.

The dismal position of Nigerian economy also contributed to the pro - Britain posture of the Buhari regime. In a dire need for domestic stability and foreign good will, the regime pursued loan facilities to the IMF. In such circumstance, the regime could hardly take any independent actions particularly those that could harm any British interests as it relied on Britain for possible assistance in securing such loans. Also, Nigeria still depended on Britain for both military advisers and hardware. In essence, there was a continuous warm and cordial Nigerian - Britain relations during the Buhari years.

Despite the economic crunch that forced it to go on low profile diplomacy, the Buhari regime still demonstrated unequivocally its commitment to the cause of decolonization and eradication of racism and apartheid in Africa. The regime was at the front rank against the and Reagan linkage policy on Namibian independence.[50] In effect, the Buhari regime recorded marked achievement in its bid to re-establish the Nigerian leading status in African affairs. In what appeared to be a twist of events, the Buhari regime was toppled by another military junta which made Gen. Ibrahim Babangida the Head of State on August 27, 1985.

**The Babangida Years, 1985 - 1993**

Babangida emerged Nigerian Head of State at a time when uneasy calm enveloped the land. The gap - toothed General employed this charming personality to lure Nigerians into accepting his regime. As a matter of fact, he portrayed himself to the people as a reformer. According to Amata, "the foreign policy angle of Babangida's philosophy of reform derives logically from his views on the domestic scene"[51] The economy had not improved remarkably when Babangida took office. The regime therefore considered it imperative to improve the economy and work for the efficiency of ECOWAS in the sub-region to serve as the platform for launching its foreign policy. From
all indications, Babangida seemed to have a clear understanding of the importance of vibrant economy to external relations. It was the desire of Babangida to establish Nigeria as an important player in the game of diplomacy both in Africa and in the emergent world order. To achieve this, Babangida embarked on what has come to be known as economic diplomacy. The simple logic of this new – found philosophy was that "no more was Nigerian foreign policy going to be conducted without a keen eye on our national interests defined mostly in economic terms".[52]

In re-asserting the leadership position of Nigeria in the West African sub - region. Babangida largely made use of the ECOWAS. In 1985, he stated to a cheering circle of ECOWAS member states that 'ECOWAS was ripe for

rebirth.[53] Apart from his donation spree, Babangida also resorted to inter - personal diplomacy with heads of states in the sub- region. This was to be an effective diplomatic tool to rally support for the formation of ECOWAS Monitoring Group. (ECOMOG); a peace - keeping force, later in 1990. The piloting role of Nigeria in ihe ECOMOG enterprise earned her a pride of place in West African affairs. The two closely-related terms; regional security and economic cooperation, became recurrent items on the agenda of regional meetings and summits. It needs not be over - stressed that Nigeria played the leading role in the ECOWAS standing mediation committee which eventually established ECOMOG in 1990. The role of Nigeria in the Liberian conflict through ECOMOG was indicative of the desire of Nigerian leadership to re - assert the country's position in the sub - region.

Babangida maintained cordial relations with the West through his 'cooperative' economic behaviour. The Structural Adjustment Programme (SAP) was designed in response to the requirement of foreign (particularly western) creditors. These requirements included privatization and commercialization of public enterprises, economic deregulation and devaluation of national currency among others.[54]

**Nigeria's External Relations under Abacha, 1993 - 1998.**

Nigeria appeared irretrievably doomed to total disintegration following the annulment of the June 12 election and the plethora of crises it precipitated. The Interim National Government (ING) under Ernest Shonekan was put in place as a last-minute face saving measure by the Babandiga regime. Completely rudderless and unprepared, the ING could neither initiate nor effect any meaningful contact with the outside world. In such circumstance of confusion, Abacha staged a palace coup, sacked the ING and installed himself as Head of State on November 17, 1993.

Nigeria's external relations underwent the darkest moment in its history under Abacha. The expectation that Abacha would curry the friendship of the outside world after settling down was shattered with the unveiled confrontational position of his regime. Abacha brooked no contrary opinion whether from within or without. His regime, as aptly captioned by Kolawole, was "an era in which isolationism was the rule rather than the exception. Diplomacy ... was replaced by bull fighting. Nigeria was not courting friends but creating enemies".[55] The Abacha regimes had an unprecedented and yet unsurpassed record of human rights abuse in Nigeria's political history. This drew Nigeria into more conflicts with the outside world. Instead of the usual old alliance with USA, Britain and other western nations, the regime embarked on new found diplomatic romance with pariah countries like Libya, Iraq, China, Sudan, Iran, Malaysia, North Korea and others. Ironically, most of these states depend on the West for their economic survival the implication of this was that the national interests of Nigeria were, in no way, blessed or improved by the new direction of external relations.

Abacha went further to bring religion to bear on foreign policy as he drove Nigeria to the fold of a group of D- 8 made up of Islamic states like Bangladesh, Egypt, Indonesia. Turkey, Malaysia, Iran and Pakistan. The regime maintained a light grip on Nigeria and clamped into detention any person perceived to be expressing opposing views on both domestic ami international issues. Apart from visiting South Africa in 1994 during the- swearing-in ceremony of Nelson Mandela, Ahacha did not pay state visit to any major country of the world. Even when his state of health required prompt medical attention abroad, Abacha chose to withdraw to his cubicle like a recluse. In short, under Abacha Nigeria became a pariah in the comity of nations.

In a flagrant display of arrogance, lunacy and diplomatic indecorum, the Abacha junta executed Ken-Saro Wiwa and his eight kinsmen against responsible public opinion and world - wide plea for leniency. What is more, the execution was carried out in the most heinous and barbaric manner (with a report that acid was poured on the bodies of the environmentals activists) in November, 1995 when a Commonwealth summit of Heads of States and Government was holding in Auckland, New Zealand. This act earned Nigeria a suspension from the Commonwealth.

What was of paramount importance to Abacha was the security and sustenance of his regime. Having devolved all foreign relations responsibilities to Tom Ikimi; his External Affairs Minister, Abacha embarked on only highly

secretive and short-flight trips.

However, despite all these failures in identifying and protecting national interests, Abacha continued to advance the leadership position of Nigeria in the West African sub region through ECOMOG. With Nigerian prop, as noted by Ajayi, the ECOMOG attained the sub-regional goal of enforcing peace, keeping peace and returning normalcy to Liberia after brokering many peace accords between the warring factions until the Abuja Accord of August 1995 which was later-reviewed in August, 1996.[57] It can therefore be safely said thai Nigeria under the aegis of ECOMOG midwifed a multi - party democracy in a general election which led to the emergence of Charles Taylor as Liberian President. On the other hand, ECOMOG effort in Sierra Leone led to the liberation of Freetown from the clutches of the Paul Koromah - led junta which head sacked Tejan Kabbah's civilian regime. Ultimately, Tejan Kabbah was restored back to his position as the *bona-fide* President of Sierra Leone. In both instances (Liberia and Sierra Leone), the Nigeria's military diplomacy was applauded by the OAU, UNO, United States and the Liberian and Sierra Leonean peoples.

With no remarkable achievements at home, the Abacha regime began to appeal to the patriotism and nationalistic instinct of Nigerians, calling on them to preserve and jealously guide their independence against any foreign infiltration. Thus, the five year regime of Abacha marked an erosion of the gains Nigeria had made in the previous years. Nigeria became a country, like a plague, to be avoided by foreign investors and tourists.

**From Darkness to Dawn: External Relations under General Abubakar.**

Following the least - expected death of Abacha on June 8,1998, General Abdusalami Abubakar became the Head of State of Nigeria. Abubakar came to the saddle with two major tasks; to midwife democracy in Nigeria and bring sanity into our foreign relations. He tested the international cllimate by paying two visits to South Africa in quick succession: one was for bi-lateral purpose and the other, to attend a non - aligned nations' meeting. To demonstrate the willingness of the international community to accept Nigeria back like the proverbial prodigal son, the Secretary General of UNO, Kofi Annan and Emeka Anyaoku of the Commonwealth visited Nigeria at the early period of the regime. In Abubakar's own words, his administration "will consolidate old friendships, will win new ones and repair damaged relations" He also called on the international community to participate in the privatization programme, to invest in export-oriented industries and for Nigerian creditors to grant her debt reliefs.[57] Fundamental steps were taken towards repairing damaged relations. Mr. Ignatius Olisemeka, a foreign affairs expert, replaced Tom Ikimi while Abubakar paid state visits to Togo, Republic of Benin and Niger among other countries in the West African sub-region.

Three months to his regime, General Abubakar visited Britain and had audience with the Prime Minister Tony Blair. He traveled later to the United States to address the 53rd session of the United Nations General Assembly. There and then, he appealed to the international community to assist "in the implementation of our programmes and policies aimed at uplifting the living standards of our people".[58] He had audience later with President Bill Clinton. He also paid a state visit to France. Within the first three months, Nigeria was brought back to the fold of civilized comity of sovereign nations.59

The task of transition to civil rule started on a good note in February 27, 1999 when the presidential election was conducted. Chief Oliisegim Obasanjo emerged as the country's democratically elected President and he was sworn - in on 29th May 1999.

On the whole, Nigeria's external relations under Abubakar witnessed a re- engineering and rapid spate of repair. This was a clear departure from the Abacha style that reduced Nigeria to an isolated member of the civilized community of humanity.

**Nigeria's External Relations under Chief Olusegun Obasanjo: A Preliminary Analysis.**

The Obasanjo-led civilian government came into office amid pomp and pageantry on May 29,1999. This marked an end to-years of oppression under the jackboots of military impostors and a new hope for better life domestically

and improved image abroad was kindled. The previous experience of the new President and his unarguably monumental influence in world politics call for such optimism. Continuing from where Abubakar stopped in 1999, the Obasanjo regime embarked on winning back old friends and establishing fresh contacts. The regime struggled hard to get Nigeria back to the fold of the Commonwealth of Nations. This was attained in 2000 when Nigeria was re - admitted back to that body.

In a desperate bid to restore the confidence of the international community in Nigeria, the new administration set up the Independent Corrupt Practices and Allied Offences Commission (ICPC) to fight the scourge of corruption. This has largely established a credible image for the government and Nigeria abroad. All the sanctions imposed on Nigeria in the dark days of Abacha have been lifted and Nigeria is once again respected both within Africa and in the outside world. It is our hope that the positive trend already established would be sustained and even improved upon in subsequent years.

**Conclusion**

Thus far, the external relations of Nigeria from independence to year 2000 has been discussed in this chapter. Covering the first forty years of the country's independence, the chapter establishes a thesis that within these forty years there have been no fundamental or spectacular changes in the trend and pattern of foreign relations. The relations under various regimes have largely tilted towards the western hemisphere with Britain and USA as the leading partners. There is no doubt, therefore, that there is a strong nexus between the colonial history of Nigeria and its post-independence external relations and foreign policy. The experience of the Balewa years clearly epitomized the neo-colonial trend. And the cosmetic' changes recorded under the Gowon regime were predictably ephemeral. j

However, it is crucial to note that while Africa has continuously remained the center of focus in Nigeria's foreign relations over the years, the various regimes did not always share exactly the same perception of the intricacies of the international system. Neither did they conceptualize Nigeria's role within the system or the strategies for attaining the country's goals in the same fashion. The nature of government may explain this. From independence to 2000, the country has been governed by three civilian and seven military regimes.

The frequency of military incursion into politics robbed Nigeria of a leader that started a revolutionary phase in the nation's foreign relations. Muritala's meteoric stay in the corridor of power marked a radical phase which was partially sustained by his immediate successor.

Shugari took over and, at the start, demonstrated his religious commitment to the cause of Africa. But the unbridled corruption and executive recklessness of that regime reverted Nigeria back to the subservient position of the Balewa days. Thus, Nigeria embarked on the search for solutions to economic problems in terms of securing loans from abroad. This signified a skewed economic relations which placed Nigeria at a mere service end. This position of bastardized economy continued under Buhari who could not undertake a radical position in diplomatic matters as he might have chosen. The 'no-nonsense' nature of that regime presented it as an offshoot of the Muritala/ Obasanjo regime. But without a strong and formidable economy, there was little it could do.

The Babangida years particularly from the time SAP was introduced, were years of hardship for Nigerians. The nation's economy became tied to the western capitalist economy. All economy - related policies were influenced from abroad. The annulment of the June 12, 1993 election became the last straw which brought general criticism and condemnation on Nigeria from the international community. Such was the situation through the eighty - two days of ING, until Abacha took over in November, 1993. Abacha foisted on Nigeria, the most despotic regime ever known in the country. In short, Nigeria remained a pariah in the comity of nations for a large part of the

Abacha era. Abacha neither had a clear idea of what national interests Nigeria might pursue nor thought of the necessity of pursuing such. The international image of Nigeria was thus almost irredeemably impaired.

This presented the succeeding Abubakar administration with the herculean taks repairing damaged relations

andinitialing fresh friendship. With determined effort, Abubakar achieved this within a short while and handed over power to Chief Olusegun Obasanjo. Since 1999, the Obasanjo government has not rested on its oars in securing a full blown re - integration of Nigeria into the international system, while at the same time seeking for debt relief as well as foreign investment in the country's economy.

From the foregoing, there are enough lessons to be learnt from history (particularly with our experience in the civil war, oil boom and other sundry developments) to serve as guide in policy formulation and actual conduct of external relations in the years ahead.

**Notes and References**

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13. C 1. Idang, Nigeria: **Internal Politics....p. 16**
14. Idang, **Nigeria....p.** 6
15. Amechi, O. *Nigeria and the Superpowers* in Akinyemi A.B et.al. (eds.) Nigeria since Independence…….. p. 56
16. *Ibid.* p. 54. for additional details on Nigeria's relations with the Kasicm block, see Dudley, **An Introduction.**.. .p. 279
17. Idang, Nigeria....p. 14
18. *Ibid.y.* 16 *Ibid.* p. 18
19. Dudley, **An Introduction** ....p 285
20. Otubanjo, *Introduction....p* 5
22. This was with the exception of Shell -BP. Negotiations were furthered during Gowon's visit to London in 1974 and 35% of the company's share was bought.
23. Quoted from Dudley, **An Introduction...** .p 288.
24. For a justification for this, see Adeniran, T. *Nigeria and Great Britain* in Akinyemi, A.B et.al. (eds.) **Nigeria since Independence....p 35**

12

## OF ECONOMIC GROWTH AND DEVELOPMENT IN NIGERIA SINCE 1960

**OLUKOYA OGEN**

### INTRODUCTION

The study of economic history provides yet another intellectual platform for a proper understanding of the historical dynamics of the Nigerian State since 1960. This chapter examines the major socio-economic changes that have taken place in Nigeria since independence and the extent to which such changes have impacted positively or negatively on the living standard of Nigerians. The paper concludes that fundamentally, these changes have not been able to engender rapid economic transformation and sustainable social development.

Philosophically speaking, this work is situated within the context of the epistemological premise of "economic determinism". This concept emphasises the fact that the economic superstructure of any society is indispensable to an understanding of its socio-political and cultural framework.[1] A caveat must however be sounded here, the theory of economic determinism does not assume that history is to be explained in economic terms alone but rather that the most fundamental consideration in human progress are social considerations and the primary determinant of social change is the economic factor. Thus, our emphasis is not on the fact that economic factors "exert an exclusive influence but that

they exert a preponderant influence in shaping the progress of society".[2] Consequently, in assessing the rate of growth and development of the Nigerian state since 1960, we cannot but rely heavily on the socio-economic variables of contemporary Nigerian political economy.

**Conceptual Clarifications**

Scholars often employ the concept of development as if it is synonymous with economic development or growth. More worn some is the fact that the concepts of economic growth and economic-development are inadvertently used interchangeably in development discourse.[3] It is important to clarify and in the process draw out the differences among these three concepts.

When the national income i.e. the total output of a country is increasing, then the country may be said to be experiencing economic-growth. Economic growth may also be viewed in terms of increases in per capita income in a given country. The per capita income of a country is usually calculated by dividing a country's total national income for a year by the total population.[4] It has however been found out that there are several instances where a country's national income is increasing but very little or none of it finds its way into the hands of the poor segment of the population because the lion share has been appropriated by the ruling class and its associates. This is the major reason for the grossly inadequate expenditure on education, public-health, housing and family welfare in most developing countries. Indeed, certain patterns of economic growth actually widen the gap between the rich and the poor like during the period of the Structural Adjustment Programme (SAP). This tendency must have informed Kuznets' popular hypothesis that the initial effect of growth will be to increase inequality and that this trend could only be reversed when a certain level of Gross National Product (GNP) has been attained.[5]

The emphasis on quantitative increases in national income rather than qualitative improvement in the living standard of the generality of the population is what fundamentally distinguishes economic growth from economic development. It is interesting to note that modernization theorists right from the time of Emile Durkheim, Talcott Parsons, Gabriel Almond and down to W. W. Rostow measured economic development in terms of quantitative macro economic indicators based on neo-classical economic theories, using per capita output, Gross National Product (GDP) e.t.c as indices for measuring economic development.[6] Such an approach is too narrow and simplistic. Economic development is a multidimensional phenomenon and it involves the unity of two elements, these are quantitative growth and qualitative change. It connotes the increases in the quantity and quality of basic life sustaining goods and services such as food, shelter, clothing and health. It further includes the provision of qualitative employment, education, the eradication of poverty and the equitable distribution of wealth.[7] According to Dudley Seers, the questions to ask about a country's economic development are threefold:

*... what has been happening to unemployment? What has been happening to poverty? What has been happening to inequality?*[28]

There is no doubt that economic development entails a reduction in these three basic life-sustaining variables.

It is also important to clarify the concept of development itself since it is often mistakenly assumed to be synonymous with economic development. Dudley Seers has rightly suggested that development should always be used to mean social development, which is a broader concept than economic growth or economic development. According to Susan George, development can have only one valid objective, the promotion of the welfare of all people in all strata of society at a given time.[9]

As a very broad concept, development connotes positive changes in the structures, attitudes and institutions of a given country as well as the acceleration of economic development, the eradication of poverty and human misery and the reduction of inequality.[10] In its broadest sense, the World Bank opines that the challenge of development is the improvement in the quality of life of the people. This encompasses,

*as ends in themselves, better education, higher standards of health and nutrition, less poverty, cleaner environment, more equality' of opportunity, greater individual freedom and richer cultural life*.[11]

Thus, development is distinct from simple economic growth or the pursuit of narrow economic development. It is an all-embracing concept, which emphasises sustainable socio-development. It also has three core values which represent common goals sought by the whole of humanity. These are (1) *Life Sustenance* which relates to the ability of an individual to provide his basic needs, (2) *Self Esteem* which connotes a sense of worth and the dignity of the human person and (3) *Freedom* which involves the freedom from social servitude, ignorance, dogmatic beliefs as well as the freedom to choose from a range of political, economic and social choices.[12] Thus, for economic development to be meaningful, its social dimension has to be incorporated.

**The Structure of the Nigerian Economy Since 1960**

Since the 1940s Nigeria has been concerned with how to achieve rapid socio-economic development. There is no doubt that the quest for development served as the fundamental factor for the clarion call for self government. This is understandable because colonial rule only ensured the effective control and integration of the Nigerian economy to that of Britain for the primary benefit of the British economy. For example, there was little or no attempt at eradicating poverty and achieving sustainable development because there was no clear-cut policy for economic development. The attempt at industrialisation was at best modest and colonial policy did not permit indigenous technological development. However, with the attainment of independence, the Tafawa Balewa government built more roads, schools and hospitals. Roads constructed in the 1960s were still patterned after the colonial model of road construction by which roads were mainly feeders of railways but later there was a renewed emphasis on the construction of roads for social and developmental purposes.[13]

The railway also became a corporation and was extended to cover 3,557 kilometres. This is with a view to tapping the produce of the then 3 regions and to aid the distribution of imports in the country. There was also a perpetuation of the commercial revolution that started with the introduction of commodity exports in the 19th century. Many European firms which had hitherto concentrated solely on retail trade invested in modern manufacturing concerns in the major cities of Lagos, Ibadan, Kano, Enugu. Port Harcourt and Kaduna.[14] The period also witnessed a steady growth in the involvement of the Nigerian private sector in the Nigerian economy.[15]

| | 1958/59 % | 1962/63 % | 1966/67 % | 1970/71 % |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ture | 68.4 | 61.5 | 54.4 | 50.0 |
| | 0.8 | 2.1 | 5.0 | 11.6 |
| cturing | 4.4 | 5.8 | 7.3 | 8.0 |
| Transport/Constuction | 7.3 | 9.6 | 9.8 | 8.2 |
| | 19.1 | 21/0 | 23.5 | 22.1 |

**Source:** M.A. Olagunju (2000), p.98

It is necessary at this stage to aitempt an overview of some of the major sectors of the Nigerian economy.

**The Agricultural Sector**

The Nigerian economy during the first decade after independence could reasonably be described as an agricultural economy. Agriculture served as the engine of growth of the overall economy. From the standpoint of occupational distribution and contribution to the GDP, agriculture was the leading sector. During this period Nigeria was the second largest producer of cocoa, largest exporter of palm kernel and largest producer and exporter of palm oil. Nigeria was also a leading exporter of other major commodities such as cotton, groundnut, rubber and hides and skins.[16] The agricultural sector contributed over 60% of the GDP in the 1960s and despite the reliance of Nigerian peasant fanners on traditional tools and indigenous farming methods, these farmers produced 70% of Nigeria's exports and 95% of its food needs.[17]

**Table 2: Agricultural Component of GDP, 1960-1974**

| Year | Value in -million | % of GDP |
|---|---|---|
| 1960 | 1,423.8 | 63.4 |
| 1965 | 1,691.8 | 54.9 |
| 1970 | 1,787.4 | 51.3 |
| 1974 | 3,246.5 | 24.7 |

**Source:** S.O. Olayide (1976), p.26

The First National Development Plan (1962-68) allocated 13.6%' to agriculture. Under the Third National Development Plan of 1975-80 government became directly involved in the commercial production of food crops. Erstwhile public companies like the National Grains Production Company, the National Roots Product ion Company and the National Livestock Production Company played leading roles in this regard. The federal government also invested in quite a good number of agro-allied industries especially that of pulp and paper at Iwopin, Jebba and Oku Iboku. Sugar factories were established at Numan, Lafiagi and Sunti.[18] The poultry and livestock sector also witnessed the emergence of the Nigerian Dairies Company Limited, National Poultry Production Company Limited and the National Animal Feeds Company Limited to mention but a few.[19] The Nigerian Agricultural and Co-Operative Bank (NACB) was also established in 1973 as part of government's effort to inject oil wealth into the agricultural sector through the provision of credit facilities to support agriculture and agro-allied businesses.[20]

In spite of these efforts and with the emergence of crude oil as a major foreign exchange earner, the agricultural sector that was the traditional source of food, employment and export earnings became disrupted and dislocated. Again, the over-emphasis on export crops production in the '60s ensured that the production of food crops was relegated to the background. [21] Consequently, as from 1975 Nigeria became a net importer-of various agricultural products. In 1982 alone, Nigeria imported 153,000mt tons of palm oil at the cost of 92 million USD and 55,000mt tons of cotton valued at 92 million USD. Between 1973 and 1980, a total of 7.07 million tons of wheat, 1.62 million tons of rice and 431,000 tons of maize were imported. Thus, from -47.8 million in the 60s, the cost of food imports in Nigeria rose to -88.2 million in 1970 and -1, 027 million in 1988.[22]

**Table 3: Value of Nigeria's Food Imports, 1960-1975 (-million)**

| | 1960 | 1965 | 1970 | 1975 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 0.6 | 0.4 | 1.0 | 0.2 |
| onery | 0.09 | 0.06 | 0.06 | 0.2 |
| | 0.3 | 0.4 | 0.5 | 1.0 |
| | 0.5 | 0.02 | 0.05 | 0.1 |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | 0.02 | 0.03 | 0.04 | 3.2 |
| | 1.5 | 1.2 | 0.2 | 3.2 |
| | 0.3 | 0.6 | 1.1 | 4.4 |
| | 0.59 | 1.09 | 1.84 | 15.69 |
| | 3.9 | 3.8 | 4.8 | 24.8 |

**Source:** Deji Ogunremi andE.K. Faluyi (eds.) (1996), p.261

This appalling situation became worse despite the fact that the 4th National Development Plan (1981-1985) allocated N3 billion to the agricultural sector. Eleven River Basin Development Authorities were also established throughout the country. Multinationals such as Texaco, Leventis, United Africa Company (UAC) and Lever Brothers invested heavily in large-scale commercial agricultural ventures. But then domestic demand far outstripped the productive capacity of the agricultural sector. For example since the 1990s Nigeria has been spending an average of 60 million USD on the importation of rice. Indeed, in 1994, the agricultural sector performed below the projected 7.2 per cent of budgetary output.[23]

According to Adebayo Lawal, between 1995 and 1998 government further embarked on a number of measures to increase agricultural productivity. Some of these measures include the reformation of the lending policy of the Agricultural Credit Guarantee Scheme (ACGS) for easier access to agricultural credit, the establishment of the Calabar Export Processing Zone (EPZ) and the initiation of the Enugu, Kaduna, Jos, and Lagos EPZs, specialising in specific food and export crops. The Nigerian Commodity Exchange (NICOMEX) was also established. In fact, the National Rolling Plan for 1996-1998 assumed that by year 2000, Nigeria would have been able to feed its population, develop the capacity to process agricultural raw materials both for local industries and for export and significantly increase the contribution of the agricultural sector to the GDP.[24] These lofty goals have turned out to be a mirage. As a matter of fact, the sector which accounted for over 60% of Nigeria's export in the 1960s now account for less than 5%.[25] The reasons for this abysmal failure will be.highlighted later in this piece.

**The Industrial Sector**

Before 1960, industry's contribution to the GDP was negligible. In 1957 for instance, it contributed only 2.8% or N37.8million to a GDP of Nl, 372.2 million. The few existing industries then were restricted to brewing; vegetable oil extraction and tobacco processing.[26] The 1960s witnessed the birth of assembly plants for the production of electronics, bicycles, sewing machines e.t.c. The industrial processing of agricultural and other raw materials was also given a boost. Firms that specialised in the production of confectionery, building materials, plastics, tyres, shoes, paints, batteries e.t.c. also sprang up in several major cities. Indeed, the sector's contribution to the GDP increased from 4.6% in 1960/61 to 5.9% in 1965/66 and to 9.4% in 1969/70.[27] The sector also recorded a mean annual growth rate of 15.5% between 1960 and 1975. In 1960 the industrial sector generated a total revenue of N80.6 million, by 1975 this figure had moved up to N683.9million.[28]

Given the phenomenal rise in oil revenue in the '70s and '80s, government invested heavily in several major industries such as petrochemicals, plastics, fertilizer, newsprint, iron and steel rolling mills, refineries, liquefied natural gas and vehicle assembly plants among several other industrial concerns. Despite these efforts the industrial sector remained weak and unstable. This is mainly because Nigeria's attempts at economic development by way of industrialisation relied heavily on external stimuli and lacked internal dynamism.[29] The Import Substitution Industrialization Strategy (ISI) that Nigeria adopted has led to more distortion in the Nigerian economy because expected foreign exchange earnings and conservation as well as economic diversification have not been forthcoming.[30]

Since 1980 the fortunes of the sector have largely been on a downward spiral. The sector recorded a negative growth rate of 3.6% between 1981 and 1987. Its contribution to Nigeria's GDP was 10.7% in 1985 but this declined

to 8.1% in 1990. In 2001, the sector's growth rate was -0.3%. The organised private sector has put the blame for the dismal performance of the industrial sector on the economic policies of government which it believed have engendered spiral inflation, high costs of production, low capacity utilisation, inadequate foreign exchange e.t.c. Government on the other hand has often blamed the operators of the industrial sector for its selfishness, insincerity and sharp practices.[31] The government even alleged that,
*the manufacturers have not been manufacturing, but importing consumable goods for resale at high prices for a high turnover.*[32]

As will he shown in this chapter both excuses appear too simplistic and diversionary. The explanations tend to ignore the complexities and intricacies of Nigeria's fundamental economic problems.

**Transport and Construction Sectors.**
With the attainment of independence, there was a remarkable effort at expanding social infrastructure. The construction industry boomed, several roads, highways and bridges e.t.c were constructed. Schools, including institutions of higher learning, hospitals, airports and seaports were also built. For example, the paved roads in Nigeria increased from 8,740 kilometres in 1960 to 28,632 kilometres in 1980 (an increase of 327.5% in 20 years). And in 1990 this increased to 59,000 kilometers, (an increase of 206% in 10 years). Nigeria paved roads network increased to 171,328 kilometres in 1996. (another impressive 290.3% increase in just 6 years). As at 2000 Nigeria could boast of having 193,200 kilometers of highways.[33] Moreover, many major highways were also dualized throughout the country apart from several flyovers and bridges that were constructed during this period. It is instructive to note that the Third National Development Plan (1975-80) specifically had as its main thrust the development of essential infrastructural facilities. Actual investment at the end of the plan period amounted to N42.3billion despite the fact that the plan initially envisaged a total investment of N30 billion.[34] The building and construction sub-sectors recorded a mean annual growth rate of 19.4% between 1960 and 1975. While the transport and communication sub-sectors which generated a total revenue of N97.8million in 1960 moved to N325million in 1975.[35] However, it is most unfortunate that most of these infrastructures, especially roads are in a terrible stale of disrepair due to lack of effective maintenance.

**The Power Generation Sector.**
It is often said that the amount of energy used in a country is a true reflection of its state of socio-economic development. This thinking is informed by the fact that the performance or non-performance of the power sector has a lot of repercussions on the entire economy.[36] Before the Electricity Corporation of Nigeria (ECN) took over the supply and generation of electricity in the country in 1951, power supply was the responsibility of Native Authorities and the Public Works Department in specific areas. Shortly after independence, power systems were established and developed for each of the then existing three regions. The total installed capacity of all the system was however below 220,000 kw.[37]

In 1969 the Kainji Dam was commissioned and this raised Nigeria's power generating capacity from 484.9 megawatts in 1968 to 804.0 megawatts in 1969.[38] The dam was initially under the control of the Niger Dam Authority (NDA) but the NDA was later merged with the ECN to form the National Electric Power Authority (NEPA) in 1971. NEPA has been coordinating energy generation and supply from hydro and thermal based technology. Between 1981 and 1985, two hydro power stations were established at Oji River and Jebba and four thermal stations at Afam. Kaduna, Makurdi and Ikorodu, to bring NEPA's total generating capacity to 5194 megawatts. This figure fell to 1600 megawatts throughout the 90s and NEPA became *'Never Expect Power Alway'*. But with the renewed commitment of the civilian government of President Olusegun Obasanjo, Nigeria now generates more than 5,000 megawatts.[39] Even then, NEPA has not been able to meet the rising demands of its consumers. Its performance has largely been epileptic. Daunting problems like theft of NEPA equipment, illegal connections/disconnections and corrupt practices by NEPA's personnel remain intractable.

**The Oil Sector**

The history of the Nigerian petroleum industry began in 1908 al Araromi area of Ondo State when hydrocarbons were discovered in the area. The discovery was then considered not commercially viable. It was not until 1956 that Shell discovered oil in commercial quantities at Oloibiri, Rivers State. Thus, Oloibiri became the pioneer oil village in Nigeria. "'Beginning from early 1970s, crude oil production and the revenue den vcd from it has remained the prime mover of the Nigerian economy. The country's balance of payments, exchange rate policies, monetary and fiscal policies as well as the various National Development/Rolling Plans have been dependent on revenue from oil.[41] There was an astronomical increase in the price of oil from 3.78 dollars per barrel in 1970 to 14.69 dollars per barrel in 1974. The contribution of crude oil to the Gross National Product (GNP) increased from a mere -163.4 millfon in 1967 to N6,552.3 million in 1975. The revenue from oil also increased from -176.4 million in 1970 to N4.18 billion in 1984.[42]

The percentage contribution of oil to Nigeria's GDP was only 2.6% in 1960, this figure moved up to 32.6% in 1965 and 65% in 1970. By 1982 it had risen to 98.6%.[43] Ever since then petroleum has remained a prime factor in the Nigerian economy. Indeed, between 1970 and 1983 alone, earnings from oil amounted to over 140 billion USD. Nigeria thus became a fertile ground for international business. Studies have found out that in the early 1980s, there were about 150 American, 200 British and 130 French corporations operating in Nigeria.[44] As at 1988, Nigeria was among the top 20 producers of crude oil in the world and the 7th largest producer within the Organisation of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC). With an average production of 1.07 million barrels per day in 1988, Nigeria was the 4th largest exporter of crude oil in the world and the 2nd largest within OPEC.[45] The oil sector contributed a projected sum of N22.5 billion to the revenue estimate of -29.4 billion in 1989, N214 billion out of an estimate of N340 billion in 1986 and N243 billion out of a revenue estimate of N404 billion in 1997.[46]

Before 1971, the major activities of the oil industry were in the hands of foreign concerns while Nigerians played a nominal role. The Nigerian National Oil Corporation (NNOC) was set up by the government in 1971 as an integrated oil company and this marked a greater participation by the Nigerian government in the oil industry. The NNOC and the then Federal Ministry of Petroleum were merged in April 1977 lo form the Nigerian National Petroleum Corporation (NNPC). Since then (he NNPC have taken control of the refining, distribution, marketing and seismic data services of the oil industry.[47] The influence of oil is so pervasive to the extent that oil exports currently account for about 95% of Nigeria's export earnings and more than 80% of government revenue.[48] The above picture is however not the real story of oil in Nigeria. The actual story is one of opportunities missed by successive Nigerian governments, corruption and mismanagement. It is quite obvious that the mismanagement of petrol dollars has created several problems some of which include, the retardation and stagnation of the agricultural sector,[49] port congestion and biting inflation. It is most unfortunate that fuel scarcity remains an intractable problem in a leading oil producing country and the squalor, poverty and environmental degradation in the oil producing Niger Delta region is better imagined.

Thus, in spite of the historical role of agriculture and the emergence of crude oil, the development realities in Nigeria was such that in 1995 the Human Development Index (HDI) ranked Nigeria as the 13th poorest country in the world.[50] Today, the economy is plagued by poverty, unemployment, incessant power failures, congested ports, deteriorating roads, water shortages, unreliable telecommunication facilities, poor education and health facilities and contradictory government fiscal policies. In fact the situation has deteriorated to such an extent that the Nigerian Economic Summit Group reported in 1999 that only 15% of Nigerians have access to potable water, only three Nigerians in every 1000 have access to a telephone line and only 30% of the population have access to power supply which is even epileptic.[51]

**Table 4: Gross Domestic Product at Current Factor Cost (1994)**

| Sector | N Billion | % Share |
|---|---|---|
| ure | 345 | 39.0 |
| & Quarrying | 240 | 27.0 |
| turing | 57 | 6.4 |
| & Construction | 10 | 3.1 |
| t | 28 | 3.1 |
| and Insurance | 13 | 1.5 |
| | 152 | 17.0 |

**Source:** Kola Daisi (1999), p. 108.

In order to fully appreciate the fundamental nature of the socio-economic problems plaguing the Nigerian economy it is important to appreciate the neo-colonial character of the Nigerian State. The development implications and social dimension of its economics of corruption must also be put in its proper perspective. We shall briefly examine the following three cardinal phenomena.

(1) *The Structural Adjustment Programme (SAP).* The emphasis on SAP is informed by the fact that, until its emergence in 1986, Nigeria was a middle income

**Multilateral Imperialism/Debt Peonage**

Beginning from the late 70s, the Nigerian government started seeing the problems of underdevelopment in terms of poor industrial technology, weak domestic institutions and most importantly, lack of adequate capital. Consequently, every successive Nigerian government holds on tenaciously to the belief that modem technology has to be imported, the economy must be opened up for direct foreign investment and additional capital sought from multilateral financial institutions. But rather than leading to development, multilateral imperialism or the excessive borrowing by Nigeria from multilateral lending institutions has further undermined the Nigerian economy and truncated the gradual and steady process of development that started shortly after independence.[66]

In 1970, Nigeria's external debt was ameagreN488.8 million, in other words external debt constituted only 9.2% of GDP." In fact, Nigeria's foreign exchange was so comfortable that it was in a position to lend money to the IMF under its Oil Facility in 1974. Interestingly enough, Nigeria's first external loan of 28 million USD taken in 1958 for railway extension was fully paid back.[68] The turning point however came in 1978 when oil prices crashed and Nigeria had to borrow 1.0 billion USD for balance of payment support from the International Capital Market (ICM). Between 1979 and 1983, there was an indiscriminate resort to external borrowing ostensibly to finance development projects.[69] The result was a tremendous increase in the level of debt outstanding.

Nigeria's external debt increased from 4.6 billion USD in 1980 to 20 billion USD in 1985, thereby constituting

about 160% of GDP. This made the condition of an import dependent economy to become critical. External debt outstanding shot up rapidly to 31.424 billion USD in 1989 and 35.4 billion USD in 1995. By the end of 1995 the Paris Club was being owed about 21.7 billion USD which represented 66% of Nigeria's total external debt in 1986.[70]

**Table 6: Nigeria's External Debt and Value of Export (1960-1995)**

| Year | Debt in billion USD | Value of Export in ~ million |
|---|---|---|
| 1960 | n.a | 339.4 |
| 1970 | n.a | 885.4 |
| 1980 | 4.60 | 14,077.0 |
| 1985 | 20.0 | n.a |
| 1988 | 29.2 | 27,101.7 |
| 1989 | 31.4 | n.a |
| 1995 | 35.4 | n.a |

**Source:** Akintayo Fasipe (ed.) (1990), pp.7-8

In August 2000, Nigeria received a debt restructuring deal from the Pans Club and an additional credit of 1 billion USD from the IMF. As at 2002, Nigeria's total indebtedness to the London Club stood at 3.33 billion USD. It is alarming that even companies such as the Nigeria Airways before it was privatised recently to become Nigeria Global was indebted to the tune of -1.2 billion in foreign debts. Furthermore, Nigeria's domestic debt has been estimated at N1.6 trillion.[71]

J.O. Sanusi, the Central Bank governor listed six major factors that contributed to Nigeria's over-bloated debt portfolio. These are (1) low saving propensity of Nigerians (2) unrealistic exchange rate (3) poor external debt management (4) financing of long term projects with short/medium term loans (5) declining foreign exchange and high import bills and (6) diversion of loans to other uses.[72] What Sanusi failed to add is the active encouragement given by creditor nations in order to ensure that Nigeria continues to borrow (piling up more debts in order to remain perpetually indebted) and this fitted perfectly into the theory of "Foreign Capital for Third World Development".[73] The theory is essentially a debt trap by Western creditor nations to continue the exploitation and domination of poor countries. This point becomes clearer when we consider the costs, which the servicing of these numerous debts have imposed on Nigeria, and how it constitutes a threat to development. A ready example will suffice here.

In 1989, Nigeria obtained a loan of 27.7 million USD from the World Bank. The loan was to mature in 15 years at 7.65% interest rate per annum.[74] The implication of the conditions attached to the loan is that Nigeria would pay an interest of 2.11 million USD, which is 7.65% of the capital every year for 15 years on a loan of 27.7 million USD. At maturity the interest would have totaled 31.785 million USD, bringing the total money due to be paid by Nigeria to 59.4 million USD.

It should be noted that I have based my calculation on the simple sum of the interest on this facility, Akintayo Fasipe, for instance, calculated the compound sum of the interest on this loan to arrive at a total figure of 85.654 million USD.[75] This illustration is just a tip of the iceberg and it is meant to show how Nigeria's debt burden constitutes a hindrance to economic development.

**The Economics of Corruption**

Corruption in Nigeria has become a way of life. It constitutes perhaps the biggest clog in Nigeria's quest for growth and development. In a nutshell, the economic effects of corruption according to K.A. Ogundipe include the under-

utilisation or misallocation of resources, an increase in economic crime, income inequality, inadequate supply of public goods, low manpower utilisation and unemployment. Others are, loss of human capital, increased cost of investment and production, formulation of ineffective economic and social policies, balance of payment deficits and even political instability.[76] The list seems endless but the aggregate effect of all these is that economic development is seriously undermined. Kayode Eso puts it more succinctly;

*Corruption as it is, is more evil than what it amounts to and more evil than our legislation could cope with. It has pervaded every sector of our lives. Law enforcement agents and agencies take bribes openly, but this has become the least form of corruption. Four -one-nine (419) has gone digital and it surfaces in every area of human interest.*[11]

The pharmaceutical industry is replete with cases of fake drugs. Universities' admissions and degrees are often questioned. But more worrisome is the fact that almost every successive Nigerian government have turned out to be the godfathers of corruption. The first republic was noted for allegations of obtaining 10% of fund allocated to projects as bribes. The Gowon regime became renowned for the high level of corruption by its governors and federal commissioners. The Shehu Shagari government was highly reputed for its moral decadence and condemned for being exceedingly corrupt.[78] Professor Pius Okigbo revealed a missing 12.4 billion USD gulf war oil windfall in 1994. Indeed, the Babangida regime was widely believed to have siphoned 25 billion USD. Sani Abacha managed the economy "primarily for the private benefit of himself and his favoured asssociates".[79] The Abacha loot has been estimated at about 6 billion USD. In 2002, the Abacha family returned 168 million USD to the Nigerian government. Most surprisingly, the Abacha accounts frozen by the Swiss authorities have been estimated at 270 million USD.[80]

Perhaps the most horrendous and appalling thing about the Abacha loot was the deal entered into by the federal government with the Abacha family, in which the federal government conceded 10% of the 6 billion USD stolen by Abacha to his family while the government got the remaining share of the loot.[81] The implication is that, it appears there was a unanimous agreement between the government and the Abacha family that stealing is not sinful as long as one steals enough, money that can guarantee him an opportunity of returning part of his loot. According to a United Nations estimate, about 120 billion (15.6 trillion naira) has been stolen from the coffers of Nigeria since independence.[82] In order to fully appreciate the extent to which corruption has become institutionalised in the country, Nigeria's National Assembly recently repealed the bill setting up the Independent Corrupt Practices Commission (ICPC) which was set up in 2000. The Commission's chairman, Justice Akanbi recently accused the legislators of repealing the bill in order to shield themselves from being prosecuted for their corrupt practices.[83]

**Major Strategies for Revamping the Nigerian Economy**

Historically speaking, the roots of the crisis in the Nigerian economy lie in the neglect of agriculture, the increased dependence on a mono-cultural economy based on oil and the pervasive role of government in economic activities, which has resulted in inefficiency, wastage and corruption. To the above must be added the structural distortions and poverty induced imbalances and inequalities that emanate from the neo-colonial character of the Nigerian State.

A careful perusal of the 2001 IMF/World Bank report on the 'State of the Nigerian Economy'[84] reveals the glaring lack of control of the Nigerian economy by the Nigerian government. Virtually all the economic decisions taken by the government ranging from fiscal policies, macroeconomic reforms, exchange rate, balance of payment and debt rescheduling strategies were masterminded by the IMF. Given the lessons of historical experience, one expects the government to appreciate the fact that the IMF/World Bank and other multilateral lending institutions were primarily designed to serve the interests of Western capitalist economies. Right from the inception of SAP and up to this current craze for globalisation, IMF's policies have been targeted at ensuring that more capital moved out of Nigeria to finance industrial and technological development in Europe, the United Stales and Japan.[85]

Impeccable economic historical evidence shows that no country throughout the world has ever developed by the wholesale adoption of free market principles as preached by the IMF. The claim by its adherents that free trade is

the route to economic growth is fallacious and gravely ahistorical. The United States developed her industrial prowess behind massive protectionist walls, Japan used a shielded competition model. Taiwan and other Newly Industrialised Countries relied on a strong entrepreneurial state to govern their markets and promote local industries. No country past or present has taken off into sustained economic growth and moved from economic backwardness to modernity without large scale government protection and subsidization of infant industries and other modes of insulation from domination by powerful outsiders.[86]

Capitalist neo-liberal prescriptions for Third World underdevelopment should be taken with circumspection. After several decades of arguments and counter arguments on the need to restructure the prevailing world economic order and accelerate economic development in the South, the desired concessions from the North have failed to materialise, no debt forgiveness, no technological transfer and no appreciable foreign investment.[87]

Again, Nigerian policy makers need to be wary of development economists who assign a relatively minor role to agriculture in economic development and fervently believe that industrialisation is synonymous with economic development.[88] As argued elsewhere, any attempt to neglect or de-emphasise the agricultural sector in national planning is a false approach to development and any developmental theoretical formulation to the contrary is fraught with fundamental inadequacies. The study of economic history provides us with ample evidence that an agricultural revolution is a fundamental precondition for economic development. Increases in agricultural productivity have always been the traditional path to industrialisation and there is no industrial i sed country in the world today that did not first build a strong agricultural base.[89]

In Nigeria, the reverse seems to be the case, as a matter of fact, the limited quantum of fund available to the agricultural sector has been diminishing over the years. Only 3.4% of Nigeria's capital expenditure was allocated to agriculture in the 1996 budget. This figure diminished to 2.9% in 1997, 2.6% in 1998 and 1.4% in 1999. Even the government's agricultural credit schemes have not fared better. Of the total -866.4 billion credit advanced to the Nigerian economy between 1970 and 1996, only 13.4% or -116.1 billion went to the agricultural sector.[90] There is no gainsaying the fact that the Nigerian government needs to redirect its attention to the agricultural sector to ensure sustainable development and food security. Government must also display the will to effectively implement its own agricultural policies.

Apart from agriculture, another area that can hasten the diversification of the resource base of the Nigerian economy is the solid minerals sector. It is heartwarming to note that the Ministry of Solid Minerals was established primarily for the exploitation of 32 solid minerals hitherto untapped.[91] Again, government must strive to create an enabling environment for the development of the real/ productive sector of the economy to attract investment. For any economy to thrive its real sector must be adequately developed. A recent survey by Phillips Consulting reveals that the most attractive sector for investors in the Nigerian economy is the non-real service sector. About 80% of the respondents were only interested in service related investments. In fact, the agricultural and manufacturing sectors were not chosen at all in the responses.[92] These two neglected sectors are the only sectors that are involved in actual production, manufacturing and the conversion of basic raw materials into finished goods.

In addition, the high level of corruption in all strata of the Nigerian society must be addressed. To fight this hydra-headed monster, an appreciable level of poverty reduction must have been achieved and this will effectively check petty corruption. Corruption thrives most in an atmosphere of absolute poverty. I doubt if a policeman will find it expedient to shoot a commercial bus driver over the non-payment of a N20 bribe, if the policeman is well paid and can afford the basic human needs such as food, clothing, shelter, educational and medical services for himself and the immediate members of his family. Other strategies for fighting corruption include the reduction of income inequality through taxation and income transfer programmes to the poor, public condemnation and increase in the probability of punishment for corrupt people, the existence of an efficient bureaucracy and the availability of honest and responsible leadership. Nepotism should be outlawed and meritocracy recognised while law enforcement

agents should be properly re-oriented and equipped to fight corruption.[93]

Another important strategy is for Nigeria to embark on a Knowledge Driven Economy (KDE). In the advanced economies and the NICs, knowledge is a strategic asset for economic development. The high level of development in these countries is largely due to the availability of a highly skilled workforce. The concept of a KDE,[94] is one in which the generation and exploitation of knowledge has come to play the dominant part in the creation of wealth. The concept also connotes the effective use of all types of knowledge and creativity in all manner of economic activity. Government will have to ensure that people have access to good qualitative education. A complete overhauling of the educational system and a serious injection of resources is necessary to ensure that our schools can produce high quality graduates who are articulate, highly skilled, IT literate, innovative and entrepreneurial. They should also be able to generate ideas, solve complex problems and take risks.

Another secret of development is the use of the mother tongue as the mode of instruction in our schools. No nation develops by using a foreign language. Every developed country in Europe, Asia and America uses its own local language. Malaysia, which was economically less developed than Nigeria in the 60s, is now a comfortable member of the league of NICs; unarguably, studies have found out that the advantage of using Malay rather than English language as the official language contributed significantly to making Malaysia what it is today. In a multi-ethnic state like India, each state is entitled to choose its own regional language up to the degree level in engineering sciences.[95] It is unfortunate that so many brilliant Nigerian chaps are prevented from acquiring university education because of the colonial hangover that they must have a credit in English language.

Equally important is the expansion of Nigeria's physical and social infrastructures. Regular supply of electricity and a functioning and an efficient transport and communication system should be vigorously pursued. Better and accessible telecommunication, warehousing and storage facilities must also be provided. There is also the need for efficiency in tapping resources, ordering priorities, targeting needs and achieving optimal production of goods and services,[96]

**Concluding Notes**

There is no doubt that Nigeria has witnessed significant changes in its quest for economic development since 1960. There is also an appreciable improvement in the provision of infrastructural facilities. However, these changes have not significantly reduced the level of poverty in the country. It is sad to note that a country which is reputed to have earned about 280 billion USD between 1970 and 2000 has more than 66% of its population living below the poverty line i.e. a dollar per day. Life expectancy is between 50 and 52 years. And in spite of the fact that Nigeria produces an average of 2 million barrels of crude oil per day, it still imports 70% of its fuel requirements.[9]

With a GNP of some 38 billion USD, the size of the Nigerian economy is undeniably small. The Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) estimated Nigeria's per capita food supply between 1968 and 1988 to be 104 calories of energy per day, compared to the world's average of 2,677. The country's per capita income which in 1980 was 1,160 USD plummeted to 260 USD in 1996.[98] Thus, economically, Nigeria at 43 appears to be a non starter, the country's infrastructures are down, power supply is epileptic, the roads are in a terrible state of disrepair and petrol queues are long, winding and chaotic. But then all hope is not lost given the fact that the Nigerian economy offers vast investment opportunities because of its numerous strategic natural endowments among which are natural gas, petroleum, bitumen, columbite, iron ore, coal, limestone, lead, tin and Zinc. Nigeria is equally blessed with an abundant and vibrant human population, which is currently estimated at about 129,934,91 l.[99]

To add credence to this optimism, for instance, the telecommunication sub-sector has witnessed tremendous improvement in the last three years. The number of fixed wireless lines increased from 450,000 lines in 1999 to 702,000 lines in 2002 while mobile lines leapt up from a modest 30,000 lines to about 2 million lines during the same period due to the advent of the Global System for Mobile Telecommunications (GSM). Indeed, it was the telecommunication sub sector that arrested the downward spiral of the Nigerian economy in 2002.[100] Again,

the International Finance Corporation (IFC) opines that the Nigerian Stock Market has constantly outperformed returns on investment in emerging markets in the past few years.[101] No doubt Nigeria is one of the potentially richest countries in the world, what is required is an efficient management of Nigeria's natural and human resources and the effective implementation of policies that can stabilise and engender socio-economic development.

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13

# THE DEVELOPMENT OF TECHNOLOGY AND INDUSTRIALIZATION IN NIGERIA SINCE 1960

**DAVID AWORAWO**

## Introduction

This chapter examines the development of technology and industrialization in Nigeria from 1960 to the beginning of the 21st century. It discusses British attitude to technology and industrialization in the country in the colonial period and the level of industrial development when Nigeria became independent in 1960. This analysis provides the background for assessing the progress made in the post-independence period up to 2002. The nature and changes which took place in technological and industrial development in Nigeria since 1960 are also discussed, as well as the factors responsible for their low level of development. The concluding part analyzes the problems and challenges of the development of technology and industrialization in Nigeria in the period covered.

In this chapter, we use the word 'technology' in the general sense of "the scientific study and use of applied sciences, the application of this to practical tasks of industry"; while industrialization refers to "the process of producing goods, especially in factories".[1] It is the process of the development of these in Nigeria since independence that constitutes the focus of this chapter.

## Level of Technological and Industrial Development at Independence

When Nigeria gained independence from Britain in 1960, it was not advanced in the areas of technology and industrialization, which was also the case in other areas such as education and health. During the nearly one century of British rule in Nigeria, the development of technology and industrialization did not receive enough attention and the result was the low level of industrial and technological development in 1960. The reason for this is easy to understand. The philosophy of European colonialism in the 19th and 20th centuries was that Africa should be kept as a source of cheap raw materials to feed the industries in Europe and to serve as a market for its finished products.[2] Embarking on intense technological and industrial development was therefore tantamount to destroying the basis of colonialism itself. The fact that the British colonial authorities strongly encouraged the cultivation of cash crops easily explains this.

The development of technology and industrialization requires conscious effort, a reasonable amount of resources and a clear aim which is to promote scientific study and research, the results of which are used to make machines and other inputs for mass production of goods and to ease the laboriousness with which services are carried out. There was a tremendous advancement in this area in Europe in the second half of the 18th century and in the 19th century in what has been described as the "industrial revolution". By the turn of the 20th century, Britain, which blazed the trail in the industrial revolution, had recorded a great leap in its economic development, and the resources from the colonies and the markets they provided played a great role in this.[3] Britain did not want to disrupt this condition and her desire to maintain the status quo meant little or no attention to the development of technology and industrialization in the colonies which included Nigeria.

However, some attention was paid to scientific research and industrialization during the two world wars when it was difficult to import manufactured products from Europe. After the end of World War II in 1945, the British colonial authorities seriously considered the possibility of establishing an office to co-ordinate the development of commerce and industries in Nigeria. This led to the establishment of the Department of Commerce and Industries in 1946. This office had as one of its major assignments the conduct of research on a small scale and the promotion of industrial development.[4] The activities of the Department enhanced the development of technology and industrialization at its inchoate stage in the 1940s.

Further attention was paid to the development of technology and industrialization in the 1950s. In September 1952, a World Bank mission came to Nigeria on the invitation of the British government to conduct a survey on the state of technology in Nigeria and ways of improving it. The mission submitted its report in 1954. It observed that research efforts had not been systematic and recommended that an institute of applied technical research be established.[5] Following this recommendation, the British colonial authorities provided the sum of £260,000 which was used to establish the Institute of Applied Technical Research in 1956. This Institute, which later became the Federal Institute of Industrial Research, was responsible for coordinating research into new methods of production throughout Nigeria from when it was established until independence and even after under its new name. It earned out research in many areas, but the most prominent ones were the use of wi Id fibres for the making of sack, the use of local dyestuff for textile manufacture and the mechanization of the production of *gari.*[6] Some of the research efforts had actually commenced before the establishment of-the Institute of Applied Technical Research, but it continued from where they were inherited and struggled to ensure that they were completed so that the results could be put to good use.

The application of the modest achievements recorded by the Institute of Applied Technical Research and the few breakthroughs made before its establishment, which included the results of the research efforts of the West Africa Institute for Oil-Palm Research, constituted the level of technological development of Nigeria at independence.[7] There was, of course, local technology which continued to feature prominently in the production techniques of Nigerians. However, in most instances this was rudimentary. In fact, the research efforts of the post-World War II period was basically aimed at improving on the indigenous technology which was regarded as laborious and unsophisticated.

A similar trend was recorded in the area of industrial development. The post-World War II attention to the production of some goods in Nigeria, especially those items in which raw materials were available, resulted in the establishment of many new factories in the 1950s. This received a boost from 1955 onwards following the introduction of the Lyttleton Constitution in 1954, which transferred the responsibility for industrial development to the regional governments. The Nigerian leaders who assumed responsibility for administering the regions saw industrial development as a way of stimulating economic development. They therefore put in place policies and incentives to encourage investors. Some of these included the provision of finance in form of loans to assist private entrepreneurs. This was important since lack of capital was one of the major problems faced by industrialists, especially the indigenous ones, during ihe period. It was in accordance with this objective thai the Federal Government established the Federal Loans Board in 1956. In addition to this, the government at the center established the Investment Company of Nigeria in 1959 with the assistance of the Commonwealth Development Finance Company. The main objective of the Investment Company was to provide finance and technical assistance to companies engaged in manufacturing, agriculture and mineral exploitation.[8]

In addition to the provision of assistance to entrepreneurs, the government at various levels was involved in direct investment in industrial production as well. In 1959, the government of Eastern Region formed the Industrial and Agricultural Company to promote manufacturing and agricultural production. The Northern Nigeria government established the Northern Nigeria Investments Limited which carried out a similar function with the Eastern Region's Industrial and Agricultural Company. Long before this time the government of Western Nigeria had established the Western Nigeria Development Corporation which had been involved in industrial manufacture since 1954.[9] Apart from this, the; Western Region embarked on the development of infrastructure on a large scale which was aimed jat providing a boost to industrial production. 'All the efforts greatly' stimulated industrial development in Nigeria between 1954 and 1960.

Indeed, it can be said that the little autonomy which was provided by the 1954 Constitution was exploited by Nigerian leaders to give a leap to the country's industrial development.[10]

At independence in 1960, Nigeria had a total of 389 industrial establishments." Many of these were engaged in

the production of soap, cement, tobacco, textile and brewing. At this time, the country's population was estimated at about 50 million. Products from these factories were grossly inadequate to meet the needs of the teeming population. The result was that Nigeria continued to import much of the manufactured products it needed. This was the state of mdustiiuli/ation in Nigeria on the attainment of sovereign statehood. Taken along with the state of the development of technology described earlier, it can be concluded that the level of industrial and technological development of Nigeria at independence was very low.

**The Development Technology and Industrialization since 1960**

In the first half of the 1960s, Nigeria continued to build on the foundations of the two previous decades in the areas of industrialization and technological development. The Federal Institute of Industrial Research continued to bear the responsibility for carrying out studies into vuiblc industrial endeavours and for assisting new manufacturing establishments by offering guidance on effective use of raw materials and machines. Thus, the study into the production of jute bags and mattress filling from coconut fiber continued after independence. The same was true of the research into the industrial production of *gari* and pulp for papermaking. The latter culminated in the establishment of a paper mill at Jebba in 1963.[12] However, following the political crisis which broke out across the country in 1966 and the civil war which began in the second half of 1967, industrial research received very little attention until 1970.

The process of industrialization followed a similar pattern. There was rapid progress from 1960 to 1966, but things slowed down from 1967 and picked up again from 1970. For instance, while there were 687 manufacturing establishments in Nigeria in 1964, which increased to 776 in 1965, the number fell to 625 in 1968 as the civil war raged.

*However, after the war ended in 1970, the number rose to 703 ai the end of that year and jumped to 1,054 in 1972.*[13]

*In 1970, the Second National Development Plan was formulated to guide the development of the country for five years. Emphasis was placed on industrial and technological development in the Plan. The same was true of the Third National Development Plan (1975 to 1980) and the one that followed from 1980 to 1985. The Third and Fourth Plans specifically committed the government to the establishment and expansion of a Research Products Development Company, an Institute of Industrial Research and industrial development centers. Accordingly, the government established the Industrial Research Council of Nigeria in 1971 which was affiliated to the Federal Ministry of Industries. The agency was established to co-ordinate industrial research activities in Nigeria and organize for the application of the results to practical industrial activities.*[14] *Also, a National Council for Science and Technology had been established in 1970, which was replaced by the National Science and Technology Development Agency (NSTDA) in 1977. This Agency became a full ministry, the Ministry of Science and Technology in 1979. This ministry became the apex body for the coordination of research and technological development all over the country.*[13] *Following this, all the twenty-three research and development institutes in the country came under the control of the ministry. In addition, universities of technology were established in the 1980s with the objective of expanding research in the areas of science and technology.*

*There is no doubt that much attention has been paid to Nigeria's technological development since 1970. In 1986, a national policy on science and technology was formally launched by the government to "promote scientific and technological manpower development" and to "encourage local research and development activities in both private and public enterprises".*[16] *However, up to the end of the 20th century, Nigeria remained a technologically backward country. The problem was obviously not that of poverty of policy or blueprint but commitment and provision of the enabling environment for technological advancement.*

*As for the development of industrialization, a steady progress was recorded from 1970 to 1975 as the price of oil, which became Nigeria's major export commodity, continued to rise in the international market. The total number of manufacturing establishments in Nigeria rose from 1,054, with 127,162 people employed in 1970, to 1,290 establishments with 244,243 people employed in 1975. The value of production also rose from -844,638,000 to -2,611,091,000 during the same period.*[17] *However, by the end of the decade, things had begun to slow down as a result of the fall in the price of oil in the international market and global economic recession. The trend continued throughout the 1980s. Table two shows the performance of manufacturing establishments in Nigeria from 1963 to 1980 and reveals the trend already described.*

***Table 2: Trend of Manufacturing Establishment in Nigeria, 1963-80. (Employing Ten or More People)***

| *Year* | *Federation Total* | *Federation Total* | *ation Total -'000* | *leration Total -'000* |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *1963* | *646* | *65,798* | *274.402 .* | *109,860* |
| *1964* | *687* | *763.342* | *358,778* | *137,466* |
| *1965* | *776* | *95.614* | *444.872* | *172,582* |
| *1968* | *625* | *86,728* | *503,038* | *207,672* |
| *1969* | *639* | *102,532* | *636,036* | *209,228* |
| *1970* | *703* | *127.162* | *844,638* | *392,704* |
| *1972* | *1,054* | *167,626* | *1.046,640* | *494,855* |
| *1973* | - | - | - | - |
| *1974* | *988* | *166,540* | *1,339,966* | *1,185,334* |
| *1975* | *1,290* | *244,243* | *2,611,091* | *1,750,499* |
| *1976* | *1,276* | *271.382* | *3,814,820* | *1,989,465* |
| *1978* | *1,064* | *300,397* | *6,921,399* | *3,504,547* |
| *1980* | *1.243* | *290.690* | - | - |

***Source:*** *J. Akintola Arikawe, "The Rise of Industrialism in the Lagos Area", in A. Adefuye* et al, *(eds.)* History of the Peoples of Lagos State, *Lagos: Lantern Books, 1 1987, p. 112.*

The economic recession which characterized the 1980s adversely affected industrial development. In 1986, the government introduced the structural adjustment programme, which was expected to turn the economy around and stimulate industrialization. This, however, accomplished very little. As part of the reforms, the government decided to pay more attention to the development of small scale enterprises (SSEs). The National Economic Reconstruction Fund (NERFUND) was established in 1989 to grant the SSEs loans with low interest rates. After six years of operation, only 88 projects had received some form of assistance from the agency. The Peoples Bank of Nigeria (PEN) which was established also in 1989 had a similar experience with the NERFUND.[18] It was established to grant loans to SSEs with low interest rates and to assist groups of artisans and traders to start or expand business by providing loans and guidance. Although it performed fairly well in the first three years of its establishment, the PBN soon became a haven for people with little or no interest in the development of SSEs.

The result was that in the second half of the 1980s and throughout the 1990s, the industrial sector in Nigeria continued to perform poorly, contributing to less than ten per cent of the GDP. The sector recorded a negative growth rate of 3.6 percent between 1981 and 1987. Capacity utilization also continued to dwindle. In 1992, the average manufacturing capacity utilization was only 37.2 per cent.[19] The political crisis which engulfed the country following the annulment of the 12 June 1993 elections further adversely affected the performance of manufacturing as it did to all the other sectors of the economy. In 1993, the contribution of industrial manufacturing to the Gross Domestic product was a paltry 7.4 per cent. This decreased to 6.9 per cent in 1994, and further down progressively throughout the rest of the decade.[20] Only a slight improvement was recorded in the opening years of the 21st century as the new civilian government of the Fourth Republic struggled to improve the fortunes of the

industrial sector, with very little success.

What remains to be discussed is the reason for the low level of technological and industrial development in Nigeria since 1960 in spite of the recognition of their importance and despite all the efforts of successive governments in the country.

**Reasons for Low Level of Technological and Industrial Development**

An examination of the process and means by which Nigeria tried to pursue its technological and industrial development since independence brings to light the reasons for the low level recorded during the period. It is important to understand these factors in order to be able to make positive recommendations on the problems.

As far as technological development is concerned, a major reason for its low level is lack of commitment on the part of government and relevant agencies. The measure of attention that is required for a country with abysmally low level of technology like Nigeria has not been given. This is reflected in the amount of resources allocated to the sub-sector and government policies to regulate it. Ernest Shonekan noted in 1990 that "there is no gainsaying that compared with many other countries worldwide, Nigeria and other African countries allocate paltry resources to research and development".[21] Between 1971 and 2001, allocations to the development of science and technology was an average of about 0.9 per cent of the federal budget and 0.3 per cent of the Gross National Product (GNP).[22] When this is compared with allocations to defense which averaged over 10 percent in the same period, the problem of technological development in Nigeria can be well appreciated. Ebun Davies observed that "this is unlike the level of funding for science and technology in the developed countries where allocations to scientific research range from 2 to 3 per cent of the GNP".[23] With inadequate attention and resources, it is hardly surprising that the level of Nigeria's technological development has remained low.

Closely related to this is the attitude of Nigerian industrialists. The average Nigerian industrialist is too much in a hurry to get returns on investment. He is therefore reluctant to commit resources to research and development, which makes technological advancement possible. All too often, Nigerian industrialists are content with assembling or even just packaging products which makes it possible for them to quickly secure their returns. In such an environment technological advancement could hardly take place.

The lack of adequate commitment on the path of government and the attitude of Nigerian industrialists combine to create an acute shortage of equipment and material required for technological development. Thus, both at the Institute of Industrial Research and the different polytechnics and universities of technology, the prevailing condition is that of shortage of equipment to cany out research. Bereft of materials to work with, the average researcher with interest and energy often ends up frustrated. A few of these manage to find their ways abroad where they have the right equipment to work with and where a conducive environment exists. Some of these have gained popularity after making intriguing breakthroughs. Of course such feats can only benefit the countries where such Nigerians are based. Such is the experience of Nigeria's technological development.

For industrial development, the factors which have hamstrung its expansio'n are related to those discussed above for technology. In many respects government policies and activities have played a great role in this. In this regard, a major problem which has been identified is that of the path taken by the government to promote industrialization both during the colonial period and since independence. Like most other countries of the Third World, Nigeria adopted the import substitution industrialization (ISI) as its strategy for industrial development. This is the strategy whereby the final stages of industrial production are completed in a country with inputs imported from other countries usually more technologically advanced.[24] It was thought that this strategy would help to generate employment, increase real per capita income, promote forward and backward linkages[25] and stimulate local industrial capacity through some sort of technology transfer.

In the Nigerian case, the expected positive effects of this strategy have failed to materialize. Studies have revealed that although the amount spent on total imports declined in the first two decades of Nigeria's

independence, an addition of the amount spent on the importation of machinery, spare parts, foreign technical personnel and raw materials, gives a far higher figure than if finished products had been imported: In addition, not much employment has been generated and the much desired technology transfer as well as forward and backward linkages have not taken place. In separate studies, Onwuka Njoku and Festus Egwaikhide have concluded that the ISI strategy has been an abysmal failure in its application in Nigeria, especially from independence to the end of the 20th century. Egwaikhide stated that "after more than three decades of its implementation, it became clear that this model may not be the panacea to Nigeria's underdevelopment".[26] For Njoku, at independence hopes were high regarding the capacity of the ISI strategy to gradually but surely transform Nigeria to an industrial giant in a few years. However, at the end of the 20th century, "the expectation... proved forlorn. Four decades after independence and industrial production, the imported technology of the manufacturing firms has not been able to nurture a viable technological capability."[27] The conclusion therefore is that the ISI strategy failed and it has contributed to Nigeria's low level of industrialization.

There is however the question as to whether Nigerian policy makers at independence had a choice other than ISI since the strategy had already been used by the colonial authorities long before 1960. Another is whether there was an available alternative even if the inadequacies of the strategy were known. These are questions to which there are as many answers as there are analysts. What is however beyond dispute is that the vast majority of the newly independent countries in different parts of the world from the 1940s adopted the ISI and in most of them the expected positive results failed to materialize.[28]

Apart from ISI there have been numerous policies of government which have militated against industrial development. Some of these relate to import regulations which have been inconsistent, and different kinds of taxes that have been imposed by the government at various levels. A case in point was the land charges which was introduced by the Lagos State Government in 2000 which caused a great deal of disquiet among owners of factories in the State. It was not after intense criticism and fierce resistance that the government was compelled to drastically reduce the charges after about three years.

Closely related to the above is the problem of securing capital for industrial development. Loans provided by commercial and merchant banks have for many decades now, attracted interests beyond the twenty per cent mark. This is in addition to the stringent conditionalities that are attached to the granting of such loans. The interest rates simply make it impossible for industrialists to go for bank loans even when they are able to fulfill the requirements for securing loans from banks. For a period, in the 1970s and 1980s, the Nigerian Bank for Commerce and Industry (NBCI) which was established in 1973, and the Nigeria Industrial Development Bank (NIDB) came to the rescue. But their efficiency was short-lived as a result of several constraints, not the least was inattention on the part of government and corruption of the officials of the banks.[29] In the first decade of the 21st century, the dearth of capital remained one of the greatest problems facing industrial development process in Nigeria.

As noted above, corruption played a vital role in the failure of government efforts to establish special banks to provide funds for industrial development. It should be stated that corruption, which has become endemic in Nigeria since the 1980s, had deleterious effects on the development of both technology and industrialization in the period covered in this work. Virtually all the agencies involved in the formulation and execution of government policies on industrialization ended up becoming enmeshed in one form of corruption or the other.[30] This is well illustrated in the efforts of successive governments in Nigeria since 1970 to develop the iron and steel industry which is regarded as very crucial to industrial development.

Efforts to develop the iron and steel industry in Nigeria began in 1958 when some Western European firms were contracted to carry out feasibility study on the iron and steel industry. The result of the study was negative. However, in 1967 a Russian firm was contracted to do another study and the result was positive. Following this, a decree was promulgated in 1971 which established the Niger Steel Development Authority.[31] Work began on

the Delta Steel Complex, Aladja (DSCA) in 1979 and the Ajaokuta Steel Company (ASC) in 1981. The Aladja Steel Complex managed to function for a while in the 1980s and early 1990s, producing at about 20 percent capacity before being shut down. The, Ajaokuta Steel Complex scarcely produced anything after over $3 billion had been spent on it. In August and September 1996, M. Wakawa, the Managing Director of the Ajaokuta Steel Complex auctioned vital equipments of the company at "ridiculously give-away prices" and with impunity. By 1997, ASC was owing Tiaproexport (TPE), the contracting Russian firm $3.1 billion. The Abacha government arranged for a debt buy-back deal in which Panar Shipping Corporation (PSC) of Liberia bought the debt for $500 million. Surprisingly, the Nigerian government bought back the bills from PSC (which was obviously working on behalf of the Abacha family) for the original price of $3.1 billion. The difference of $2.6 billion was said to have been shared between the Abacha family, Bashir Dalhatu, then Minister of Power and Steel, and Anthony Ani, then Minister of Finance.[32] By the end of 2002 the iron and steel industry in Nigeria remained comatose, producing nothing and bogged down by billions of dollars of debts. The nagging problem of corruption would therefore need to be tackled for Nigeria to make any meaningful progress in its industrial development efforts.

Yet another reason for the low level of industrialization in Nigeria is poor infrastructure. It is common knowledge that in most parts of Nigeria even the most basic infrastructure such as roads, water and electric power are either non-existent or function poorly. In many instances, industrialists have had to provide these themselves with result that the cost of production has been very high. In fact, it has been calculated that production cost in Nigeria is one of the highest in the world. A major consequence of this is that due to high cost of production, imported goods are sometimes cheaper than those made in Nigeria. This makes goods produced in Nigeria to be uncompetitive and attempts to export them extremely difficult.

The frustration of industrialists as a result of poor infrastructure is well illustrated in the case of electric power supply. The agency established by government to carry out this important function is the National Electric Power Authority (NEPA). It was created in 1972 from a merger of the Niger Dam Authority which was established in 1950 and the Electricity Corporation of Nigeria.[33] In spite of its long period of existence, in many parts of Nigeria, electricity supply from government source is non-existent as a result of not having been connected to the national grid. In most other parts where electrification has been carried out, supply is so epileptic that most times owners of industry rely more on private generators. The cost of running generators being so high, irregular power supply from public source inevitably leads to high cost of production. The problem has been compounded by the acute shortage of refined petroleum products which has become a major feature of Nigeria's energy sector since 1993. The consequence is that it has been difficult to secure petroleum products to run generating sets when there is power outage from government source. Some factories are known to have shut down temporarily during periods of scarcity of petroleum products. All these leave the industrialist frustrated and both local and foreign entrepreneurs are discouraged from embarking on projects of industrial production.[34] It is for this reason that scholars of Nigeria's industrial development are agreed that rapid development of infrastructure is necessary for any substantial improvement of industrialization in the country.

The factors responsible for the low level of technological and industrial development in Nigeria are many and diverse as is evident from the above discussion. These would need to be addressed before there can be an improvement in the fortunes of these important facets of the country's national life.

**Conclusion**

The above analysis has revealed that Nigeria has not fared well in her quest for industrial and technological breakthrough since independence. It has remained a challenge which has not been successfully tackled over the years. The realization that virtually all the countries that have become economically strong and stable, with a high living standard for its people, have attained substantial level of industrialization, has made it important for the government and people of Nigeria to be concerned about the low level of industrialization of the country.

Our analysis has shown that there is an interlocking relationship between research and industrialization. For the result of the former stimulates the development of the latter. There is therefore the need for attention to be paid to

research. There is also the need for a change of attitude on the part of policy makers and entrepreneurs alike. It is a fact that the results of the little research that has been carried out have generally not been utilized and researchers have not been encouraged. Entrepreneurs need to realize that it takes time for the returns on investments on industrialization to be secured. Being too much in a hurry to get their returns has turned many an industrialist in Nigeria to a trader where they are sure of quick returns.

Undoubtedly, the bulk of the responsibility for improving the level of technology and industrialization in Nigeria rests on the government. The government at various levels would need to formulate sound and consistent policies. They would also need to pay attention to the expansion of infrastructure and provide a conducive environment for researchers and industrialists to function. The wide range of problems identified earlier would need to be addressed for the fortunes of technology and industrialization in Nigeria to improve in the rapidly changing economic climate of the 21st century.

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16

**AGRICULTURAL DEVELOPMENT IN NIGERIA SINCE 1960: POLICIES AND PROGRAMMES**
**O. S. SALAMI**

## INTRODUCTION

The importance of agriculture cannot be over emphasized. They are important sources of employment, food, raw materials, foreign exchange and revenue for government through taxes, grading fees etc; (Galleti et al, 1956 and Olayemi, 1972).

During the pre-colonial and colonial era agriculture provided most of the country's food, earned, foreign exchange for the country and generated a significant proportion of government revenue. For most part of this period, self-sufficiency in food production was taken for granted. Hence, most of the early efforts to develop the country's agriculture were concentrated on export of cash crops like cocoa, palm oil and groundnut. These efforts were on setting up Marketing Board for distribution of the major export crops and research institutes for agronomic research into the crops. FMA (1984).

The first time that Nigeria experienced a food problem was during the Second World War (1939-1949) when due to war disruptions, agricultural activities declined. This problem reduced and only featured during Nigeria civil war (1967-1970). Agriculture did not fare better in the 80s and 90s. Despite the fact that the country is blessed with both human and material resources needed to make the country self sufficient in food production.

Nigeria did not have an explicit statement of national agricultural policy for most of its history as a nation. The publication of such a document in 1987 was a welcome relief for policy analyst and other stakeholders (Idachaba, 2000). Hitherto, the best was the chapter on agriculture in the first four National Development Plans and budget documents. In spite of the various policies and programmes on agriculture as contained in the development plans and the national agricultural policy of 1987, the performance of the sector was still low. The plan objectives and targets were rarely achieved.

This main objective of this paper is to review governments major agricultural policies and programmes from 1960 to 2000. This paper has five sections. Section one introduces the discussion. Section two presents the conceptual framework. Section three is devoted to the review of some agricultural policies and programmes in Nigerian history. In section four, the policies and programmes analysis and their implications were outlined. The final section contains some recommendations and concluding remarks.

## 2.0. Conceptual Framework

Agricultural policy as defined by Olayide (1980) is (he plan of action based on aims, ideals and beliefs of a government or a political party in respect of effecting a positive change in the structure, conduct and performance of the nation's agriculture. It is a general belief among economist or those concerned with the design and implementation of policies that agricultural development induces a general increase in production in the economy. (Kwanashie, 1997).

This proposition is on the basis that the structural features of the agricultural sector in these economies places the sector in a strategic position in any programme that aims at;

- arresting the decline in Sub-Saharan African (SSA) economies in the short run.
- improving trade and payment balances.
- generating medium term economic growth; and
- engendering a long-term transformation of these economies (Kwanashie etal, 1997).

Ricardo in his principle of Political Economy and Taxation believed that a limitation on the growth of agricultural output set the upper limit to the growth of the non-agricultural sector and to capital formation for economic expansion. Olashore (1991) argues that there are three major stages in the evolution of agricultural production. They are: the pure, low productions subsistence farming; the diversified or mixed agriculture (produce grown for self-consumption and part for sale); and the modern farm or specialized agriculture (for commercial market only).

Olashore (1991) argues further that agriculture in most parts of the country (Nigeria) is still in the subsistence stage. There are however, a number of large plantations owned by retired military and civil servants or some conglomerates. During the pre-colonial era, however, the mode of agriculture in Nigeria revolved mainly around subsistence agricultural production.

Policies and programmes can be evaluated by situating the analysis within some particular period or by examining the policies and programmes generally without breaking them into distinct periods. Rather than analyzing the programmes for example based on Pre-SAP (1%0-1985) and post SAP (1986-2000), where some programmes were in operations during the two periods, this study adopted the first option, which ensure than programmes that were in the two periods need not be repeated. This method had been used earlier by Ihimodu (1993) to appraise SAP and Nigeria agricultural development.

Following an earlier research, Idachaba (2000) concluded that one major policy failure is the absence of requisite "policy varietal trials". Policy varietal trials are policy options that are developed and disseminated just like biological, chemical and mechanical varieties. Unlike biological and chemical varietal development, policy varieties are more of the outcome of the policy ideas and preferences of key policy actors and their advisors. While biological varieties are often introduced in phases, temporally and spatially, policy varieties are often implemented on a national scale, all at once. While biological varieties often entail a trial and error phase, policy varieties usually have no trial phase.

## 2.0 Agricultural Policies And Programmes

To a large extent this study relies on the works of Ihimodu (1993), Bankole (1996) and Salami (2000) for the review of Nigeria agricultural policies and programmes.

### 3.1. *Agricultural Policies*

#### 3.1.1. *Agricultural Policies in the Development Plans*

The Nigeria government initiated a number of agricultural policies, programmes and projects, largely within the framework of National Economic Development Plans (1962-1985). The policy objectives of the four successive development plans between 1962 and 1985 were basically the same, they were summarized by Awoseyila (1997) into 5 and are listed below:

(i). Ensuring food supplies in adequate quantity and quality to keep pace with increasing population and urbanization, having regards to changing taste and the need for fair and stable prices.

(ii). Expanding the production of export crops with a view to increasing and further diversifying the country's foreign exchange earnings.

(iii). Significantly increasing the production of agricultural raw materials to support domestic manufacturing activities especially in the field of agro-based industries in addition to export.

(iv). Creating rural employment opportunities to absorb more of the increasing labour force in the nation and minimizing the tendency for inadequate and inefficient use of human resources in the rural areas generally.

(v). Involving appropriate institutional and administrative framework to facilitate a smooth integrated development of the agricultural potentials of the country as a whole. Table 1 revealed a list of some selected agricultural policies in the second to fourth Nigerian National Development Plans.

The first plan was a ten-year plan of development and welfare for Nigeria, which was introduced in 1946. The attention of this plan with respect to agriculture was on a limited range of cash crops such as cocoa, palm produce, cotton, groundnuts and timber. Before the first National Development Plan (1962-68), which was actually the first post-independence plan, there were Federal and Regional plans between 1954 and 1962.

In the first National Development Plan, 9.8% of the capital expenditure was devoted to agriculture, the contribution of agriculture to the GDP during the plan period dropped from 61% in 1962/63 to about 58% in 1967/68 (Ayo, 1988). Only about 9.9% of planned capital expenditure was allocated to agriculture in the Second National Development plan (1970-74). In this plan agriculture recorded a negative growth rate of about 0.06%. In the third National

Development Plan, Agriculture recorded a negative growth rate of 0.1%. This was increased to a positive growth rate of 1.1% in the fourth National Development Plan.

### 3.1.2. *National Agricultural Policy*

Government adopted a comprehensive package of policy instruments in 1986 to improve the performance of the country's agricultural sector. This became necessary when all efforts to tackle the sector's problem via agricultural policies, programmed and projects, largely within the framework of the National development Plans implemented by government from the first to the fourth National Development Plans failed.

The Nigeria agricultural policies published by the Federal Ministry of Agriculture in 1987 and reprinted in year 2000 contained an evaluation of the roles and past performance of the agricultural sector and the objective of the policy. It also contained a number of macro policies on agriculture and agricultural sector policies and strategies. The policy also outlined the roles and responsibilities of the three tiers of government in Nigeria and the mechanism for the periodic review of agricultural policies (FMAWRRD, 2000).

**Objectives of the Agricultural Sector in Nigeria Agricultural Policy.**

The policy was planned to achieve the following objectives:

(i). The attainment of self-sufficiency in basic food commodities with particular reference to those food commodities which consume considerable shares of Nigeria's foreign exchange and which can be produced locally within the country.

(ii). Increased production of agricultural raw materials to meet the growing needs of an expanding industrial sector.

(iii). Increased production and processing of export crops with a view to increasing their foreign exchange earning capacity.

(iv). Modernization of agricultural production, processing, storage and distribution through the infusion of improved technology and management.

(v). Creation of increased rural employment opportunities through improvements in infrastructural facilities so as to productively absorb an increasing labour force.

(vi). Improvement in the quality of life of that rural dwellers through the provision of social amenities like potable water and improved health and educational facilities.

(vii). Improved protection of agricultural land resources from drought, desert encroachment, soil erosion and flood. (FMAWRRD, 2000).

**Macro- Policies that affect Agriculture.**

The Nigeria agricultural policy in the first National Plan devoted a chapter to macro policies. These include, pricing policy; trade policy (e.g. trade liberalization, export promotion, tariff regulation); backward integration; agricultural investment promotion; exchange rate policy, and agricultural land policy (e.g. land use decree, agricultural land etc).

**Agricultural Policies and Strategies.**

This includes policies that affect food production (i.e. crop, livestock, fishery, forestry and wildlife) and industrial raw material production. The main objectives of food crop production are self-sufficiency in food production; and improvement in the level of technical and economic efficiency in food crop production.

The strategies for achieving these are through the network of Agricultural Development Project (ADPs); Back- to-the- Land; input supply (seed, water, land, fertilizer, agro-chemical supply), plant quarantine and gene banking); and input subsidy.

The livestock production general policy objective is to put all available livestock resources into best use. This will be achieved through increased production either by expanding the resource base, by increasing the productivity of the existing resources through a systematic improvement of the national production system or both. The strategies to achieve this policies are outlined under the following headings; ecological specialization; sedentarisation; livestock feeds; livestock breeding; animal health; incentive; veterinary public health; animal by products

development; input supply; and input subsidy.

The fish production policy objectives as contained in the Nigeria agricultural policy can be summarized as follows:

* The achievement of self-sufficiency in fish production within five years.
* Provision of fisheries infrastructures e.g. potable water, schools, roads, electricity etc.
* Development of and modernization offish production, processing, storage, and marketing by adoption of improved technology and management practices.
* Acceleration of fisheries research and improvement in existing fisheries training programme. To achieve this objective, the policy outlined some strategies under the following headings; production mode; provision of economic incentives; fish investment services; fisheries organization and input improvement of the quality of life in fishing areas.

The policy on forest products aimed at achieving self-sufficiency in wood products through the employment of ground forest management principal and techniques as well as mobilization of human and material resources. The strategy to achieve this included ecological specification (i.e. zones suited for parks, games reserve and wilderness recreation facilities; establishment of national forest patrol services; establishment of private and communal forest; launching of a forest trust fund; adequate supply of inputs; and input subsidy.

The Industrial Raw Material Production (i.e. Industrial crop production and agricultural by products) were given attention in the policy. The targets of the government are the complete local sourcing of industrial crop raw materials in five years and the revival of their export.

Government also aimed to meet the internal demand of processed agricultural by products such as bone meal, blood meal, fish meal, and so on, in the shortest time possible. The strategies for achieving these policies are adequate supply of input, input subsidy; backward integration by agro-industries; back-to-land programme; abattoir development and quality control.

The agricultural policy also covered agricultural support services. These include agricultural extension, technology development and transfer agricultural credit; agricultural insurance; agricultural produce marketing, agricultural commodity storage; agricultural commodity processing,; agricultural research; agricultural cooperatives; Land resources; pest control; agricultural mechanization; water resources development, rural Infrastructure; agricultural statistics and data bank; agricultural investment and management advisory services, and agricultural manpower development and training.

Some of the major programmes or organization introduced or to be strengthened in the agricultural policy under the above stated support services are: Establishment of demonstration farms and rural processing demonstration centers for crops, livestock, fisheries and forestry; establishment of rural specialized banks (State Agricultural and Co-operative Banks) with Nigeria Agricultural and Cooperative Bank (NACB); establishment and initial funding of the agricultural insurance scheme; restructuring of technical committee on agricultural produce and the export commodities co-operating committee; revitalize the strategic grains reserve; adequate funding of research institutions; production of land use maps; establishment of land management committees is all states; development of the National Center for Agricultural Mechanization; retention of River Basin Development Authorities and State Water Boards; provision of rural Infrastructure (e.g. feeder roads, waterways, rural electrification, health, educational, banking and recreational facilities); establishment of central agricultural data bank; establishment of national remote sensing center; and strengthening of agricultural investment bureau.

## 3.2. Agricultural Programmes

Some of the agricultural programmes as contained in the development plans, national budgets and agricultural policies are reviewed in this section. Some of the programmes has been terminated, some are still on going. There is yet others that have restructured or been, merged with other programmes.

### Agricultural Research and Higher Institutions

Agricultural research began in Nigeria nearly a century ago, when the British colonial government established the botanical garden in the colony of Lagos. This was followed by full-fledged crop research station at Moor Plantation in Ibadan, crop research station at Samaru, a veterinary research station at Vom, and a forestry research station at Ibadan. In addition, a commodity research station for cocoa at Ibadan and Oil palm station at Benin were set up.

During the 1970s and 1980s, agricultural research continued to expand and faculties of agriculture and veterinary medicine were created in many of the new universities. In addition, Universities of agriculture were set up in Markudi, Abeokuta and Umudike. As at 2002 there were 18 research institutes and 23 faculties of agriculture and veterinary medicine, and three Universities of agriculture. There are five international agricultural research centers that also operate in the country; International Institute of Tropical Agriculture (IITA) has its headquarters in Nigeria; while International Crop Research Institute for Semi Arid Tropics (ICRISAT), International Livestock Research Institute (IRRI) and West African Rice Development Association (WARDA) have stations located in different parts of Nigeria (Shaib et al, 1997).

There are over 30 colleges established specifically for the training of manpower in the field of agriculture all over the country. The colleges were set up by the federal government and some state governments. Majority of these colleges were designed to train students on general agriculture. While others were set up to specifically train graduates in forestry, fisheries, animal health, fresh water, leather technology, water resources, cooperatives, wildlife and veterinary medicine. Initially, the national agricultural research system performed reasonably well with financial, human and logistic support provided since the early eighties, however, it has experienced serious set back due to drastic reduction in funding, frequent changes in government's administrative policies, and lack of clear research policy initiatives.

### Commodity Marketing Boards

Agricultural commodity marketing commenced in the 19$^{th}$ century. The pricing policy of this commodity between 1874 and 2000 followed a generation of regulated and also deregulated policy. Prior to 1938, the Association of West African Merchants controlled both internal and external trades of the British West Africa country. In 1939, the West African Produce Control Board was established (Ayorinde, 1966). In 1947, Nigeria set up four Commodity Marketing Boards as offshoot of the Regional Produce Control Board. The Boards were for cocoa, groundnut, cotton and palm produce.

These boards were set up to stabilize producer prices and producer income from year to year in the face of fluctuation in the world market prices and generate trading surplus to be used for the development of these crops (Salami, 2000). Between 1954 and 1963, following the political and economic autonomy for the regional government, Regional Marketing Boards were set up in Western Region, Northern Region, Eastern Region and Mid-Western Region in 1967. Following the creation of 12 new states, the Regional Marketing Boards gave way for new ones in the new states. In 1977, the Commodity Board act No 29 (1977) dissolved the state Marketing Boards and set up seven new Commodity Boards. By 1986 the commodity markets was deregulated with the abolition of Commodity Boards (Ihimodu, 1993, Idachaba, 1995 and Salami 2000).

### Farm Settlement Scheme

The Scheme was aimed at encouraging school leavers to take to farming and thereby developing a crop of young modern farmers.

### The National Accelerated Fish Production Programme.

This programme was established in the 70s to make fish inputs such as outboard engines, hooks, nets boats etc, available to farmers at subsidized prices.

**National Accelerated Food Production Programme (NAFPP)**

This is a joint programme of federal, state and local governments and farmers to accelerate production of grains such as maize, rice, guinea com, millet, cowpeas and root crops. This was to be achieved through the introduction of high yielding seed varieties, fertilizer, insecticide, marketing and storage facilities. Various research institutes were mandated to develop high yielding varieties of crops. An advantage was that farmers were involved at all the stages of the production package.The programme suffered from poor financing, shortage of extension staff and low market price for grains.

**The Agricultural Projects, Monitoring and Evaluation Unit**
(APMEU)

APMEU was set up in 1975 as a special unit under the Federal Department of Agriculture (FDA). APMEU provided training support to other progammes and department such as National Agricultural Research Project (NARJ) Federal Department of Fisheries; Planning Research and Statistics Department, National Accelerated Industrial Crop Production Programme (NAICPP) etc. The unit operated from its headquarters located in Kaduna, Recently, the government of President Olusegun Obasanjo merged APMEU with Federal Agriculture and Co-ordinating Unit (FACU) to form Project Coordinating Unit (PCU)

**Agricultural Development Project (ADP)**

The ADP is a joint venture of the federal and stales governments on the one hand and the World Bank on the other. The primary aims of the ADPs is to increase agricultural productivity and incomes of farmers in the areas of their coverage and thereby increase total food and raw materials supplies for the population and agro-based industries. This is to be done through providing a package of essential inputs as well an efficient delivery system through the farm service center. Some of the main features of the ADPs include the improvement of infrastructures within the project areas through the construction of feeder roads, dams for providing water for irrigation, provision of credits to farmers and other social services in the project area. Some achievements of the ADPs include land clearing for farmers; construction of access roads; distribution of farm inputs, and extension services.

**Agricultural Technology (Mechanization)**

The need for agricultural mechanization was much felt during the oil boom as a result of rural-urban migration and brought about labour shortage on the farm. Measures were then put in place to achieve some degree of mechanization. These measures include: (i) Fstabhshmcnt of Tractor Fliring Unit (THU) by government. These arc units where farmers could hire tractor at subsidized rates. The problems here are inadequate number of tractors, lack of spare parts and frequent breakdowns, (ii). The inducement of fanners to purchase their own tractors. There-was liberalization policy on importation of tractors and farmers and cooperative groups were encourage to purchase machinery at subsidized rates while payments were made in instalments; (iii). RBDAS were mandated to provide assistance on land clearing, (iv). and the establishment of a National Center for Agricultural Mechanization (NCAM) in 1981.

The NCAM is to put up a programme in the operation and maintenance of tractors and other machines and also to provide answers to problems of agricultural mechanization in the country. Such problems are how small fragmented holding of small scale farmers could be mechanized, the mechanization and weeding of intercropped farming system and mixed farming. The Centre is also to ascertain the suitability and standardization of all farm equipment. It is also to engage in research towards development of new machines and farming techniques for local condition as well as training of Nigerians in different areas of agricultural engineering.

**The Agricultural and Rural Management Training Institute (ARMTI)**

This is an institution that is jointly funded by the World Bank and the Federal Government. The institute is located in Ilorin, Kwara State. ARMTI was established to provide managerial and supervisory training for all staff at all levels of

agricultural and rural management. ARMTI has been performing well, however, the Institute needs better funding by Federal Government to make it perform effectively.

**The Livestock Development Project**

This project commenced in 1976. The objective were; commercializing beef cattle production by the establishment of large scale public breeding ranches, small scale private ranches, development of grazing reserves and the provision of supervised credit for smallholders fattening schemes for the benefit of large numbers of small scale producers.

**Operation Feed the Nation** (OFN)

OFN was launched in 1976 as an emergency national campaign designed to stimulate the interest of all classes of Nigerians in farming. It was designed to give encouragement and material assistance to farmers in form of technical advice, supply of quantities of fertilizer, improved seeds, livestock feeds, pesticides etc at subsidized prices. To implement this, management committee were set up at the federal and states levels. Also there was a national council for OFN and a state's council for each of the states. The councils were charge with policy matters while the committees were directly responsible for the implementation of the programme in liaison with State Ministries of Agriculture. Many fanners, educational institutions and civil servants benefited from this programme. The programme made impact in terms of awareness and mobilizing people for food production. But statistically, insignificant increases were added to area cultivated.

**Green Revolution Programme (GRP)**

A modified form of OFN was launched in 1980. GRP aimed at accelerated agricultural production by removing all known constraints. The scheme is wider in scope than OFN. It involves:-establishment of input procurement and distribution center; establishment of federal extension services; input subsidies and crop pricing policies are to be streamlined in keeping with the need to husband the nations resources.

The main aim of GRP is to make the country self sufficient in basic food production in five years and rehabilitate her export produce in seven years. It covers all aspects of agricultural production, food and export crops livestock, fisheries and forestry. The programme achieved significant increase in production especially through the ADP and NAFPR But distributors of farm inputs were politicians and large-scale farmers became the major beneficiaries.

**River Basin Development Authorities**

The River Basin Development Authorities (RBDAs) were established in 1975 in order to have sufficient water for agriculture and for effective use and control of water resources. Chad Basin and Sokoto Rima were established in 1975. The RBDA were restructured thereafter to eleven. They were charged with the following functions:-Undertaking schemes for control of floods/erosion; development of underground water for multipurpose uses; constructing and maintaining dams, wells, boreholes; irrigation and drainage systems; and development irrigation schemes for production of livestock and leasing of irrigated lands to farmers; controlling pollution in rivers and lakes. The National River Basin Development Commission was then established to supervise and advise on RBDA. Presently, the RBDA are under the supervision of the Ministry of Water Resources. Direct agricultural production has been removed from their functions and they are now left with harnessing water resources.

**Classification as Preferred Sector**

CBN directed all Banks to give priority to agriculture in their allocation of loans and advances (credit guidelines). The sector took preference over other sectors in terms of volume of loan and ease of granting loans. This improved the financing of agriculture.

**Agricultural Credit Guarantee Scheme Fund (AGCGF).**

The ACGSF is jointly financed by the Federal Government and CBN. It was established in 1977 with the sole objective of encouraging banks to grant loans more readily to farmers. This was to be achieved by providing a guarantee cover to banks who gives loan to the agricultural sector of the economy. The scheme was introduced because banks failed to meet the requirement of volume of loans to the agricultural sector due to the high risk in

the sector. The guarantee was expected to reduce bank risk on such loans. The fund made appreciable contribution to agricultural financing. The banks have complained about farmers poor response to payment of loans at maturity. Only small proportions of the facilities get to small-scale farmers who constituted the bulk of the Nigerian farming population.

**Nigerian Agricultural and Cooperative Bank** (NACB).

It was established in 1973 for the purpose of providing financial resources for all types of agricultural activities. It is mandated to grant loans for all types of production by individual farmers, state owned institutions for onward lending to farmers, cooperative societies etc. it is also expected to provide consultancy services to clients, assist other banks in formulating and administering agricultural credits, and enhance rural standard of living. The bank has been merged with the defunct FEAP, Peoples Bank. The new name for the bank is now the National Agricultural Cooperative and Rural Development Bank.

**Land Use Decree** (1977/78).

This is relevant to the collective farming strategy because of its bias towards large-scale production. It is the most sensational institutional reform in Nigerian Agriculture and aims at facilitating large-scale farming. Essentially, the decree is aimed at making land available to farmers and non-fanners interested in fanning. With land tenure, the right of beneficial use of a piece of land in perpetuity lies with the community of which a fanner is a member and the community may be a family or a village. With the reform of land use decree, the control of all land was vested in states' government to be held in trust for the federal government.

**Integrated Agricultural Development Projects (lADPs)**

The Integrated Agricultural Development Projects (lADPs) were conceived in the early 1970 as a means of raising productivity and farmers' incomes in the rural areas through the provision of improved seeds, fertilizers, pesticides, credit facilities, infrastructure ( roads, water supply and health care). The ADP and DFRRI were examples of lADPs in Nigeria.

**Nigeria Agricultural Insurance Scheme**

Among the measures initiated by the Federal Government of Nigeria, aimed at increasing the level of agricultural output was the Nigeria Agricultural Insurance Scheme. The scheme was launched on the 15th of December 1987, while the company that was to implement the scheme NAIC was incorporated in 1988. The scheme was designed specifically to; (i) Promote agricultural production.

(ii) Provide financial support for farmers in the event of crops and livestock losses arising from national hazard.

(iii) Induce the provision of crdit by financial institutions to farmer; and

(iv) Minimize or eliminate the need for adhoc assistance provided by the Government during agricultural disasters.

Most farm operators are not aware of the advantage of taking the insurance cover. Secondly, the small-scale farmers do not see the need to take insurance cover.

**Directorate of Food and Rural Infrastructures (DFRRI)**

DFRRI was established by decree 4 1986. The directorate among others was set up to identify areas ofhigh production potentials for the country's priority food and fiber refinement with the aim of achieving food sel-sufficiency. A large amount ofmoney went into agriculture through the DFRRI. Federal Government implemented the program inconjuction with the states and local government councils. The programme was scrapped and merged with the Federal Ministry of Agriculture, when it could not perform efficiently.

**The IFAD Cassava Multiplication Programme (CMP)**

The Cassava Multiplication Programme (CMP) was a project supported by International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD) between 1985 and 1999. The overall objective of the programme was to multiply and promote improved varieties of cassava to about 350,000 farmers, to increase productivity and income. The programme on the technical side achieved the planned objective with six varieties incorporated to varying degrees into farmers' cropping system.

**Roots and Tubers Expansion Programme**

This programme is supported by International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD). The overall objective of the RTEP is to increase smallholder's production of cassava, yam, potatoes, and cocoyam as well as their end products, and thus enhance national food self-sufficiency and improve rural household food security and income within the sourthern and middle belt states of Nigeria. The prograamme is an offshoot of the Cassava Multiplication Project.

The programme covered 25 states which fall in theroots and tubers growing belt, namely; Abia, Akwa-Ibom, Anambra, Bayelsa, Benue, Cross-River, Delta, Ebonyi, Edo, Ekiti, Enugu, Kaduna, Kogi, Kwara, Imo,Lagos,Nasarawa, Niger, Ogun, Ondo, Osun, Oyo, Plateau, Rive, Taraba and the Federal Capital Territory.

**National Agricultural Technology Support Fund (NATSF)**

This is a short-term facility introduced by the Federal government at the expiration of the Multi-State ADP. It was to serve as a residual fund pending the time an enduring funding arrangement would be put in place for all ADPs in the Country.

The NATSF is designed to provide assistance in the area of upgrading basis technology to extension services, adaptive research, women in agriculture, andmonitoring and evaluation. The facility also supports smaller discrete activities or pilot programmes designed to increase farmers productivity and production through acquisition, adaptation and dissemination of technology.

**National Fadama Development Project (NFDP)**

The general objective of the facility is to support the development of small-scale irrigation in the Fadama areas of the state through dissemination of appropriate technologies for water use, provision of fadama infrastructure, wells andpumps. The fund also covered support services such as training, planning monitoring and evaluation.

**National Advisory Committee for Agricultural Research (NACAR)**

This is a body established in 1992 by the Federal Ministry of Agriculture and Natural Resources (FMANR) to administer the NARIs-National Agricultural Research Institutes through the Department of Agricultural Science (DAS).

**National Agricultural Land Development Authority (NALDA)**

NALDA was established by Decree 92 of 7th May, 1992. The main objective of NALDA is the optimal use of the Nation's land and human resources to uplift the quality or rural life and to accelerate food production in Nigeria. The programme had been scrapped by the Obasanjo regime and merged with the Federministry of Agriculture.

## 4.0 Policy Analysis and Implications

This paper has reviewed the agricultural policies and programmes of Nigeria between 1960 and 2000, a period of about 40 years. The paper revealed useful lesson for the development and sustainability of the Nigerian agricultural sector. Some of the findings and their implication are discussed below:

i) The failure of Nigeria agricultural policy and programme like other macro or sectoral policies were due to bad implementation and/or mismanagement.

ii) In most instance political consideration tend to override economic consideration. Political instability in Nigeria ddid not also help agricultural sector: Most agricultural policies and programmes like NAFPP, OFN, and GRP were good programmes but failed becaused of frequent changes in government.

iii) As rightly observed by Idachaba (2000), most of the agricultural policies inNigeria are bankrupt of "policy varietal trail". The polcies were not subjected to requiste policy trails and options. The only exemptions was the ADPs which moved from the design and appraisal phase through the policy varietal phase of the enclave ADPs to the state wide ADPs in all states. The other was the NAFPP, which moved from pilot phase to a mass adoption phase. Furthermore, agricultural policies were not consultative and participatory in all

pahses of thepolicy process. All the stake holders were not involved.

iv) The present and previous agricultural policies gave local government less responsibilities and resources for agricultural activities particularly agricultural extension. They need to perform more of this role because they are the closest to the farmers. Closely related to this is the fact that some role of local, state and federal government in agriculture overlap or are completely taken over by the federal government.

v) A lot of policies that affect agriculture originate from outside the sector; they include monetary policy, fiscal policy, external trade policy and foreing exchang policy. All these polices have had positive and negative consequences for Nigeria's agricultural. (Idachaba 2000).

vi) Agricultural policies most often favoured unintended beneficiaries as aginst, intended beneficiaries e.g. fertilizer subsidy programme was supposed to have benefited the small scale farmers. Howerver, the uniteneded beneficiaries (the real beneficiary) wre ministers commissioners and public bureaucrats, fertilizer merchants and importers, fertilizer transporters, fertilizr middlemen and commission agents and foreign fertilizr supplier (see (Table 2) Idachaba, (2000).

vii) The agricultural pricing policy did not fully achieve the planned objectives. There were still instability of prices of inputs and output. Both farmers and consumers faced escalating prices in input and output markets.

viii) With rgards to agricultural trade policy, the agricultural sector recorded partial successes. In the post SAP period, there was an improvement in non-oil exports particularly cocoa exports.

ix) The agricultural land policy have failed, despite theland use decree, farmers and would be farmer still find it difficult to get land for agricultural activities.

x) Government efforts at providing infrastructures through DFRRI, ADP, rural infrastructure programme have failed to make the desired impact.

xi) An empirical evidence indicator) of the failure of past agricultural policies and programme is the share of agriculture in the GDP. This performance has been poor. Table 3 showed that the percentage share of agriculture in the GDP declined from 60.96 percent in 1964 to 18.00 percent in 1980. It keeps fluntuating to 38.97 percent in 1998. Similarly from Table 4 it can bee seen that eventhough the total value of agricultural export increased from N304 million in 1964 to N19,826 million in 1997, the share of agricultural export of the total value of export declined from 70.80 percent in1964 to 1.6 percent in 1997. Finally the average yield of millet, guinea corn, groundnut, beans, yams, cotton, cocoyam and manyfell in the 1990s relative to the 1980's. Only cassava recoreded an increase in average yield over the period (see Table 5).

## 5.0 Recommendation and Conclusion

### 5.1 Recommendation

Ministry of Agriculture needs to collaborate continuously with other ministries and parastatals, relevant research institute, university, private sector, civil organization in order to avoid duplication of efforts at streamlines policy and program for sustainable agricultural development. In addition, all the stakeholders must be involved in all phases of the next policy process through consultation and effective participation before anypolicyis implemented it must follow the due process of policy varietal trial as proposed by Idachaba (2000).

It is strongly recommended that theloclagovernment shouldbe given more responsibility and resources particurly for agricultural extension. There should also be proper devolusion of poer among the government clearly and distinctively.

Since macro-eceonomic policies have a significant impact on agricultural sector, any policy or programme to alleviate the problems within the sector must take into consideration the effect of the macro-economic policy environment on the new programme.

### 5.2 Conclusion

This paper has revealed that agricultural sectorhad gone through a lot of policies and programmes between year 1960 and 2000 without much to show for it. Some of the weakness and strength of thepolicy had been enumerated in this paer and some policy recommendations proffered. It is strongly suggested that government

should look into the recommendations for appropriate action.

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**APPENDIX**

**I. ABBREVIATIONS**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| ACGSF | - | Agricultural Credit Guarantee Scheme Fund. |
| ADP | - | Agricultural Development Project |
| ARMTI | - | Agricultural and Rural Management Training Institute |
| CBN | - | Central Bank of Nigeria |
| CMP | - | Cassava Multiplication Programme |
| COMMEX | - | Commodity Exchange |
| | - | Directorate of Food, Roads and Rural Infrastructures |
| FACU | - | Federal Agriculture and Co-ordinating Unit |
| FMA | - | Federal Ministry of Agriculture. |
| - | | Federal Ministry of Agriculture, Water Resources and Rural Development. |
| GDP | - | Gross Domestic Product |
| GRP | - | Green Revolution Programme |
| lADPs | - | Integrated Agricultural Development Projects |
| EFAD | - | International Fund for Agricultural Development. |
| IMF | - | International Monetary Fund. |
| NACB | - | Nigeria Agricultural and Cooperative Bank |
| NAFPP | - | National Accelerated Food Production Programme |
| NAIC | - | Nigeria Agricultural Insurance Company |
| NALDA | - | National Agricultural Land Development Authority (NALDA) |
| NCAM | - | National Center for Agricultural Mechanization |
| NDE | - | National Directorate of Employment. |
| OFN | - | Operation Feed the Nation |
| PEN | - | People's Bank of Nigeria |
| PCU | - | Project Co-ordinating Unit |
| RBDA | - | River Basin Development Authority |

SAP - Structural Adjustment Programme
THS - Tractor Hiring Services

**Table 1. Selected Agricultural Policies in the Second, Third and Fourth Nigerian National Development Plans.**

| Second Plan (1970-74) | Third Plan (1975-80) | Fourth Plan (1981-85) |
|---|---|---|
| notor powered implements and drawn implements.<br>sis on food crops. | ed government participation in od production and processing.<br>Bank Assisted Small-holders nine (WBASP)<br>ed Agricultural Development mme (IADP) | Farm services centers to nputs to small holders.<br>Establisliment of National tural Co-operative Management (NACMC).<br>Expansion of World Bank ADPs.<br>Direct government ment in food production reduced.<br>The River Basin and Rtiral oment Authority (RBRDA) ced. |
| l Seed Multiplication Centre ) National Accelerated Food ion Programme (NAFPP). | de-emphasized. National Grains ion Company, established.<br>al Root Crops Production Company hed. | ntures to be established by Nationa ops Production Company, Nat iona Production and National Beverages ny Lmited.<br>Cotton, Rubber and oil Palm tation scheme. |
| n Agricultural Credit Bank (NACB | tural Credit Guarantee Scheme ) | esource allocation of the NACB an tural G -till Cooporation. |
| | nd tax incentives.<br>eed minimum Price.<br>ced. Subsidies on inputs. | ubsidy to be continued.<br>equent review of guaranteed m prices |
| xchange rate Policy.<br>rate regulation. | xchange rate Policy.<br>rate regulation.<br>ublic investments.<br>cal deficits. | xchange rale Policy.<br>rate regulation.<br>ublic investmems.<br>cal deficits. Rising debt service. |

**Source: Garba (1999).**

**Table 2. Agricultural Policies in Nigeria**

| S/N | Policy | Intended Benficiaries | Unlimited Benficiaries |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | er Subsidies | Scale Farmers | Rent sekking Ministers nmissioners of Agriculture.<br>Rent seeking public rats<br>Fertilizer merchants ar rs<br>Fertilizer transporters<br>Commission agents<br>Foreign suppliers of rs |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | s: Many probes into fertilize<br>ion scandals over the years. |
| | dity price Support Scheme and<br>dity Boards | cale Farmers | erchants<br>d Buying Agents<br>rds as owners of strorage<br>rters of grain<br>eking public servant. |
| | asin Development Authorities (RBDAs | Small Scale Farme | tors/Builders of large dams.<br>tor/Supplier of irrigation<br>eking public servants. |
| | n Feed the Nation (OFN) | cale Farmers<br>er | nts and transports of<br>rs, livestock and Fisheries<br>eeds etc.<br>eking public servants. |
| | ng Board | cale Farmers | ector<br>aries of Projects funded in<br>icultural sector with<br>ng Board taxes (e.g. Cocoa<br>Wemabod Estate). |
| | Grain Reserves | cale farmers<br>ers | ctors/builders of strategic<br>serve silos<br>Merchants and middle men<br>eking political and<br>ratic leaders and operators |

**Source: Idachaba(2000).**

**Table 3. Contribution of Agriculture to Nigeria's Cross Domestic Products (GDP) at Current Factor Cost**

| Year | Total Export (~ Million) | ultural Export (~ Million | ultural as Percentage of Total |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1964 | 2,745.8 | 1,673.8 | 60.96 |
| 1965 | 2,894.4 | 1,676.4 | 57.92 |
| 1966 | 3,110.0 | 1,691.8 | 54.39 |
| 1967 | 3,374.8 | 1,855.0 | 54.97 |
| 1968 | 2,752.6 | 1,527.8 | 55.50 |
| 1969 | 2,656.2 | 1,145.2 | 53.28 |
| 1970 | 3,549.3 | 1,711.7 | 48.23 |
| 1971 | 5,281.1 | 2,576.4 | 48.49 |
| 1972 | 6,650.9 | 3,033.7 | 45.61 |
| 1973 | 7,187.5 | 3,092.7 | 43.03 |
| 1974 | 12,118.0 | 3,352.1 | 27.66 |
| 1975 | 16,462.8 | 3,943.0 | 23.95 |
| 1976 | 19,462.8 | 4,579.5 | 23.56 |
| 1977 | 23,826.0 | 4,898.3 | 20.56 |
| 1978 | 26,758.5 | 5,143.4 | 19.22 |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1979 | 27,370.2 | 5,389.1 | 19.69 |
| 1980 | 31,424.7 | 5,656.8 | 18.00 |
| 1981 | 50,456.63 | 13,580.32 | 26.9 |
| 1982 | 50,556.63 | 15,905.50 | 30.8 |
| 1983 | 56,709.77 | 18,837.19 | 33.2 |
| 1984 | 63,006.19 | 23,799.43 | 37.8 |
| 1985 | 71,368.10 | 26,625.21 | 37.3 |
| 1986 | 72,128.24 | 27,887.45 | 38.7 |
| 1987 | 106,883.20 | 39,204.22 | 36.8 |
| 1988 | 142,678.26 | 57,924.38 | 40.6 |
| 1989 | 193,659.28 | 68,754.57 | 35.5 |
| 1990 | 257,893.0 | 84,344.5 | 32.71 |
| 1991 | 320,247.3 | 97,463.3 | 30.3 |
| 1992 | 544,330.7 | 145,522.2 | 26.68 |
| 1993 | 691,600.0 | 231,832.1 | 33.52 |
| 1994 | 922,070.0 | 349,244.86 | 38.33 |
| 1995 | 1,960,690.0 | 629,306.83 | 31.59 |
| 1996 | 2,749,720.0 | 841,457.07 | 30.60 |
| 1997 | 2,834,998.69 | 953,549.37 | 33.65 |
| 1998 | 2,721,510.71 | 1,060,718.54 | 38.97 |

**Sources: FMA (1984); Titilola (1997); CBN Statistical Bulletin, various issues; FOS Annual Abstract of Statistical various issues.**

**Table 4. Share of Agriculture in Total Export Value**

| Year | Total Export (~ Million) | ıltural Export (~ Million | ultural as Percentage of Total |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1964 | 429.4 | 304.0 | 70.80 |
| 1965 | 536.6 | 327.4 | 61.01 |
| 1966 | 568.2 | 292.6 | 51.50 |
| 1967 | 540.0 | 264.6 | 49.00 |
| 1968 | 467.0 | 269.7 | 57.75 |
| 1969 | 683.0 | 278.2 | 40.73 |
| 1970 | 885.0 | 286.8 | 32.38 |
| 1971 | 1,280.8 | 265.5 | 20.73 |
| 1972 | 1,404.7 | 190.2 | 13.54 |
| 1973 | 2,278.4 | 288.7 | 12.67 |
| 1974 | 5,794.8 | 307.7 | 5.31 |
| 1975 | 4,922.5 | 256.5 | 5.21 |
| 1976 | 6,751.1 | 261.5 | 3.87 |
| 1977 | 7,630.7 | 437.7 | 5.74 |
| 1978 | 6,064.4 | 444.2 | 7.32 |
| 1979 | 10,836.8 | 498.5 | 4.60 |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1980 | 14,186.7 | 340.5 | 2.4 |
| 1981 | 11,023.3 | 178.4 | 1.6 |
| 1982 | 8,206.4 | 198.6 | 2.4 |
| 1983 | 7,502.5 | 259.0 | 3.4 |
| 1984 | 9,088.0 | 208.0 | 2.3 |
| 1985 | 11,720.8 | 192.1 | 1.6 |
| 1986 | 8,920.5 | 402.0 | 4.6 |
| 1987 | 30,360.6 | 1,588.5 | 5.2 |
| 1988 | 31,192.8 | 1,794.2 | 5.7 |
| 1989 | 57,971.2 | 1,833.0 | 3.2 |
| 1990 | 109,886.1 | 2,429.3 | 2.2 |
| 1991 | 121,533.7 | 3,425.6 | 2.8 |
| 1992 | 205,611.7 | 3,054.9 | 1.5 |
| 1993 | 218,801.1 | 3,522.3 | 1.6 |
| 1994 | 206,285.1 | 3,818.8 | 1.9 |
| 1995 | 952,883.1 | 15,512.0 | 1.6 |
| 1996 | 1,309,584 | 18,020.4 | 1.3 |
| 1997 | 1,241,662.7 | 19,826 | 1.6 |

**Sources: FMA (1984); Titilola (1997); CBN Statistical Bulletin, various issues**

**Table 5. Average Yield of Crops *in* Nigeria *1971-96* (kg).**

| | 1971/72- 1979/80 | 1980/81-1989/90 | 1990/91-1995/96 |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 791.11 | 899.10 | 858.33 |
| Corn | 756.56 | 1933.10 | 918.17 |
| ıut | 740.33 | 815.30 | 772.50 |
| | 284.67 | 469.20 | 435.00 |
| | 10056.11 | 1 1 250.50 | 9980.67 |
| | 796.00 | 1034.70 | 1032.17 |
| | 1015.00 | 1320.00 | 1191.00 |
| | 8595.1 1 | 12519.70. | 22779.83 |
| | 1694.30 | 2296.70 | 1351.33 |
| | 650.56 | 1335.60 | 1288.50 |
| d | 725.00 | 1262.00 | - |
| n | 4813.56 | 5694.00 | 4342.83 |

**Sources:** from Idachaba (2000)

17

# RELIGION AND SOCIETY IN NIGERIA SINCE INDEPENDENCE

**S. AWONIYI**

## INTRODUCTION

Nigerian society with an estimated population of 102.1 million people and over 250 ethnic groups has the largest population m suh-Saharan Africa.[1] Nigeria, a former British colony celebrated its independence in October 1, I960, but when the country was commemorating her independence, nobody ever visualized that Nigerian society would not remain politically united till today. This is consequent upon numerous religion, secular belief systems and cultural diversity. Nevertheless, Nigeria has been experiencing unity in diversity since independence which actually has a lot of negative effects on the socio-economic and political development of the country. These primordial attachments such as religion and ethnicity have even been so prominent in Nigeria to the extent that they have become determinant factors in government policies across the country. The concept, religion is a relative word or personal experiential phenomenon. More importantly, religion deals with the issue of ultimate Reality which is beyond complete human understanding. In view of this, scholars have found it difficult to agree on one common definition of religion, however some common features of religion should be identified. In religion, there are beliefs, supernatural beliefs, a supernatural life, secular world-views, the destiny of man, the meaning of history, sacredness, worship, and ethics.[2] Broadly speaking, there are three mam religions in Nigeria: they are, Christianity, Islam and Nigerian traditional religion. There is no denying the fact that there are other belief systems

such as Asian-oriented belief systems, secular ideologies or world-views in the country.[3] In support of this observation Boyle and Sheen have this to say:

*Atheism and free thought were first taught publicly in the late 19th century by Herbert Jumbo in Bonny. Educator Tai Solarin, who died in 1994 was a publicly declared, confirmed non-theist in the twentieth century. He separated religion from education and occupied himself solely with secular goals.*[4]

The fact is that everybody has a world-view guiding the life he is living. All the same, this type of worldview or secular ideology in relation to the above claim is in turn a religion to the person who embraces such a worldview. In consonance with this, Odumuyiwa in his own perspective affirms that:

*There is no society that is devoid of religion and religious activities'. Even in an atheistic society, it is presumed that such society recognizes the place of religion believing that there is no God is a kind of belief.*[5]

It implies that religion is an inescapable phenomenon in human society.

On the other hand, it is pertinent to stress that sociologists have agreed that the concept, society has to take account of people, relationships and institutions. Moreso, it also takes account of the importance of political organizations which distribute and exercise power within a recognized geographical entity. Hence, religion and society are related, this is because religion exists and it is practised in society, and every society has a religion as a moral sustainer with the view to building a well-ordered society. Scharfestablishes that, religion has a pervading, continuing and universal power in all societies.[6] It is in this sense that Durkheim once said that "the voice of man is the voice of God" (vox populi vox dei).

As it follows, despite the fact that Nigeria is a religiously pluralistic society, the fact holds that diverse religious adherents do apply their religions to their social, emotional, economic, intellectual and spiritual life. They also hold the strong conviction that religion is relevant in every unit of their life. However, the challenge is how to persuade religious adherents to eschew religious rivalry, intolerance and bloodshed, and foster peaceful co-existence and unity to build a virile and worthwhile society for the present and generations to come in Nigeria. It is obvious that religion is so important in the life of every man and society, why then are there elements of socio-ethical ills and moral decadence? Does any of these religions encourage misdemeanour in Nigeria? Then, how can a peaceful and harmonious society be built? These questions are part of the tasks ahead for discussion.

In this chapter, a modest and comprehensive introduction to religion and Nigerian society since independence is made. The chapter discusses the position of religion in human affairs. It further highlights the composition of religious beliefs and secular world-views in Nigeria; religion and state issues; manifestations of religious intolerance and their shortcomings. Finally, the chapter examines the way out of this dilemma. For this purpose, the chapter is divided into seven sect ions as follows:

i) Introduction: Nigeria, Religion and Society
ii) Religion in Human Affairs
iii) Composition of Religious beliefs in Nigeria
iv) Religion vis-a-vis State issues
v) Manifestations of Religious intolerance and their shortcomings
The way-out of this dilemma

**Religion in Human Affairs**

Religion is a universal phenomenon. It has been accepted as a legitimate and necessary activity of the human race from the very beginning of time.[7] Nabofa corroborates the assertion that:

*Human beings are inevitably involved in religion because deep down in the human nature there is an inherent urge in him which makes religion a matter of ultimate concern, ...Religion concerns itself witli the most sublime of humanaspirations.It is regarded as the source of morality and public order and the inner peace of the individual persons.*[8]

In a similar vein, Boyle and Sheen affirm that religion is a universal part of human life. It connotes that there is surely an innate "religiousness" in every person, and this grants him the intuitive idea that he has every right to the subjects religion.

However, it has been argued by some people that religion is a superstition, illusion and a devise by the privileged to cheat and subdue the underprivileged. Karl Marx, Engels, Lenin, Berbert Jumbo and Tai Solarin are in this category.[10] To put the point very starkly in terms of an example, in the defunct Soviet Union, the decree of 15th May, 1932 illustrates thus: "By May 1937, no church is to be left in the Soviet Union. God will therefore be expelled as a medieval relic from the territory of USSR".[11] No sooner the decree was in operation when the people started yearning and aspiring for spiritual consolation. Meanwhile, religious texts were even smuggled into the territory of USSR from the Western world. It is pertinent to ask a question that if religion is an illusion or simply the search for security, how is it that some people are prepared to die for the religion they practise? We have examples of Latimer, Ridley, Crammer who were martyred for their convictions. Savonarola in Florence, Italy in 14th century is another person who died for his faith.[12] As the biblical allusion states "Behold, he will slay me; I have no hope; yet I will defend my ways to his face. This will be my salvation, that a godless man shall not come before him."[13] A Muslim mystic once prayed that O God! If I worship thee for fear of hell, bum me in hell, if I worship Thee in hope of paradise, exclude me thence; but if I worship Thee for Thine own sake, withhold not from me Thine everlasting beauty[14]. Religion is a common heritage, and Nigerian society shares it with the rest of mankind.

The Russian Government may be anti-religion, but not the people. Nabofa reports that in Russia, there are many cult objects of religion. He goes further to say that during the second world war, many Russians gathered in Moscow and prayed for victory. To whom was the prayer directed? E. A Canham also reported that when the wasin Moscow, he visited the atheistic Moscow University. And that not very far from this university was an old Russian orthodox church, then Canham asked the old woman who was its caretaker whether the students from the University ever come to attend services. In response, the woman looked around to see if anybody was listening and she
then replied that during examination time, the place is always full. As reflected earlier that there have been those who claim that they cannot see any value in religion on the basis that they could live their lives happily without any guiding spirit.

Most of those who make this claim realize faintly that they have religion inherent in them. The fact that man repudiates God does not always mean that God gives man up completely, even though it always means that man is denying himself of the full benefit of his enabling grace. Irreligion may exult in some form of material success, but what about the cost of it that should be incurred in the restricted area of man's private life, where discomfort and venomous living combine in the work of the person's annihilation. It also happens in the wider area of national life. Koenig equally affirms that almost every one when age, disease, or sorrows strike him; inclines to think there is a God, or something very like Him[15]. Then, if man cannot see any value in religion, what real value is there in irreligion?

**Reflections on the Values of Religion In Society**

The values of religion can be summarised briefly as follows:

- Religion provides mankind with moral values by which to live.
- Religion gives food to meet spiritual hunger
- Religion answers some questions which nothing else can answer
- Religion provides people with a view of the World

- Religion inspires people to produce the best, the greatest, and the
- noblest that is in them.
- Religion pays attention to key moments in the life of the individual
- Religion celebrates life or regenerates the cosmos
- Religion shows people their limitations.
- Religion helps people to communicate in two directions. First, through social communication where people meet together for a common purpose otherwise refer to as horizontal direction of religious communication. Second, there is vertical communication between man and God, as well as between man[16] and the spirits beings.
- Religion provides prophetic function in society by contributing its own share to safeguard the use of power and economic resources. It calls for justice, fairness, respect and human dignity. It cries against corruption, indiscipline and crime.
- Religion provides norms, rules and prohibitions which are in accordance with the society's moral expectations.[17]

It has been established that religion, with its attendant values, is a widespread tradition which Nigerian society shares with the rest of human race, however the numerous religious beliefs and diverse ethnic groups have been the peculiar nature that characterize major set-backs in Nigeria be it religious, social, political or economical.

**Composition of Religious Beliefs In Nigeria**

Nigeria with 102.1 million people and 250 ethnic groups, accommodates three main religious traditions: Nigerian traditional religion, Christianity and Islam. In contemporary years, nearly all the foremost living religions of the world, especially in their new appearances have come to be displayed in the country. We shall examine here the composition of these religious groups, in particular their forms and arrangements in Nigerian society[18].

***The Christian Tradition***

Nigeria has numerous religious belief systems and bodies; new ones are claimed by the Christian Association of Nigeria to number up to five thousand[19]. Ohiora lists one thousand and eighteen churches that exist in Nigeria. Yet, the list is not exhaustive because there are others which are not contained in the list. Christianity is the second largest religious groups, though some would claim that indeed it constitutes the majority. Christianity consists of the Protestant, Roman Catholic and Spiritual - Evangelical - Pentecostal Churches which flourish all over Nigeria. The protestant denomination includes the Anglican Church, Baptist, Methodist and Christ Apostolic Chmvlies. the Jehovah's Witnesses, Seventh-Day Adventists, the Presbyterians, the Unitarian Brotherhood Church and the Salvation Army.[20]

The Urban Spiritual - Evangelical Churches include breakawaymovements from protestant churches and other indigenous Nigerian churches and new movements like Celestial Church of Christ, Evangelical Church of Yahweh, Church of the Lord, Cherubim and Seraphim Church among others. Hackett describes New Religious movements in Nigeria as an indigenously created religious organisation stemming from social and religious encounter, and selecting and combining local exogenous religious elements in diverse and dynanm ways. She further adds that this group of religion is newer in a chronological sense, because they emerge after the arrival of the mam missionary bodies[21]. Nevertheless, these new religious movcmenis trace their origins to a religious experience and are sustained by a religious interpretation of reality. Examples of some of the Urban based new movements are Grail Message, Lodge, Krishna consciousness, Guru Maharaji and Rosicrucian groups.

***The Islamic Tradition***

Islam consists of a wide variety of groups and movements in Nigeria. One of the notable organizations is the Jama'tu Nasril Islam (society for the support of Islam) which was established in 1961 by the premier of the Northern region, Sardauna. Another coordinating body closely connected with the above is the Supreme Council for Islamic Affairs established in 1973. This council serves as an umbrella for the welfare of all Muslims under the

chairmanship of Sultan of Sokoto, the supreme head of the Nigerian Muslims. Equally important to note, there are many other societies with less national appeal[22].

More importantly, one of the unique Islamic sects in the country is the tariqa, the Sufi brotherhoods notably the Qadiriyya and the Tijaniyya Tariqa. Another organisation of contemporary importance is the Yan Izala. It was formed in 1979 in Jos by Malam Ismaila Idris. Furthermore, the Ahmadiyya movement which was founded by Mirza Gnulam Ahmad in India also has a presence in Nigeria. It was introduced to Nigeria in 1916 and exists till today[23].

In addition, there are other puritanical sects such as Bamidele Movement, Zumratu I'Mu'minin [the gathering of the faithful] and Lanasc Movements[24].

***Nigerian Traditional Religion***

Traditional religion is another major religion in the country. Traditional religions comprised of the indigenous traditional beliefs and practices of the various ethnic groups. The doctrines and world-views are not written down but are implicit in myths, rituals, proverbs, songs and symbols. Ancestors are honoured in recognition of their on-going relationship with the living. Also, life transition rituals accompany birth, puberty, marriages and death. So, there are calendrical rituals celebrating social institutions established in primordial time[25].

In recent limes, there has been a revival of traditional movements and cult groups in Nigeria. At the Obafemi Awolowo University, Ile-Ife the Orile Orisa (the Abode of the Orisa) cult and shrine for the worship of Yoruba deities was created. The seventh international congress of Orisa, Tradition and Culture was held in the year 2001 at Oduduwa Hall, Obafemi Awolowo University, He Ife[26].

In 1963, the Aruosa Cult or Edo National Church, a modernized version of Bini neo-traditional religion, merged with the National Church of Nigeria to form Godianism with the view to working towards the universalisation and proselytisation of the "God of Africa". The movement rejects all "alien" religious intermediaries such as Jesus Christ or Prophet Muhammed. The movement was effective until the 1970s in promoting the unity of Nigerian society, but later it was affected by internal disagreements and now it operates within a few branches around Aba and Onitsha.

In view of the fact that there are numerous religious beliefs in Nigeria, it should be identified here that the common persuasion of these religions are ethics, morals and values which they all teach to their various adherents. It is averred that various religions are not in conflict. However, conflicts arise when adherents of various religions in Nigerian society decide to go to their different ways and even restlessly search for the extermination of not just the other religions but also their adherents.

**Religion and State Issues In Nigeria**

*One of the most remarkable achievements of the 19th century reformation and; in particular, the second Vatican council was its declaration on religious freedom (Digitatis Humanae) which emphasized the rights of man and of communities to social and civil freedom in religious matters.*[28]

In the Nigerian context, the setting up of the Constitution Drafting Committee [CDC] in 1976 was part of the efforts of the Murtala regime to pursue the programme of the return to civil rule by the military administration. A draft constitution was ready on the 20th August, 1976 and (he government threw it for debates and comments around (he country. Then, at this juncture, the Sharia debate at the Constituent Assembly [CA] in 1977/78 marked an important landmark in ushering religion into Nigerian politics till today-[29]. It was evident that the debate on Sharia continued to dominate the political landscape beyond the political programme of 1979.

In consonance with the second Vatican council Declaration on religious freedom, the Nigeria's 1979 and the suspended 1989 constitutions enshrined the protection of freedom of thought, conscience and religion thus:

a. Prohibition of a slate religion, that is, a particular religion should not be taken as an official religion in the country;
b. Everyone has the freedom to practice their religion according to their conviction;
c. While leaching of religion is allowed in schools, there should be no compulsion in matters of religious education.[30]

However, the secular formulation of the religion vis-a-vis state relationship has been the subject of controversy particularly between Christians and Muslims. While Christians interprete the constitution to mean that Nigeria is a secular state and consider this appropriate given the country's heterogeneity. Muslims see church/state separation as Judaeo-Christian Western doctrine. The Grand Khadi of Abuja declared in 1994 that church/state separation is not acceptable in Islam, and that one provision of the constitution does not make Nigeria a secular state, the Muslims often refer to the preamble to the constitution winch invokes the guiding image of a harmonious state "under God". Also, the Muslims regard common law as laden with Christian ideals and doctrines. They further argue that Sunday is a work-free day of rest in contrast to Muslim Friday prayer day. Again, they submit that the cross is used as a symbol of medical and health services; why not the Islamic crescent?[31]

On other hand, the Christians in their turn, accuse the government of supporting the political and economic power of the Muslims. The former president Ibrahim Babangida, in 1986 dragged Nigeria into the organization of Islamic Conference (OIC). This eventually led to tension between Christian and Muslims[32]. Recently, the report has it that even Organisation of Islamic Conference (OIC) budgets a whopping sum ol money to aid any Muslim candidate aspiring for the posl of presidency to win election in the year 2003". Against this background, Oshiomhole submits that clamouring for religious and ethnic president and other political leaders in the country is dangerous and a threat to the socio-economic and political survival of Nigeria. Instead, he posits that the challenges should be how to make every Nigerian benefit from the presidency[34]. The major reason for this is that the Government usually involves itself unduely in religious issues.

In any pluralistic society as ours, government should steer clear of any policy that gives semblance of support for any religion. In Nigeria today, Islam and Christianity not only play prominent roles in the nation's political, social, cultural and economic life but they also received recognition and assistance from the state to the exclusion of the Nigerian traditional religion. In Abuja the Federal Capital territory only Christians and Muslims were allocated land and funds to build a national Mosque and national Cathedral. Besides, government plays an important role in organizing pilgrims welfare boards. The state governments grant pilgrims concessional fares and favourable foreign exchange rates when they travel to Jerusalem and Mecca[35]. A cursory survey in the previous section of this chapter reveals the variety of diverse religious traditions and organizations in the country. It implies that the government should be neutral in this circumstance to enable stability and progress.

**Manifestations of Religious Intolerance and their Shortcomings**

History is an important element of society. It is the store-house of the past and current social conditions, circumstances, events, causal factors and effects on the people, relationships, institutions and other aspects of society in relation to civilization, progress as well as well-being of society. Society also learns from a historical experience of how it met successes and failures in the course of its history[36]. This section therefore shed light on manifestations of religious intolerance and their consequences in order to re-orientate Nigerian society.

Religious intolerance can be explained as a state or condition when someone or group of people is not willing to endure and respect or honour difference of beliefs, ideologies or world-view particularly in a religiously pluralistic society. Thesaurus also gives the meaning of religious intolerance as being, synonymous to religious bigotry, narrow-mindedness, parochialism, fanaticism, chauvinism, insularism, onc-sidcdness amoim others [37]. Religious intolerance in Nigeria has manifested through incessant civil unrest and internal armed conflicts in Nigeria. The observation of Boyle and Sheen in this respect may be worthy of note. According to them,

*Intolerance of religion and belief in Nigeria has manifested itself through sporadic civil unrest and some internal armed conflict. In places where Christian and Muslim religious revivalisms are in geographic proximity, the results can be explosive. Between 8,000-10,000Nigerians died in religious violence between 1980 and 1987*[38].

**RELIGIONS IN NIGERIA**

**African Traditional Religion**

A Roman writer Cicero held that the word religion came from a root "leg" meaning "to take up, gather, count or Observe" (i.e to observe the signs of Divine Communication). Servius on the other hand, held that it came from another root "lig" "to bind", so that "religio" meant "a relationship" (i.e a commission between the human and super-Human). The word religion came to embrace both meanings either interchangeably or in combination. Religion came to mean the scrupulous observation of omens and performance of rituals and also a fixed relationship between the human self and some non human entity, the sacred, the supernatural, the self-Existent, the Absolute, or simply "God"

Inspite of the size, complexity of culture and system of beliefs in Africa, a careful look, through actual observation and comparative discussions, shows that there is a common factor which the coined word negritude_ will express aptly. There is common Africanness about the total culture and religious believes and practices of Africa. This common factor may be due either to the fact of diffusion or to the fact that most Africans share common origin with regard to race and customs and religious practices. With regard to the concept of God, there is a common thread, running throughout the continent. It is in fact this one factor of the concept, with practical reference to the character of Deity which makes it possible to speak of a religion of Africa. There is for example the name of God which appears in various forms in several places according to the native tongue of each locality. Olorun by the Yoruba, Chukwu by the Ibo, Soko by the Nupe and Obangiji by the Hausas,Tamuno, Osanobua etc.

African Traditional Religion has however, in the past, been variously described by foreign observers as Paganism, Heathenism; Idolatry, Fetishism or Animism. All these are borne out of racial prejudice and personal, ethnic or political egocentricity, A clear etymological connotation of these words shows that they are being applied to African belief system in appropriately.

There are in reality five component elements that go into the making of African traditional religion. These are belief in God, belief in divinities, belief in spirit, belief in the ancestors and the practice of magic and medicine, each with its own consequent attendant cult.

In these religious systems, the idea of a God is fundamental. the believe in the existence of a supreme, primordial being, the lord of the universe, which is his work. Among the Yoruba and the Edo, where society is highly organized and carefully graded on a hierarchical bases, Deity is conceived as supreme king of a theocratic world, with heavenly ministers appointed over each department of his realm. Among the Igbo, on the other hand, the divine ministerial system is not as elaborate, because society is not as homogenous as among the Yoruba. In each locality, the concept of God usually takes its emphasis and complexion from sociological stricture and climate.

The belief in divinity is entrenched in Nigerian belief system. The belief in a supreme being but the persistence of the worship of other deities at the same time can be described as implicit monotheism. The divinities were not created by God but were brought into being or that they came into being in the nature of things with regard to the divine ordering of the universe. The divinity however have no absolute existence they are in being only in consequence of the being of Deity (God). Their Powers and authorities are meaningless apart from him.

These are the basic tents of African Traditional Religion with which the two foreign monotheistic religions (Christianity and Islam), came in contact and have succeeded in eroding its influence acceptance in Nigeria over the years

We would consider these two world religions to see how they came to be embraced by a greater majority of

Nigerians.

## ADVENT OF ISLAMIC IN NIGERIA

For a clear understanding of Islamic influence on the development of Nigeria, its relevant to discuss the various stages of establishment in various parts of the federation. The most prominent areas where Islamic influence could be recognized easily include Hausa land, Kanem-Bornu and Yoruba land incidentally, these are the same areas where Islamic Culture has had its longest history in the country and we shall discuss these one by one.

## HAUSA LAND

Islamic was said to have been introduced to Hausa landin the 2nd half of the 14th century by Wangarawa merchants, though it seems likely that something of Islam would have been known before this time through contacts with Bornu whose tradition of Islam goes back some 3 centuries prior to this. The Kano Chronicle, an anonymous late 19th century compilation based largely on oral tradition claim that Islam was introduced to Kano in the reign of "Ali Yaji (1349 0 85). He built mosque where prayers were said. However this did not lead to widespread growth of Islam as Yaji's successor Kanajeje (1390-1410) was a pagan. In the reign of Yaqub (1452-63) there was migration of Fulani who brought books of Islamic law and theology and Arabic grammar. His successor Mohammed Runfa (1463-99) began to pursue more active Islam polices, including the building of mosques and the observance of festivals and sought advice from Muslim Scholars. It was at this time that the sacred tree of Kano was cut and a mosque built in its place. Scholars from Timbuktu were coming in good member from this time. Islam among the Hausa was however confined to the urban centres and sometime the courts of the rulers. The situation at the end of the 18th century reveals that Islam evidently was practiced mostly by the head of the Habes who were mixing the religion with traditional practices. It was a clash between this group and the nomadic Fulani who remained orthodox in their practices that led to the outbreak of the 19th Century Jihad of Usman Dan Fodio.

## KANEM-BORNU

The name of Kanem was known to the Arab geographers from as early as the 9th cent. It was however around the end of the 11th cent that we first hear of a muslim ruler, Ume Jilmi who reigned (1085-97). An Arab source names Mohammed (Dunama Dabalemi who rulded in the mid 13th century as the first Muslim ruler. This probably mean that the rulers of the two preceding centuries were nominal muslims. Dunama Dabalemi (1221-1259) was the first mai to make a break with local religious cult.

On the international plane, although we know of private scholarly contacts with Morocco from the late 12th century the first official contacts were made with North Africain in 1257 whenan ambassador was sent to the Hafsid prince Al-Mustansir in Tunis. Fifteen years earlier, the number of Kanem students going to Cairo for higher studies had become sufficiently great to warrant the establishment of a special college and hostel for them in a suburb of that city, the Madrasat Ibn Rashiq. The most celebrated Bornu ruler was Mai Idris Alooma (1570-1602). He was a zealous Muslim, it was from his reign that the real Islamisation of Bornu began.

## ISLAM INYORUBALAND

It is still a subject of controversy among scholars as to when Islam came to Yoruba land. Adam Abdullah has suggested that Islam was first known in Yoruba land during the reign of Mansa Musa of Mali (1337). He argued that Islam was introduced by Mali traders and Maillian ambassadors who used to visit old Oyo, hence the religion was known as *Imale.* Ahmad Baba of Timbuktu (1610) is reported to have mentioned the presence of Islam in Yofubaland in his work. Gbadamosi reported the incident of one *Baba Kewu,* a Muslim Mallam from Nupeland, who challenged the action of Alaafin Ajiboyede (1562-1570) for killing some people on account of his son's death. The presence of Baba Kewu in Oyo indicates the presence of Islam in the town at the time. However by 18th century, Islam had become widly accepted in Yorubaland. Musque had sprung up in different parts of Yoruba country. Oyo 1550; Ketu 1760, Iseyin 1770 Lagas 1775. The Jihad of Usman Dan Fidio which led to the Islamization of llorin however, accelerated the influx of Muslim from the north. Also important was

the influx of liberated slaves into Lagos and Badagry after the abolition of Slave Trade. Most of the returnees included Muslim who were skilled and talented artisans. By 1930, the Muslim community in Badagry was numerically strong enough to organize an impressive Id-al -fitri celebration witness by European explorers.

**Impact of Islamic**

Traditional customs and institutions of Nigeria have been displaced by Islamic culture and institutions. Arabic language of the quran has become the lingua franca. Islamic schools and universities have been established all over the country.

Sharia (Islamic laws) have been adopted as the basis of governance in some states of the Federation. For marriage, inheritance property and day to day life are dictated by Islamic culture in a great proportion of the northern States of Nigeria.

Muslim festivals have become national holidays like Idel Kabir, Fitri and Mouloud. Islamic in Nigeria has become an integrative force making it possible for the welding together of diverse tribes into homogenous state called Sokoto caliphate.

Islam developed in Muslim a cosmopolitan attitudes and the feeling of sense of brotherhood of all Muslim irrespective of race.

**THE COMING OF CHRISTIANITY TO NIGERIA**

The earliest attempt by Europeans to establish Christianity in Nigeria was in the 16$^{th}$ century when the Portuguese gained inroads into Benin Kingdom and Warri. This early efforts were however, concentrated on the rulers. Consequently the religion was however, limited to the royal courts and it fortunes varied with the vagaries of royal patronage.

However, interest in Christian evangelization of Africa was re-kindled by the evangelical revival of the late 18$^{th}$ century championed by John Wesley. From the beginning Christian missions had three-pronged mission of spreading the three C's: Christianity, Commerce and Civilization (Western). This complementary blend of ideals was epitomized by John Wesley, the leading evangelical and Thdnias Powell Buxton, the famous anti-slavery activist who rationalized opposition to slavery from religious andcommercial perspective. This was expressed in the famous concept of the "Bible and the plough". This was the context within which Christian missions deployed men and material to the Nigerian area from the 1840s. It also inform their close collaboration with anti-slavery activist in the Niger expeditions of 1841 - 1854.

After the abortive attempts in the past, Christianity was at last successfully introduced to Nigeria at the early years of the 1840s. In 1842, the first batch of Christian missionaries landed at Badagry, on their way to Abeokuta. They came in the wake of the liberated slaves returning to Nigeria.

Thomas Fowell Buxton and others advocated that the Africans be returned to their country where they might all be engaged in agricultural development and evangelization. The combined introduction of the Bible and the plough would usher in light and civilization into the heart of the African continent. However because of the cold reception they received from Badagry they moved to Abeokuta. Missionaries were admitted into Abeokuta in 1846 because thevjvanied their help in the political maneuvres against Lagos and other hostile neighbours.

The missionary efforts of Townsend, Crowther and Gollmer at Abokuta yielded some early fruits. Schools and churches were built and on February 5, 1845 the first converts were baptized.

The return of the emigrants also resulted in the introduction of Christianity into other Yoruba towns such as Lagos. Ibadan. Ijaiye, and some Christian presence in towns and villages as far away as Ede, Iragbiji and llorin. From these centres, Christianity filtered to other towns in Yorubaland in the second half of the 19th century.

In the southeastern area it was the Scottish missionaries who pioneered Christian evangelization. Hope Waddell arrived Calabar in1846, settled in Duke town and Creek town. The pace of development was slow and it was only in 1853 that the first baptism was conducted. In 1857 they builta church. The group of Christian converts swelled when the emigrants began to arrive in Calabar settlings mainly on mission land at Duke town. Most of them were Anglican and Methodist. The Anglican began work in the Niger frst at Abo and more successfully at Onitsha in 1857, Brass 1861 and Bonny 1964.

In the second half of the 19th century the concern of Christian missionaries was how to evangelize the Muslim area of Nigeria. The main pioneer of this enterprise was Reverend Samuel Ajayi Crowther. His interest was kindled in Hausaland evangelization by the Niger Expeditions of 1841 and 1854. On becoming the head of the Nigger Mission founded in 1857, he persuaded the Emir of Bida to allow him carry out missionary activities in Nupe Kingdom and two mission stations were established in Kipoo hill in 1875 and at Shonga in 1876 on the caravan routes to Sokoto and Salaga. The emir gave a son to Crowther to educate and later allowed him to establish a mission at his capital Bida. But this approach failed to win converts.

The high water mark of missionary work was when in July 1910 a conference of all missions in the northern states was held. This was the United Missionary Conference with over 17 missionaries representing 7 bodies including CMS, S.I.M, C.U.M.P and the Mennonite Brethren in Christ. They gathered to discuss common problems and decided on areas of cooperation and common action. The Christian achievements in terms of the number of converts, however was small relative to the exertions of the missionaries energy. Up till 1910 there were only 45 churches and 650 pupils in mission schools in the northern parts of Nigeria. In contrast, there were 116 churches in Ijebu- Ode district alone and over 4000 children in mission schools in Abeokuta.

**IMPACT OF CHRISTIANITY**

This is base on the parts they played consciouly or unconsciously in the rise of nationalism in Nigeria.

The spread of western education creased middle class of Nigerian intellectuals. They believe that good Christians must be like European. In order to entrench Christianity, African were made to forsake their culture such as polygamy, wearing of the native dress, bearing African names. The revolt against this led to African nationalism.

Western Education produced new class of leaders and leader of nationalist movement and consequent independence. Western education and Christianity led to disintegration of indigenous Africa Society and traditional values.

The revolt against European led to the breaks away of some missions and founding of African Churches (Fissiparous tendency), which adopted a more lenient and understanding attitude towards African Culture Christian mission were useful in providing social services. Apart from schools they built hospitals and dispensary.

Christianity demonized and destroyed African culture like polygamy and Mode of dressing. This is responsible for the slow growth of the religion in Africa. Christianity gave western education which detribalized Nigerian.

Many Nigerian become Europeanized in mode of dressing and attitude to life. The native language and

consequently culture was being eroded.

Christianity provided the intellectual leadership for nationalist movement that led to agitation for and attainment of independence.